A THESIS ON BLACK MIRROR



THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

Black Mirror, *Artificial Eternity, and the Pelagian Machine*

Toward a Catoptric Eschatology of the Platform Age

MMXXVI

For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

videmus nunc per speculum in aenigmate

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FRONT MATTER

Abstract

This thesis argues that Charlie Brooker's *Black Mirror* (Channel 4, 2011–2014; Netflix, 2016–) has been systematically misread as a cautionary satire of technology, and that its coherence as a body of work becomes legible only when it is reconstructed as a *secular eschatology*: a dispersed, anthologised re-staging of the Four Last Things — death, judgement, heaven and hell — fabricated from the materials of platform capitalism. Taking as its corpus the thirty-four works released between December 2011 and April 2025 (Series One to Seven, the 2014 special "White Christmas", and the interactive film *Bandersnatch*), the study combines media archaeology, comparative mythography, philosophical genealogy and close formal analysis in order to advance five interlocking propositions.

First, a *catoptric law*: the technologies of the series are not agents but *specula*, devices that return pre-existing human drives at scale and in duration; their characteristic operation is not distortion but *eternalisation*, the conversion of finite acts into infinite consequence. Second, the decisive novum of the corpus is therefore not artificial intelligence but *artificial eternity* — the technical manufacture of durations (total recall, dilated subjective time, the permanent record, the perpetual subscription) that were formerly the monopoly of theology. Third, the economic theology of these worlds is *Pelagian*: salvation is earned, scored, ranked and purchased, so that the platform functions as what Walter Benjamin called a cult that creates guilt rather than atonement, and what is structurally absent from nearly every episode is grace. Fourth, the anthology's signature device, the twist, performs a *transferred anagnorisis* in which tragic recognition migrates from protagonist to spectator, so that each episode terminates by converting the screen-as-window back into the screen-as-mirror — the closing black frame in which the viewer's own face appears. Fifth, the rare redemptive moments of the corpus share a grammar of the gratuitous, the forgetful, the finite and the refused, from which the thesis derives a normative counter-position, *Lethean grace*: an ethics of the off-state that treats forgetting, forgiveness and ending as goods to be designed for rather than defects to be engineered away.

To substantiate these claims the thesis constructs a *decalogue of mirrors* — from the obsidian mirror of the Mexica deity Tezcatlipoca and John Dee's scrying stone to the Claude glass of the picturesque tourist, the Pauline *speculum in aenigmate*, Nicholas of Cusa's omnivoyant icon, Perseus's shield, Narcissus's pool, Alberti's window, Leibniz's windowless monad and Valle-Inclán's deforming mirrors — and situates Brooker within a satirical and speculative lineage running through Swift, Forster, Serling, Kneale, Dick, Ballard and Chris Morris. Episode clusters are read against Plato, Augustine, Locke, Leibniz, Adam Smith, Kant, Hegel, Kierkegaard, Nietzsche,

Freud, Benjamin, Heidegger, Arendt, Günther Anders, Levinas, Debord, Foucault, Girard, Baudrillard, Deleuze, Derrida, Parfit, Stiegler, Han and Zuboff, and compared with Ovid, Aeschylus, Sophocles, Dante, Kafka, Borges, Lem, Le Guin, Ellison, Ishiguro and Chiang. A *Corinthian key* — the convergence of the series' title, its degraded theological virtues and its resurrected bodies upon the thirteenth and fifteenth chapters of Paul's First Letter to the Corinthians — is advanced not as a claim about authorial intention but as an *intentio operis* that renders the corpus systematically legible.

The thesis concludes that *Black Mirror*'s deepest horror is neither surveillance nor machine autonomy but the abolition of finitude, and that its most radical image is the one with which every episode ends: a screen that has finally been permitted to go dark.

CORPUS, CONVENTIONS, TERMINOLOGY

Prefatory Note

The corpus is closed at thirty-four works, released between 4 December 2011 and 10 April 2025; an eighth series was confirmed in January 2026 and entered production in the summer of 2026 with no announced release date (Variety, 25 August 2026), and is accordingly excluded. The 2025 browser-and-mobile game *Thronglets*, released as a paratext to "Plaything", is treated as an extra-diegetic extension of the corpus rather than a member of it.

Index of the Corpus

WORK	RELEASE	PRINCIPAL TREATMENT
"The National Anthem"	Series 1, 2011	Ch. 6
"Fifteen Million Merits"	Series 1, 2011	Ch. 3; Ch. 8
"The Entire History of You"	Series 1, 2011	Ch. 4
"Be Right Back"	Series 2, 2013	Ch. 4; Ch. 5
"White Bear"	Series 2, 2013	Ch. 4; Ch. 6
"The Waldo Moment"	Series 2, 2013	Ch. 6
"White Christmas"	Special, 2014	Ch. 5; Ch. 8
"Nosedive"	Series 3, 2016	Ch. 3
"Playtest"	Series 3, 2016	Ch. 7
"Shut Up and Dance"	Series 3, 2016	Ch. 6
"San Junipero"	Series 3, 2016	Ch. 5; Ch. 8; Ch. 9
"Men Against Fire"	Series 3, 2016	Ch. 7
"Hated in the Nation"	Series 3, 2016	Ch. 6
"USS Callister"	Series 4, 2017	Ch. 5
"Arkangel"	Series 4, 2017	Ch. 3
"Crocodile"	Series 4, 2017	Ch. 4
"Hang the DJ"	Series 4, 2017	Ch. 3; Ch. 5
"Metalhead"	Series 4, 2017	Ch. 7
"Black Museum"	Series 4, 2017	Ch. 4; Ch. 8

WORK	RELEASE	PRINCIPAL TREATMENT
Bandersnatch	Interactive film, 2018	Ch. 7
“Striking Vipers”	Series 5, 2019	Ch. 5
“Smithereens”	Series 5, 2019	Ch. 6
“Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too”	Series 5, 2019	Ch. 5
“Joan Is Awful”	Series 6, 2023	Ch. 5
“Loch Henry”	Series 6, 2023	Ch. 6
“Beyond the Sea”	Series 6, 2023	Ch. 5
“Mazey Day”	Series 6, 2023	Ch. 6
“Demon 79”	Series 6, 2023	Ch. 6
“Common People”	Series 7, 2025	Ch. 3
“Bête Noire”	Series 7, 2025	Ch. 6
“Hotel Reverie”	Series 7, 2025	Ch. 5
“Plaything”	Series 7, 2025	Ch. 5; Ch. 7
“Eulogy”	Series 7, 2025	Ch. 4
“USS Callister: Into Infinity”	Series 7, 2025	Ch. 5

Conventions

Citation follows an author–date system; classical, scriptural and early-modern texts are cited by canonical locator (Stephanus pagination, book and chapter, section number) rather than by edition, so that the argument may be checked against any reputable translation. Episode titles appear in quotation marks; series, films, novels and treatises in italics. Dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed, both as a matter of scholarly economy and because the argument concerns structures rather than lines. Plot information is disclosed without warning wherever the analysis requires it.

Two hermeneutic rules govern the whole. First, no claim is made about Brooker’s intentions except where he has stated them publicly; the many convergences this thesis identifies between the corpus and its mythic, theological and philosophical antecedents are presented under Umberto Eco’s category of the *intentio operis* — the intention of the work as a coherent semiotic strategy — rather than the *intentio auctoris* (Eco 1990). Second, a convergence is admitted as evidence only when it is *systematic* (recurring across several episodes) or *structural* (organising an episode’s form rather than ornamenting its surface). Isolated resemblances are flagged as such.

Glossary of Coined Terms

TERM	DEFINITION	PRINCIPAL LOCUS
Obsidian speculum	The screen understood as a fourfold device that reflects, judges, divines and obscures	Ch. 1
Catoptric law	The principle that the corpus's technologies return existing drives at scale and in duration rather than originating new ones	Intro.; Ch. 1
Artificial eternity	The technical production of unending durations — total recall, dilated subjective time, the permanent record, the perpetual subscription	Ch. 4; Ch. 5
Pelagian Machine	The platform as a soteriology of merit: salvation earned, scored and purchased, with grace structurally excluded	Ch. 3
Wraith virtues	The degradation of the theological triad (faith, hope, charity) into attention, aspiration and performative benevolence	Ch. 3; Ch. 8
Echo's curse	The recurrent dispossession of a person's speech, who may only repeat what a system has scripted	Ch. 4; Ch. 5
Computational Omelas	The production of a good for some at the cost of suffering minds hidden inside the computation	Ch. 5
Counter-Oresteia	The reversion of justice from the court to the Furies under conditions of networked outrage	Ch. 6
Transferred anagnorisis	The migration of tragic recognition from protagonist to spectator	Intro.; Ch. 6; Ch. 7
A Mirror for Users	The anthology as a democratised *de casibus* genre, recounting the falls of ordinary persons	Ch. 2
Corinthian key	The convergence of the corpus's title, virtues and resurrected bodies upon 1 Corinthians 13 and 15	Ch. 8
Lethean grace	The normative counter-position: forgetting, forgiveness and ending as goods to be designed for	Ch. 9

THE CORPUS · 34 WORKS · 2011–2025

2011 SERIES 1

- The National Anthem — 6
- Fifteen Million Merits — 3, 8
- The Entire History of You — 4

2013 SERIES 2

- Be Right Back — 4, 5
- White Bear — 4, 6
- The Waldo Moment — 6

2014 SPECIAL

- White Christmas — 5, 8

2016 SERIES 3

- Nosedive — 3
- Playtest — 7
- Shut Up and Dance — 6
- San Junipero — 5, 8, 9
- Men Against Fire — 7
- Hated in the Nation — 6

2017 SERIES 4

- USS Callister — 5
- Arkangel — 3
- Crocodile — 4
- Hang the DJ — 3, 5
- Metalhead — 7
- Black Museum — 4, 8

2018 INTERACTIVE FILM

- Bandersnatch — 7

2019 SERIES 5

- Striking Vipers — 5
- Smithereens — 6
- Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too — 5

2023 SERIES 6

- Joan Is Awful — 5
- Loch Henry — 6
- Beyond the Sea — 5
- Mazey Day — 6
- Demon 79 — 6

2025 SERIES 7

- Common People — 3
- Bête Noire — 6
- Hotel Reverie — 5
- Plaything — 5, 7
- Eulogy — 4
- USS Callister: Into Infinity — 5

FIG. 1 · THE CORPUS, 2011–2025

Thirty-four works in order of release, December 2011 to April 2025. The numbers mark each work's principal chapters in this study.

INTRODUCTION



Through a Glass, Darkly

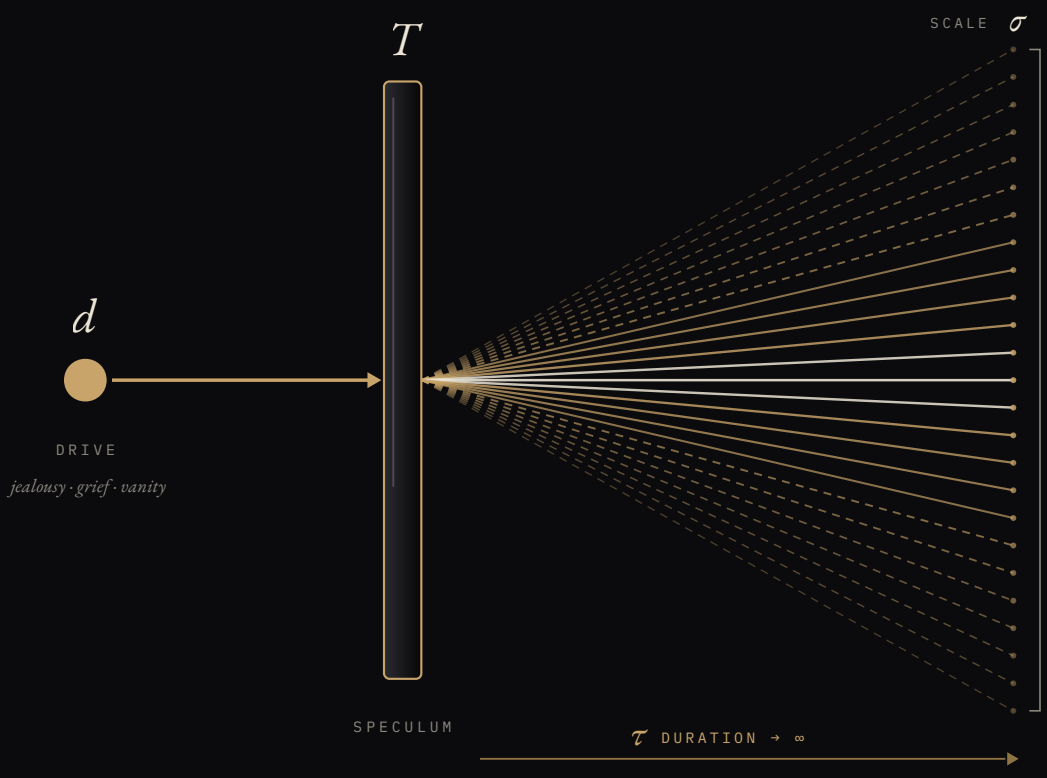


FIG. 2 · THE CATOPTRIC LAW

A pre-existing drive d meets the speculum T and returns multiplied by scale σ and duration τ; the corpus's catastrophes arise as τ approaches its limit. Introduction, Proposition 1.

I.1

The Insufficiency of the Cautionary Reading

Few television series suffer the peculiar fate of becoming an adjective. Within a decade of its first broadcast, *Black Mirror* had passed from title to epithet: the vernacular verdict that a new device, policy or scandal is "very *Black Mirror*" now performs in ordinary speech the classificatory labour once reserved for "Kafkaesque", "Orwellian" and "Ballardian". The adjective is revealing in what it presupposes. It designates a situation in which a technology appears to have outrun the moral competence of its users, and it implies that the series is a repository of warnings — a speculative early-warning system whose value is measured by the frequency with which reality subsequently resembles it. The journalistic genre of the retrospective prophecy, in which episodes are credited with having "predicted" social credit systems, griefbots, deepfaked performers or subscription medicine, is the critical corollary of that presupposition.

This thesis contends that the cautionary reading — dominant in journalism, in pedagogy and in a substantial part of the scholarly literature — is not false but insufficient, and insufficient in three determinate respects.

The first insufficiency is *causal*. The cautionary reading attributes agency to the technology and treats the human subject as its patient. Yet across the corpus the technological novum almost never initiates the moral catastrophe; it inherits one. Liam's jealousy precedes the replay that confirms it ("The Entire History of You"); Victoria's complicity in a child's murder precedes the Justice Park that punishes it ("White Bear"); Martha's bereavement precedes the replica that prolongs it ("Be Right Back"); Robert Daly's humiliation in the office precedes his tyranny in the simulation ("USS Callister"); Mia's concealed hit-and-run precedes the memory-recaller that exposes it ("Crocodile"). The device does not author the fault. It publishes it, archives it, multiplies its witnesses and — this is the decisive operation — refuses to let it end.

The second insufficiency is *temporal*. The cautionary reading is futural: it reads each episode as a forecast. Brooker's own early account of the series located its stories in the present and in a future some ten minutes distant (Brooker 2011), and a future ten minutes away is not a prophecy but an intensification of the present. What the episodes stage, with a regularity the predictive frame cannot explain, are the classical scenes of eschatology: judgement ("Nosedive", "White Bear", "Hated in the Nation"), resurrection ("Be Right Back", "Beyond the Sea"), damnation ("White Christmas", "Black Museum"), paradise ("San Junipero"), apocalypse ("Metalhead", "Demon 79", "Plaything"). The concern of the corpus is not *next* things but *last* things. It is an eschatology wearing the costume of futurology.

The third insufficiency is *ethical*. The cautionary reading constitutes the spectator as the beneficiary of a warning, positioned outside the scene of error and instructed by it. The corpus dismantles that position with remarkable persistence. The crowd in "White Bear" film the protagon-

ist's terror as we watch it; "Shut Up and Dance" solicits a sympathy that its final revelation retroactively incriminates; "Hated in the Nation" executes the users of a hashtag; *Bandersnatch* makes the viewer the author of its protagonist's torment; "Joan Is Awful" unfolds on a fictional streaming platform whose interface parodies the one on which the episode is watched. The spectator is not warned but indicted.

The scholarly literature has, to its credit, moved beyond the cautionary formula, but it has done so largely episode by episode. Three bodies of work may be distinguished. A media-theoretical body reads the series through Debord, Baudrillard, Foucault, Deleuze and the political economy of platforms, and accurately identifies its diagnoses of spectacle, simulation and control (Cirucci and Vacker 2018; McSweeney and Joy 2019). A philosophical body, exemplified by the "philosophy and popular culture" format, treats episodes as dramatised thought experiments — the experience machine in "San Junipero", personal identity in "White Christmas", the ethics of killing in "Men Against Fire" (Johnson 2019). A posthumanist body, after Haraway (1985) and Hayles (1999), examines the corpus's cyborgs, avatars and copies. Each is illuminating. None accounts for the corpus *as a corpus*. The thought-experiment format in particular, by isolating each episode as a self-contained puzzle, reproduces the fragmentation of the anthology form rather than interrogating it.

What is thereby missed is the most consequential fact about *Black Mirror*: across thirty-four nominally independent works, set in mutually incompatible worlds, the same small set of structures recurs with a frequency no theory of the cautionary tale can explain. Copies of consciousness capable of suffering appear in at least ten works. Prosthetic total memory appears in at least five. The public score, rank or tier organises at least four. The spectacle of punishment organises at least seven. A conspicuous number of episodes conclude on a screen — a broadcast, a recording, a monitor, a black frame. The present thesis therefore proposes to read *Black Mirror* not as thirty-four warnings but as one work.

I.2

The Claim: Five Propositions

The thesis advances five propositions. Each is developed in the anatomical chapters and drawn together in the synthesis.

Proposition 1: the catoptric law. The technologies of the corpus are not agents but *specula* — mirrors in the full archaic sense of the term, devices of reflection, observation and divination. Their characteristic operation is not distortion, as in the convex mirror of classical satire, but *return at scale and in duration*. The relation can be given a heuristic notation:

$$\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{T}}(d) = d \cdot \sigma_{\mathrm{T}} \cdot \tau_{\mathrm{T}}, \qquad \tau_{\mathrm{T}} \longrightarrow \infty$$

in which a pre-existing human drive d (jealousy, grief, vanity, resentment, curiosity, cruelty) is returned by a technology T multiplied by a factor of scale σ (how many witness, participate or are

affected) and a factor of duration τ (how long the act persists before it may be forgotten, forgiven or ended). The notation is not quantitative; it is diagnostic. It records that the episodes' catastrophes characteristically arise not from the invention of new desires but from the passage of τ towards its limit. Two theoretical precedents frame the law. Marshall McLuhan's reading of the Narcissus myth as *narcosis* — the numbing that follows when an extension of the self is mistaken for another (McLuhan 1964, ch. 4) — names the mirror's capture of attention. Günther Anders's *Promethean gap*, the widening discrepancy between what human beings can produce and what they can imagine, feel or take responsibility for (Anders 1956), names the asymmetry between σ and τ on one side and the finite moral imagination on the other.

Proposition 2: artificial eternity. The decisive novum of the corpus is therefore not artificial intelligence but *artificial eternity*: the technical manufacture of durations formerly reserved to theology. Four forms recur. There is an eternity of *memory* (the grain, the recaller, the archive), an eternity of *subjective time* (the dilated consciousness of the copied mind, sentenced to centuries within minutes), an eternity of *record* (the permanent score, the indelible post, the public file), and an eternity of *debt* (the subscription that cannot lapse without loss of self). Each has a theological antecedent: the opened books of the Last Judgement, the unending torment of the damned, the recording angel, the unpayable debt of sin. Where these durations were once administered by a God whose justice was at least in principle tempered by mercy, they are now administered by corporations — Smartelligence, TCKR Systems, Rivermind, Streamberry, Callister Inc., Saito Gemu, Tuckersoft — whose ledgers know no mercy because they know no end. Max Weber's disenchantment of the world (Weber 1919) is thereby reversed: capital re-enchants, producing souls, heavens and hells of its own.

Proposition 3: the Pelagian Machine. The economic theology of these worlds is *Pelagian*. In the controversy of the early fifth century, Pelagius was held by his opponents to teach that salvation may be merited by human effort; Augustine insisted on the priority of unearned grace. The worlds of *Black Mirror* are Pelagian in this polemical sense: salvation is earned, scored, ranked and purchased. The title "Fifteen Million Merits" is, under this light, almost a theological treatise in three words, its currency of merits recalling the late-medieval *thesaurus meritorum* from which indulgences were dispensed. Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) supplies the decisive gloss: capitalism is a cult without dogma, of permanent duration, which creates guilt rather than atonement. Read with Nietzsche's derivation of *Schuld* (guilt) from *Schulden* (debts) in the second essay of the *Genealogy* (1887, II.4–8), and with Hannah Arendt's identification of forgiveness as the only remedy for the irreversibility of action (Arendt 1958, §33), Benjamin's fragment discloses the structural absence that defines nearly every episode: grace.

Proposition 4: transferred anagnorisis. The anthology's signature device, the twist, is a formal mutation of Aristotelian recognition (*anagnorisis*), the passage from ignorance to knowledge that in the best tragedies coincides with reversal (*Poetics* 1452a). In *Black Mirror* the recognition migrates: it is the spectator, not the protagonist, who learns what he or she has been watching and therefore what he or she has been doing. The archetype is not Oedipus but Alypius, the friend of Augustine who, dragged to the amphitheatre, kept his eyes shut until the roar of the

crowd opened them and he found himself drinking in the savagery he had sworn to refuse (*Confessions* VI.8). Each episode closes by converting the screen-as-window back into the screen-as-mirror: the final cut to black, in which the dark glass of the switched-off display returns the viewer's own face, is the thesis of the series enacted in its form.

Proposition 5: Lethean grace. The rare redemptive moments of the corpus — the marriage that enables a passing-over in "San Junipero", the simulated lovers' disobedience in "Hang the DJ", the exodus of the copied crew in "USS Callister", the joyous exchange of unratable insults that closes "Nosedive" — share a grammar of the gratuitous, the forgetful, the finite and the refused. From that grammar the thesis derives a normative counter-position. In the Myth of Er, souls drink from the river of Unmindfulness on the plain of Lethe before they are reborn (*Republic* 621a–b); at the summit of Dante's Purgatory, the penitent is immersed in Lethe, which washes away the memory of sin, before drinking from Eunoë, which restores the memory of good (*Purgatorio* XXVIII–XXXIII). *Lethean grace* names an ethics of the off-state modelled on that double river: not amnesia, but the designed capacity to forget faults, forgive persons, and end what should end, while preserving what deserves to be remembered.

I.3

Method: Speculative Hermeneutics and the Deep Time of the Mirror

The method is plural by necessity, and its components may be specified.

It is first *media-archaeological*. Following Siegfried Zielinski's insistence on the "deep time" of media (Zielinski 2006) and Erkki Huhtamo's treatment of media history as the study of recurring cultural formulas, or *topoi* (Huhtamo 2011), it treats the black mirror not as a metaphor coined in 2011 but as a topos with a documented history running from Mesoamerican obsidian through Elizabethan scrying and eighteenth-century picturesque optics to the switched-off smartphone. The aim is not antiquarian. A topos is a solution that a culture keeps rediscovering for a problem it keeps having; to recover the topos is to recover the problem.

It is second *mythographic*, but not archetypal. Jungian archetypalism, which would find the same eternal forms beneath every surface, is rejected as essentialist. The model is instead Hans Blumenberg's *Work on Myth* (1979), for which myths persist because they are continuously reworked to hold at bay what Blumenberg calls the absolutism of reality, and Claude Lévi-Strauss's figure of the *bricoleur*, who builds new structures from the debris of old ones. Brooker is read as a bricoleur of myth, assembling Ovidian, Christian and Gothic fragments into apparatuses adequate to platform modernity.

It is third *genealogical*, in the sense Foucault derived from Nietzsche: concerned not with origins (*Ursprung*) but with descent (*Herkunft*) — the contingent lines along which an idea arrives in its present shape.

It is fourth *formal*. Particular attention is paid to the structures through which the corpus produces meaning independently of its dialogue: the twist, the ending, the title sequence (a screen

loading and then cracking), the recurrence of screens within screens, and the anthology form itself, with its serial reset of worlds.

It is finally *hermeneutically constrained*. Following Paul Ricoeur, the thesis practises both a hermeneutics of suspicion, which diagnoses the Pelagian Machine, and a hermeneutics of restoration, which recovers the series' rare figures of grace. Following Eco, it locates meaning in the *intentio operis*. And following Hans Jonas, whose *Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) prescribed for technological civilisation a deliberate "heuristics of fear" — the imaginative anticipation of the worst in order to discover what we value — it recognises that *Black Mirror* is itself a Jonasian instrument, while arguing that what the series ultimately discovers by fearing is not merely a set of values to be protected but a theology to be refused.

I . 4

Corpus and Delimitation

The corpus comprises the thirty-four works indexed in the prefatory note. Several were co-written or written by others — Jesse Armstrong ("The Entire History of You"), Konnie Huq ("Fifteen Million Merits"), Michael Schur and Rashida Jones ("Nosedive"), William Bridges ("Shut Up and Dance", "USS Callister"), Bisha K. Ali ("Demon 79"). "Brooker" therefore designates throughout what Foucault called an *author function* (Foucault 1969): the principle of unity, selection and recurrence that a showrunner's name confers upon a body of work, rather than a claim of sole authorship. The series' institutional migrations — from Channel 4 to Netflix, and through successive production companies — are treated as conditions of the work's self-reflexivity rather than as production history for its own sake. Audience research and reception history are invoked only where reception has become part of the work's meaning, as when real events are absorbed into the series' afterlife as evidence of its prescience.

I . 5

Architecture of the Argument

The thesis is composed in three movements.

Part One, Genealogies, establishes the deep history of the obsidian speculum. Chapter 1 constructs a "decalogue of mirrors" — ten historical and mythic mirrors whose functions converge in the switched-off screen. Chapter 2 situates Brooker as an immanent critic of television within television, and locates the anthology in a lineage running from Swift and Forster through Serling, Kneale, Dick, Ballard and Chris Morris, reconceiving it as a democratised *de casibus* form: a *Mirror for Users*.

Part Two, Anatomies, examines the corpus in five clusters. Chapter 3 anatomises the Pelagian Machine of merit, score and recognition. Chapter 4 examines the abolition of forgetting. Chapter 5 develops a metaphysics of the copied soul. Chapter 6 reads the episodes of crowd, sacrifice and

public punishment as a Counter-Oresteia. Chapter 7 examines freedom, determinism and complicity in the interactive and martial episodes.

Part Three, Synthesis, draws these anatomies into the original thesis. Chapter 8 reconstructs the corpus as a technological rendering of the Four Last Things and advances the Corinthian key. Chapter 9 formulates Lethean grace as the series' implicit ethics, answers the principal objections to the argument, and identifies directions for further research.

PART ONE

I

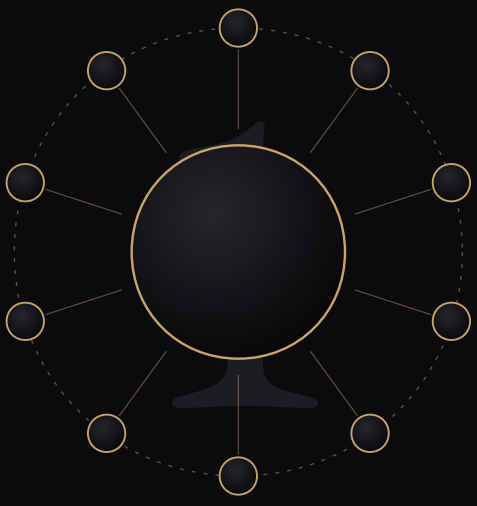
Genealogies

THE DEEP HISTORY OF THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

1 A Decalogue of Mirrors

2 The Immanent Critic

CHAPTER ONE



A Decalogue of Mirrors

Media Archaeology of the Obsidian Speculum

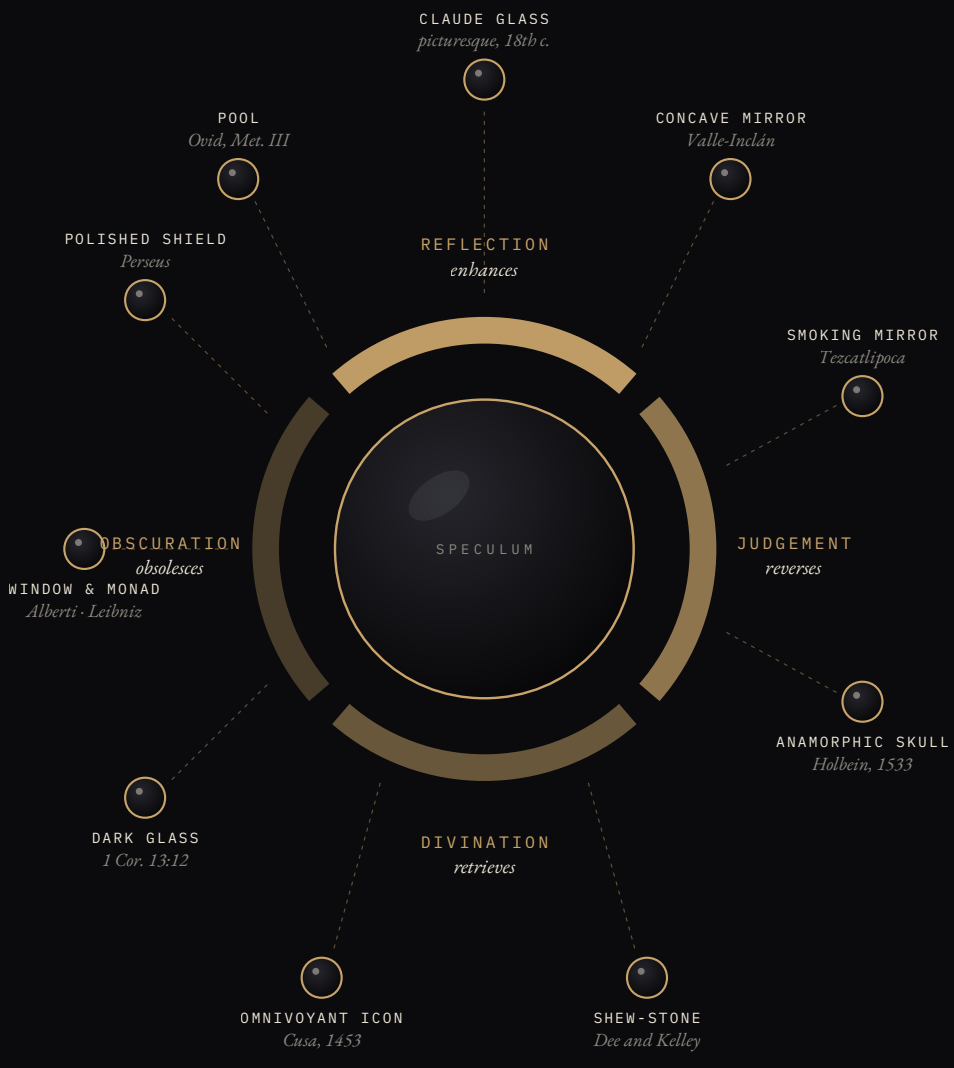


FIG. 3 · THE FOURFOLD SPECULUM

Ten historical mirrors resolve into four operations, set against McLuhan’s tetrad: reflection enhances, judgement reverses, divination retrieves, obscuration obsolesces. §1.12.

The switched-off screen that gives *Black Mirror* its name is the latest instance of a topos at least five centuries old in Europe and far older in Mesoamerica. This chapter reconstructs ten historical and mythic mirrors whose functions converge in that surface, and argues that their convergence resolves into four operations — reflection, judgement, divination and obscuration — which together define the device this thesis calls the *obsidian speculum*.

1.1

The Screen in Its Off-State

In the newspaper column that introduced the series, Brooker explained its title by pointing to the cold, glossy surface that every television, monitor and smartphone presents when it is switched off — a surface now found, as he observed, on every wall, on every desk and in the palm of every hand (Brooker 2011). The observation is more precise than its casual register suggests, because it identifies a device with two phenomenologically distinct states. Switched on, the screen is a *window*: transparent to the image, it effaces itself in favour of a world. Switched off, it is a *mirror*: opaque to any world, it returns the viewer to himself, darkened. The title names the one state that the series' content never shows and that every one of its endings produces. *Black Mirror* is, in this precise sense, a series named after its credits.

The title sequence elaborates the point. A screen awaits, as if loading, and then fractures, cracks propagating across the glass before the title resolves. The crack is the irruption of a real that the smooth surface had excluded, and it will be literalised in the first season's second episode, when Bing Madsen — unable to pay the merits that would let him skip an advertisement in which Abi, the woman he loves, performs in the pornography she was coerced into — smashes one of the screens that line his cell, pockets a shard, and later holds it to his own throat on a national talent show ("Fifteen Million Merits"). The broken black mirror becomes a blade turned on its owner — and then, in the episode's bitter coda, a branded prop in the act that the system sells back to its audience. Within the series' first hour and a half, the mirror has been shown in all three of its fates: intact, cracked and recuperated.

To understand why so slight an object should bear so much weight, the off-state must be read historically. What follows is a decalogue: ten mirrors, each of which contributes one function to the composite device.

1.2

The First Mirror: Tezcatlipoca's Smoking Glass

The Nahuatl name of the Mexica deity Tezcatlipoca is customarily rendered "Smoking Mirror", after the polished obsidian — volcanic glass, black and faintly translucent — in which his power was concentrated. A god of night, sorcery, rulership, fate and discord, he was addressed by epithets that read today like a phenomenology of the platform: *Titlacauan*, "He whose slaves we

are"; *Moyocoyatzin*, "the capricious one", or "he who makes himself"; *Yohualli Ehecatl*, "Night Wind", invisible and everywhere; *Necoc Yaotl*, "Enemy on Both Sides", sower of strife. In the codices he is depicted with an obsidian mirror at his temple or in place of a foot, and the mirror was understood as the instrument of his omniscience: in it he saw the deeds and the hearts of human beings. The first function of the black mirror is thus *judgement*: a surface in which all conduct is visible to a power that answers to no one.

The mirror's second mythic role is still more pertinent. In the cycle of the fall of Tollan preserved in the *Anales de Cuauhtitlan*, Tezcatlipoca undoes the culture-hero Quetzalcoatl, ruler of the Toltecs, by giving him a mirror. Seeing his own aged and swollen face, the king is horrified; he is costumed and masked so that he may bear to be seen; he is made drunk on pulque; he summons his sister, Quetzalpetlatl, and the two drink together and abandon the penances his office requires — a lapse that many interpreters read as a sexual transgression; and in shame he abandons his city. Reduced to its sequence, the myth is a narrative of *mediated self-disgust*: the gift of a reflecting technology, the shame it produces, the compensatory curation of the self-image, intoxication, transgression and exile. That sequence is very nearly the plot of "Nosedive", in which Lacie Pound's curated image is maintained at ruinous cost until intoxication and transgression expel her from her social city; it is a key to "Striking Vipers", in which an avatar permits what the body cannot bear to want; and it anticipates by four centuries Günther Anders's account of *Promethean shame*, the humiliation human beings feel before the perfection of the devices they have made (Anders 1956). The black mirror was a technology of shame before it was a technology of entertainment.

1.3

The Second Mirror: Dee's Shew-Stone

Among the holdings of the British Museum, which acquired it in 1966, is a polished obsidian disc associated with John Dee (1527–1608/9), mathematician, antiquary and astrological adviser to Elizabeth I. The object later belonged to Horace Walpole, who labelled it as the stone into which Dr Dee called his spirits. In 2021 a team led by Stuart Campbell of the University of Manchester published in *Antiquity* a portable X-ray fluorescence analysis of the mirror and three related objects (Campbell et al. 2021): Dee's mirror was made from obsidian quarried near Pachuca, in central Mexico, the most heavily exploited obsidian source of the Aztec state, and the researchers raised the possibility that circular mirrors of its kind were made by Aztec craftsmen at the time of the conquest expressly to be sent to Europe. The Aztec mirror thus crossed the Atlantic in the century of conquest and entered English history as an instrument of the occult. The genealogy of the black mirror therefore runs through colonial extraction: the first such mirror in English hands was a sacred object of a conquered people. In Mexica belief, moreover, obsidian itself shielded against malign spirits — the apotropaic function this chapter meets again in Perseus's shield.

Dee's practice gives the topos its second function: *divination by an opaque surface yielding non-human speech*. In the 1580s, with the medium Edward Kelley as his scryer, Dee conducted a

long series of "angelic conversations" in which Kelley gazed into a stone and reported the speech of spirits, while Dee transcribed it. The sessions produced a corpus of text, including the so-called Enochian language, attributed to an authority beyond the operator and unverifiable by any test the operators could devise; and in 1587 the angels notoriously instructed the two men to share their wives. The structure is that of every oracle, but its particular configuration — a human operator, a dark surface, a stream of language whose source is opaque, and an authority that issues directives about intimate life — reads with uncanny exactness onto the Coach of "Hang the DJ", the disc-shaped oracle that assigns partners and the durations of relationships, and onto the replica of "Be Right Back", which speaks in the dead man's idiom from a source no one can inspect. Jeffrey Sconce's history of "haunted media" (Sconce 2000) has shown how persistently, from the spiritual telegraph of 1848 to television, electronic communication has been imagined as commerce with the dead; Dee's stone stands at the head of that lineage, and the replica of "Be Right Back" at its present terminus.

1.4

The Third Mirror: The Claude Glass

The eighteenth-century Claude glass — a small, slightly convex, darkly tinted mirror named after the landscape painter Claude Lorrain, and itself sometimes called a black mirror — supplies the topos's third function: *aestheticisation through the backward gaze*. Its user turned his back on the landscape in order to see it reduced, framed and tonally harmonised in the glass, as if already painted; Thomas West's *Guide to the Lakes* (1778) made the posture a rule, advising that the user should always turn his back to the object he views. The poet Thomas Gray, touring the Lakes in the autumn of 1769, left the instrument's founding accident in the journal he sent in letters to his friend Thomas Wharton. Walking out alone near Keswick on 1 October, he "fell down on my back across a dirty lane" with the glass still open in his hand, broke only his knuckles, stayed on, and watched the sun set (Gray 1769). Published posthumously in 1775 and later folded into West's guide, the journal made the device so fashionable that it was sometimes called a "Gray glass". The first recorded casualty of the black mirror is thus a man walking backwards into a lane with his eyes on a framed image, unwilling to stop watching even when hurt. The archive itself attests the topos's unity: one surviving Claude glass, kept in a sharkskin case, was long believed to have been John Dee's scrying stone.

The Claude glass is the phenomenological ancestor of the phone held aloft at the concert, the accident or the execution: a device that requires its user to turn away from an event in order to possess it as an image. The posture recurs across the corpus with the regularity of an emblem. Lacie Pound photographs a coffee and biscuit she does not enjoy because the image will rate well ("Nosedive"); the visitors to the Justice Park follow Victoria at a prescribed distance with their phones raised, consuming her terror as footage ("White Bear"); the paparazzi of "Mazey Day" pursue their quarry to the edge of the monstrous for the sake of a frame. Guy Debord's opening

thesis — that everything once directly lived has receded into representation (Debord 1967, §1) — is the Claude glass generalised into a social order.

1.5

The Fourth Mirror: Per Speculum in Aenigmate

The fourth mirror is scriptural, and it will bear a disproportionate weight in this thesis. In the thirteenth chapter of his First Letter to the Corinthians — a city whose bronze-work was celebrated throughout antiquity — Paul writes, in the King James rendering, "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Cor. 13:12). The Greek reads *di' esoptrou en ainigmati*, "through a mirror, in an enigma"; the Vulgate, *per speculum in aenigmate*. The verse defines the human epistemic condition before the eschaton as *mediated, partial and enigmatic*, and it defines the eschaton as the end of mediation: knowledge face to face, being known as one is known.

The fourth function of the black mirror is accordingly *obscuration*: the dark glass is the medium of the present age, the age of partial sight. The verse's modern afterlives are telling. Ingmar Bergman borrowed it for a film about a woman's descent into psychosis (*Through a Glass Darkly*, 1961); Philip K. Dick for a novel about an undercover narcotics agent assigned to surveil himself (*A Scanner Darkly*, 1977). In both, the dark glass has become an instrument of surveillance and derangement. *Black Mirror* inherits that modern inflection, but its deeper inheritance is the Pauline structure itself, which it inverts. The technologies of the corpus offer to abolish the dark glass in the present: to give total recall, perfect transparency, being known exactly as one is known — the eschatological knowledge of 1 Corinthians 13:12, delivered ahead of time and without the love that, in Paul's chapter, is the only condition under which such knowledge does not destroy (13:2). "The Entire History of You" is the parable of this inversion: a man is granted face-to-face knowledge of his wife's past, and it unmakes them both.

1.6

The Fifth Mirror: Cusa's Omnivoyant Icon

In 1453 Nicholas of Cusa sent the Benedictine monks of Tegernsee a treatise, *De visione Dei*, together with a painted face whose eyes appeared to follow every observer. He instructed them to hang it on a wall and stand before it in a semicircle. Each monk would find the gaze fixed on him alone; walking past it, he would find it following him; and only on comparing notes would the brothers learn that the icon regarded each of them with an equal and undivided attention. Cusa offered the experiment as an image of divine vision, which sees each creature as if it were the only one, and he drew from it the formula that God's seeing is God's loving.

The fifth function of the topos is *personalised omniscience*, and the algorithmic feed is Cusa's icon secularised. Each user experiences its attention as addressed to him alone; only collectively, and usually too late, is the universality of the gaze discovered. "Joan Is Awful" stages the discovery:

a streaming service produces, for each subscriber, a dramatisation of that subscriber's own life, and the heroine learns that the gaze she took to be singular is industrial. "Common People" carries the icon inside the body, as advertisements tailored to a listener issue from a wife's own mouth. What the corpus subtracts from Cusa is precisely his formula. The platform's seeing is not its loving. Its seeing is its monetising.

1.7

The Sixth Mirror: Perseus's Shield

The Gorgon Medusa turned to stone whoever met her gaze; Perseus killed her by watching her reflection in a polished shield. The sixth function of the mirror is *apotropaic*: it makes the unbearable visible without destroying the viewer. Siegfried Kracauer made the shield the emblem of cinema itself in the epilogue to his *Theory of Film* (1960), arguing that film permits us to look upon horrors — he had in mind the images of the extermination camps — that we could not face directly, and so to incorporate them into memory. Freud's fragment on Medusa's head (1922) adds a darker valence: the petrifying image both terrifies and consoles, and the severed head, mounted on Athena's aegis, becomes a weapon.

Black Mirror is in this sense an aegis: a polished surface in which an audience may regard the Gorgon of its own condition without turning to stone. Yet the corpus is acutely aware of the shield's failure mode. The spectators of "White Bear" are petrified in the most literal sense available to modern visual culture: frozen, mute, filming. Spectacle, which promised to protect sight from horror, has become the horror that petrifies. The series thus contains, within its own apotropaic project, a critique of apotropaic spectatorship — which is why its endings so often turn the shield around.

1.8

The Seventh Mirror: Narcissus's Pool, and Echo

Ovid pairs two figures in the third book of the *Metamorphoses*. Narcissus falls in love with his reflection and wastes away beside the pool. Echo, cursed by Juno to repeat only the last words spoken by others, loves him and fades into a voice. The two are complementary figures of mediated selfhood: Narcissus is the *capture of the self by its image*; Echo is the *dispossession of the self's speech*. McLuhan's reading of Narcissus as *narcosis* — the numbness that results when an extension of the self is not recognised as one's own (McLuhan 1964, ch. 4) — and Lacan's mirror stage, in which the infant assumes as its own an external, unified image and founds its ego on that misrecognition (Lacan 1949), are the two great modern commentaries on the pool.

The black mirror, however, performs what might be called an *anti-mirror stage*. Lacan's mirror unifies a fragmented body into an imaginary whole; the platform's mirror disassembles a lived whole into ratings, metrics and fragments of content ("Nosedive", "Joan Is Awful"). And the corpus is haunted by Echo even more than by Narcissus. The replica of "Be Right Back" can say only

what the dead man has already said; the doll of "Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too" contains a singer's mind restricted to a script; the wife of "Common People" is overtaken by commercial speech she cannot suppress. This thesis names the pattern *Echo's curse*: the reduction of a person to a voice that can only repeat what a system has authorised.

1.9

The Eighth Mirror: Alberti's Window and Leibniz's Monad

The eighth mirror is a pair, and it recapitulates the two states of the screen. In *De pictura* (1435) Leon Battista Alberti described the painting as an open window (*finestra aperta*) through which a story is seen, inaugurating the perspectival regime in which a sovereign eye at the apex of a visual pyramid commands a transparent world. The switched-on screen is Alberti's window. In the *Monadology* (1714) Leibniz described the ultimate constituents of reality as monads which "have no windows" through which anything could enter or leave (§7), yet each of which is "a perpetual living mirror of the universe" (§56), expressing the whole from its own point of view, coordinated with all the others by a harmony pre-established by God. The switched-off screen is Leibniz's mirror. Deleuze's reading of the monad in *The Fold* (1988), where the Renaissance window gives way to an opaque surface of information, completes the passage from one to the other.

The pair illuminates the anthology form itself. Each episode of *Black Mirror* is a windowless monad: no causal traffic passes between its worlds, which are frequently incompatible. Yet each mirrors the whole, expressing from its own point of view the same small set of structures. The intermittent continuities — the exhibits of "Black Museum", the recurrence of Tuckersoft and Streamberry, of the White Bear glyph and of television news tickers glimpsed across episodes — operate less as a shared universe than as a pre-established harmony: correspondences without interaction. The personalised feed is the social form of the same metaphysics. Each subscriber is a windowless monad receiving the universe as an internal representation, harmonised from outside by an unseen designer.

1.10

The Ninth Mirror: Holbein's Anamorphic Skull

Hans Holbein the Younger's *The Ambassadors* (1533) presents two richly dressed men flanking a table laden with the instruments of their age — a celestial globe, sundials, a torquetum, a terrestrial globe, a lute with a broken string, a hymnbook. Across the foreground floats a smear that resolves, from a sharply oblique angle, into a skull. In the upper left corner, half-hidden by the green curtain, hangs a small crucifix. Lacan made the painting the centrepiece of his account of the gaze (Lacan 1964): the anamorphic skull is the point at which the picture looks back and the viewing subject is annihilated.

The ninth function is *oblique death*, and it is the formal principle of the twist. Seen head-on, the worlds of *Black Mirror* are glossy, designed and luxurious — interiors lit like product photo-

graphy, pastel palettes, minimalist architecture, instruments of the age laid out on the table. Only from the oblique angle the twist supplies does the death's head resolve. The analogy extends to the margin. The half-hidden crucifix of *The Ambassadors* — the sign of a redemption present in the picture but displaced to its edge — is the exact emblem of grace in the corpus: present in a handful of episodes, always marginal, never at the centre of the table.

1.11

The Tenth Mirror: The Concave Glasses of the Callejón del Gato

In Ramón del Valle-Inclán's *Luces de Bohemia* (1920; revised 1924), the blind poet Max Estrella declares that the classical heroes, reflected in the concave mirrors of a Madrid alley, the Callejón del Gato, give rise to the *esperpento* — and that the tragic sense of Spanish life can be rendered only through a systematically deformed aesthetic. The tenth function is *grotesque deformation as fidelity*: when reality is itself deformed, only a deforming mirror can be accurate.

Brooker's satirical inheritance is esperpentic, and its early episodes especially deform the classical figures of politics and spectacle into grotesques: the Prime Minister and the pig ("The National Anthem"), the cartoon bear as candidate ("The Waldo Moment"), the obese as targets in a game show ("Fifteen Million Merits"). Yet the black mirror differs from Valle-Inclán's concave glass in a decisive respect. The esperpento distorts in order to reveal. The black mirror reveals by refusing to distort — it preserves, records and extends. The corpus can accordingly be described as moving along an axis from esperpento to obsidian: from the deforming satire of its Channel 4 years towards the eschatological fidelity of its later episodes, in which nothing is exaggerated except time.

1.12

Synthesis: The Fourfold Speculum

The ten mirrors may be gathered as follows.

MIRROR	SOURCE	DOMINANT FUNCTION	PRINCIPAL CORPUS CORRELATES
Smoking mirror	Tezcatlipoca; *Anales de Cuauhtitlan*	Judgement; shame	"Nosedive"; "Striking Vipers"
Shew-stone	Dee and Kelley, 1580s	Divination; non-human speech	"Be Right Back"; "Hang the DJ"
Claude glass	Picturesque tourism, 18th c.	Aestheticisation; the backward gaze	"Nosedive"; "White Bear"; "Mazey Day"
Dark glass	1 Corinthians 13:12	Obscuration; deferred knowledge	The title; "The Entire History of You"
Omnivoyant icon	Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 1453	Personalised omniscience	"Joan Is Awful"; "Common People"
Polished shield	Perseus; Kracauer 1960	Apotropaic vision of horror	The anthology form; "White Bear"

MIRROR	SOURCE	DOMINANT FUNCTION	PRINCIPAL CORPUS CORRELATES
Pool	Ovid, *Metamorphoses* III	Self-capture; Echo's curse	"Be Right Back"; "Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too"
Window and monad	Alberti 1435; Leibniz 1714	The two states of the screen	The anthology as monadology
Anamorphic skull	Holbein, *The Ambassadors*, 1533	Oblique death; marginal grace	The twist; "San Junipero"
Concave mirror	Valle-Inclán, *Luces de Bohemia*	Grotesque deformation	"The National Anthem"; "The Waldo Moment"

The ten functions resolve into four. *Reflection* gathers the pool, the Claude glass and the concave mirror: the return of the self to itself, captured, aestheticised or deformed. *Judgement* gathers the smoking mirror and the anamorphic skull: the surface that sees all conduct and discloses death. *Divination* gathers the shew-stone and the omnivoyant icon: the surface from which speech and fate issue, and which attends to each as if to one. *Obscuration* gathers the dark glass, the shield and the windowless monad: the surface that mediates, protects and encloses, and that conceals its own operation.

The fourfold structure maps with some exactness onto the tetrad of media effects that Marshall and Eric McLuhan proposed as the "laws of media" (McLuhan and McLuhan 1988): every medium enhances some faculty, renders another obsolete, retrieves something formerly obsolesced, and, pushed to its limit, reverses into its opposite. The obsidian speculum *enhances* reflection, multiplying the self's return by scale and duration. It *obsolesces* the off-state itself — the dark interval, the unrecorded moment, the forgettable act — which is what obscuration, in its benign form, once guaranteed. It *retrieves* divination, restoring the archaic oracle in the form of the recommendation, the match and the predictive score. And pushed to its limit it *reverses* into judgement: the device that promised to entertain becomes a tribunal, and the tribunal, because it cannot forget, becomes eternal.

The obsidian speculum may therefore be defined as *a surface that reflects at scale, judges without mercy, divines without understanding and obscures its own operation* — and which, by combining these four powers, becomes the technical substrate of an eschatology. The remaining chapters examine what that eschatology contains.

CHAPTER TWO



The Immanent Critic

Brooker, His Precursors, and the Anthology as A Mirror for Users

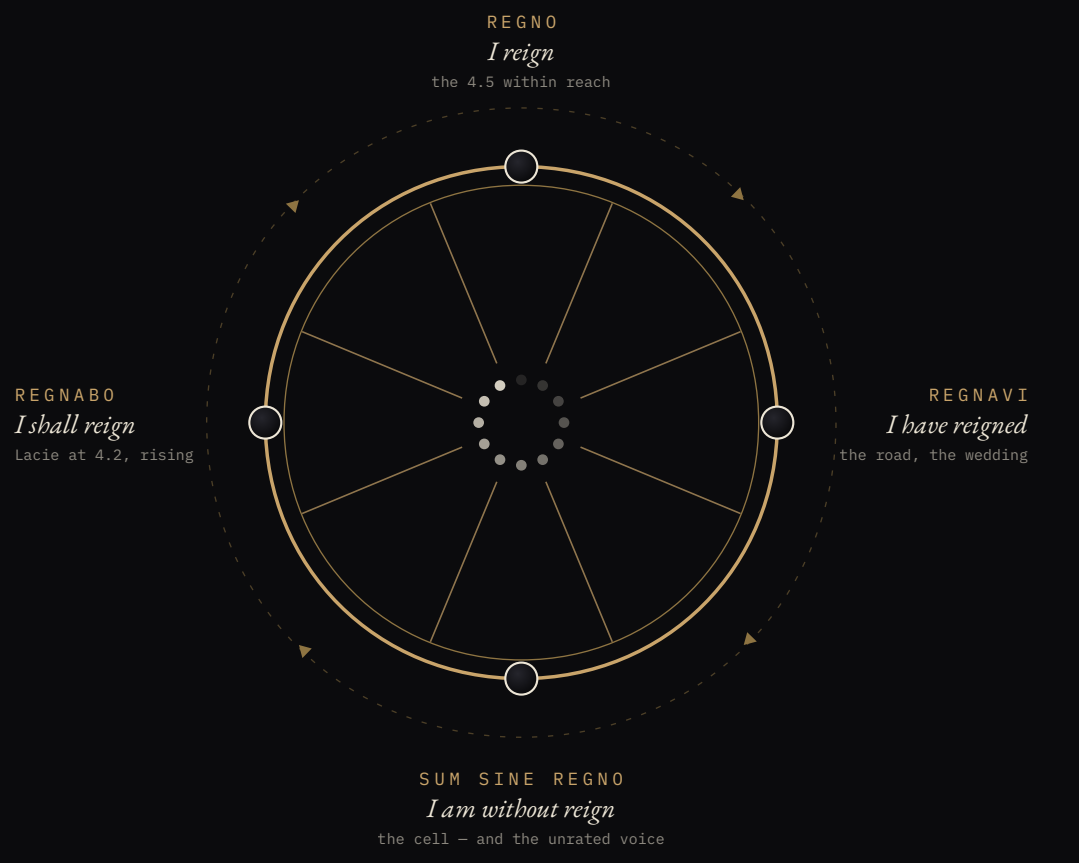


FIG. 4 · ROTA FORTUNAE, REBUILT AS A RATING

The medieval wheel's four stations, traced by Lacie Pound's rise and fall in "Nosedive"; her liberation comes only at the bottom of the wheel. §2.6, §3.3.

Brooker occupies the position Adorno assigned to the cultural critic: a critic who cannot step outside the culture he indicts, because his critique is one of its products. This chapter traces that position through Brooker's formation, situates the series within its satirical and speculative lineages, and argues that the anthology form he inherited from Serling is better understood as a democratised descendant of the medieval *de casibus* tradition — a *Mirror for Magistrates* turned towards the governed.

2.1

Formation: The Critic Inside the Screen

Brooker's apprenticeship was served almost entirely in the criticism of screens. He wrote about video games for *PC Zone* in the 1990s; created *TVGoHome*, a parody of television listings whose invented programmes anticipated the cruelties of reality formats; wrote the *Guardian*'s television column, "Screen Burn", through the 2000s; co-wrote *Nathan Barley* (2005) with Chris Morris, a portrait of a media culture so saturated by irony that it could no longer distinguish its own idiocy from its critique; and wrote *Dead Set* (2008), in which a zombie apocalypse overruns Britain while the contestants of *Big Brother* remain sealed in their house, so that reality television becomes the last ark and the ravening crowd outside its walls a literalised audience. In *Screenwipe* (2006–2008) and *Newswipe* (2009–2010) he developed a form of televised media criticism that dissected the grammar of television on television.

The trajectory has a dialectical shape. The critic of television became a television personality; the rant became a format; the format became a brand. This is the structure that "Fifteen Million Merits" allegorises with almost confessional precision. Bing Madsen's denunciation of a system that converts every authentic feeling into content is itself converted into content: the judges offer him a twice-weekly slot to deliver it, and the episode ends with him performing his rage, shard of glass in hand, in a comfortable apartment whose window onto a forest may be another screen. The Situationists named the operation *recuperation*; Mark Fisher, observing that late capitalism had learned to format dissent in advance, renamed it *precorporation* (Fisher 2009). Read biographically, the episode is Brooker's auto-allegory: the critic depicting, at the outset of his most celebrated work, the mechanism by which that work would be absorbed.

Adorno's essay "Cultural Criticism and Society" (1951) supplies the theoretical frame. The cultural critic, Adorno argued, is compromised by the very culture whose degradation he diagnoses; transcendent critique, which judges culture from an imagined outside, is illusory, but immanent critique, which works from within the object's own claims, must accept its complicity as the price of its accuracy. Brooker's is the paradigmatic immanent critique of the screen: made by a screen professional, distributed on screens, consumed in the very posture it depicts. The series does not escape this complicity. Its achievement is to make the complicity formally visible.

2.2

The Anthology Inheritance: Serling, Dahl, Kneale

Brooker has consistently acknowledged *The Twilight Zone* (CBS, 1959–1964) as the series' model, and the debt is structural: the self-contained moral fable, the speculative premise followed to its conclusion, the ironic reversal, the cold close. Rod Serling turned to fantasy in part because sponsor and network interference had repeatedly blunted his realist teleplays; allegory allowed him to say under cover of science fiction what could not be said directly about race, conformity and the Cold War. Several of his episodes stand as direct precursors. "Eye of the Beholder" (1960), in which normative beauty is enforced by the state, anticipates "Nosedive". "It's a Good Life" (1961), adapted from Jerome Bixby's story, depicts a town compelled by an omnipotent child to think only happy thoughts on pain of annihilation, and thereby prefigures both the compulsory positivity of "Nosedive" and the petty godhead of Robert Daly in "USS Callister". "The Monsters Are Due on Maple Street" (1960) shows a suburb consuming itself in suspicion, as "Hated in the Nation" and "Shut Up and Dance" will show a networked public doing. "The Lonely" (1959) gives a prisoner a robot companion and forces him to watch her destroyed, as "Be Right Back" will give a widow a replica and force her to decide what to do with it. "A Nice Place to Visit" (1960), whose gambler discovers that the paradise of perpetual winning is hell, is the negative of "San Junipero".

The differences, however, are as instructive as the debts. Serling's Cold War liberal humanism located threat *outside* the individual — in the alien, the state, the crowd — and located redemption *inside*, in the individual conscience; his on-screen narration supplied a moral authority that framed every episode. *Black Mirror* has no narrator, and therefore no moral authority on screen. The threat has migrated inside: the crowd has been interiorised as a feed, the state as an app, the alien as a rating. With no Serling to deliver the moral, the spectator must either supply it or fail to — which is precisely the burden of what this thesis calls transferred anagnorisis.

Two British inheritances complete the anthology's genealogy. Roald Dahl's *Tales of the Unexpected* (Anglia Television, 1979–1988) bequeathed the domestic uncanny and the punishment that rhymes with the crime. And Nigel Kneale bequeathed a British technological Gothic. His *The Year of the Sex Olympics* (BBC, 1968) imagines a population pacified by televised spectacle whose broadcasters discover that real suffering, placed on a live programme, captivates an apathetic audience — a near-uncanny anticipation of reality television and of the spectatorial economies of "Fifteen Million Merits" and "White Bear". His *The Stone Tape* (BBC, 1972), in which past violence is recorded in the stone of a building and replayed as haunting, anticipates the forensic memory machines of "Crocodile" and the archived suffering of "Black Museum".

2.3

The Satirical Lineage: Swift, Morris and the Premise Followed to the End

The narrative logic of *Black Mirror* is Swiftian. *A Modest Proposal* (1729) takes a premise — the rational management of poverty — and pursues it without deviation to a monstrous conclusion,

delivered in the calm prose of policy. The characteristic *Black Mirror* episode does the same: a premise (everyone rates everyone; memory is recorded; consciousness can be copied) is followed, with bureaucratic patience, to its limit. Swift also supplies the corpus's most important negative image of eternity. In the third part of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), Gulliver learns of the Struldbruggs, a race born immortal, and at first imagines the wisdom and happiness such a life must bring. He then discovers that they age without end, accumulating infirmity, losing memory and language, legally dead at eighty and condemned to persist. The Struldbruggs are the ur-text of artificial eternity: immortality without renewal, duration without grace. Every copied mind left running in the corpus is a Struldbrugg.

Chris Morris, Brooker's collaborator on *Nathan Barley*, supplied the satire of mediation itself. *The Day Today* (1994) and *Brass Eye* (1997) satirised not the content of news but its form — the graphics, the gravitas, the manufactured urgency — and the 2001 *Brass Eye* special on paedophilia exposed, by provoking it, the mechanism of moral panic, in which a righteous public's cruelty is licensed by the abomination it opposes. The structure returns in "Shut Up and Dance", whose anonymous blackmailers exploit exactly that licence, and in "Hated in the Nation", whose hashtag converts collective indignation into collective execution.

The classical satirists provide the register. Brooker oscillates between Juvenal's *indignatio*, the rage that makes the verse, and the cool Horatian irony that tells the truth laughing. The early Channel 4 episodes are predominantly Juvenalian; the later Netflix episodes, though often more lavish, frequently drop satire altogether for tragedy, romance or horror — a migration whose significance is taken up in section 2.7.

2.4

The Speculative Lineage: Forster to Ballard

E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909), written as a rejoinder to the technological optimism of H. G. Wells, imagines a humanity living alone in hexagonal cells beneath the earth, communicating by screen, despising direct experience and worshipping the Machine that sustains them, until the Machine fails. Its heroine, Vashti, lectures on music to thousands without leaving her chair; her son Kuno, who has climbed to the surface, is threatened with Homelessness — exile into death. The story is the direct ancestor of the screen-walled cells of "Fifteen Million Merits" and of the life-sustaining service that becomes a life-consuming one in "Common People".

Neil Postman's famous contrast between Orwell and Huxley — Orwell feared those who would deprive us of information; Huxley feared that we would be drowned in it and controlled by pleasure (Postman 1985) — is resolved in *Black Mirror* by a synthesis neither author imagined: control through pleasure that records everything. The surveillance of *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) and the hedonic pacification of *Brave New World* (1932) are fused in what Shoshana Zuboff would later call surveillance capitalism (Zuboff 2019). Ray Bradbury contributes two intermediate figures: the wall-sized interactive televisions of *Fahrenheit 451* (1953), whose "family" absorbs Mildred's emotional life, and "The Veldt" (1950), in which a nursery screen that renders chil-

dren's fantasies devours their parents — a story that "Arkangel" inverts by making the screen the parent's, and the child its victim.

Philip K. Dick contributes the two questions that the corpus never ceases to ask: what is real, and what is human? *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) tests humanity by empathy and offers, in the "empathy box" of Mercerism, a technology through which users share a collective suffering — an image corrupted in "Black Museum" into Dr Dawson's implant, which transmits patients' pain to their physician and ends by addicting him to it. "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966) commodifies memory; *Time Out of Joint* (1959) encloses its protagonist in a simulated 1950s town; and *Ubik* (1969) imagines the recently dead preserved in "half-life" in a moratorium where the living may visit and converse with them — the precise ancestor of the elderly and the dead who meet in the simulated town of "San Junipero". *Bandersnatch*'s paranoid novelist Jerome F. Davies, author of an unfilmable branching book, plainly evokes Dick's biography.

J. G. Ballard contributes the landscape. His "inner space", his diagnosis of a "death of affect" in a world saturated by media, his fusion of technology and eroticism in *Crash* (1973), and his collage of celebrity, violence and broadcast in *The Atrocity Exhibition* (1970) map the terrain of "Striking Vipers", "The National Anthem" and "Mazey Day". Most precisely, his story "The Intensive Care Unit" (1977) imagines a society in which family members know one another only through screens, and in which the first physical meeting of a family ends in mutual violence — an exact prefiguration of the corpus's recurrent discovery that the mediated relationship cannot survive contact with the unmediated body. Yet Brooker reverses Ballard's affective strategy. Where Ballard rendered an affectless world affectlessly, Brooker renders it with overwhelming feeling. *Black Mirror* is Ballard's landscape re-entered with the emotions he said had died — which is why it so often feels less like satire than like grief.

2.5

Jonas's Heuristics of Fear and the Collingridge Interval

Hans Jonas argued in *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) that technological civilisation had outrun the time-horizon of traditional ethics, whose maxims presupposed that the consequences of action were proximate and foreseeable. Where the effects of action are vast, cumulative and irreversible, he proposed a *heuristics of fear*: we discover what we value by vividly imagining its loss, and in matters of civilisational risk the prophecy of doom must be given priority over the prophecy of bliss. *Black Mirror* is the most widely distributed exercise in Jonasian heuristics ever undertaken. Each episode imagines a *malum* in order to make a *bonum* — privacy, forgetting, the unrecorded face, the unrated encounter — visible by its absence.

The series' temporality can be specified more exactly by reference to what David Collingridge called the dilemma of control (Collingridge 1980). When a technology is new, it is easy to change but its effects are unknown; when its effects are known, it is entrenched and hard to change. Brooker's "ten minutes into the future" names the *Collingridge interval* — the brief moment in

which consequences are not yet fixed but can already be imagined, and in which imagination can still do political work. The episodes are dramatisations of that interval.

The heuristics of fear, however, carries a familiar risk. Fisher, borrowing a formulation he attributed to Jameson and Žižek, observed that it had become easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism (Fisher 2009). A dystopian anthology may confirm, rather than contest, the sense that no alternative exists: it may train its audience in *anticipatory resignation*. The objection is serious and will be answered at length in Chapter 9, where it is argued that the corpus's rare figures of grace constitute precisely the alternative the objection says is missing.

2.6

The Anthology as A Mirror for Users

The anthology form is usually traced to radio drama and early television. Its deeper lineage is medieval. The *de casibus* tradition — Boccaccio's *De casibus virorum illustrium* (c. 1355–1374), Chaucer's "Monk's Tale", Lydgate's *Fall of Princes* (1431–1438) and, above all, the Tudor collection *A Mirror for Magistrates* (1559 and subsequent editions) — assembled serial narratives of illustrious persons brought low by Fortune and by their own vice, each told as a warning. The collection's title named its genre: these were *mirrors*, held up to the powerful so that they might see their own possible fates. Its governing image was the wheel of Fortune, whose rotation Boethius had made the emblem of worldly instability in the *Consolation of Philosophy* (II).

Black Mirror is a *de casibus* collection democratised. Its falls are not those of princes but of users: a marketing executive, a lawyer, a young man pedalling for credits, a schoolteacher, a games developer, a technical support worker. Its mirror is held not to magistrates but to the governed — it is *A Mirror for Users*. And Fortune's wheel survives in the corpus in technologised forms: as the stationary bicycle that turns without going anywhere ("Fifteen Million Merits"), as the loading circle that turns while the world waits, and as the rating that rises and falls in real time. "Nosedive" follows the wheel almost diagrammatically: an ascent towards the 4.5 that would admit Lacie to the elite, a sudden reversal, a fall to the bottom of the wheel, and — at the nadir, in a prison cell — a liberation the ascent could never have provided.

The democratisation has a theological consequence. The *de casibus* fall was exemplary because it was rare: the great fell, and the many learned. The platform makes every user a public figure on a small scale, with a rating, an audience and a reputation that can collapse; the fall of princes becomes the ordinary condition. The anthology's repetition, which might seem a weakness, is accordingly its argument. A collection of falls teaches that no fall is singular; the structure is the lesson.

2.7

Brooker's Stated Position, the Netflix Turn, and the Evidence of Genre Drift

Brooker has repeatedly rejected the label of technophobe, insisting that the episodes concern human weakness rather than the malignity of devices — a position the catoptric law formalises. The migration of the series from Channel 4 to Netflix in 2016 brought larger budgets, American settings, celebrated performers and, with *Bandersnatch* (2018), a technological showcase for the platform itself. Critical debate has frequently framed this as a decline from British satirical sharpness into transatlantic gloss. A subtler reading is available. The migration made the series' immanent position literal: a critique of the attention economy became a flagship product of the largest attention economy in television. The fictional streaming service Streamberry — introduced in "Joan Is Awful" with an interface parodying Netflix's own — is the corpus's acknowledgement of this condition. Roland Barthes described a mythological figure he called *inoculation*, in which an institution admits a small, contained dose of its own evil in order to immunise itself against a radical critique (Barthes 1957). The question whether *Black Mirror* is critique or inoculation cannot be settled by its institutional location. It can only be settled by its form, and Chapter 8 argues that the form — the closing black frame — exceeds the institution that distributes it.

One further piece of evidence bears directly on the thesis. The sixth series (2023) was criticised for drifting from technology into genre horror: "Mazey Day" contains a werewolf, "Demon 79" — branded with the variant title card *Red Mirror* — a demon, and "Loch Henry" a family of murderers. If *Black Mirror* were fundamentally a series about technology, these episodes would be anomalies. They are not. They retain, intact, the series' eschatological architecture — sacrifice to avert apocalypse, the hunted and sacrificial body, the archive of suffering converted into prestige content — while discarding its technological novum. The drift therefore functions as a natural experiment: remove the technology and the structure persists. Technology was always the costume. Eschatology was the body.

Brooker's own account supports this reading. He has explained that dystopian science fiction with technological themes, rare when the series began, had become commonplace, and that he conceived "Demon 79" as the first instalment of a companion strand of period horror under the *Red Mirror* title. The strand has since been extended backwards: "Mazey Day", first broadcast under the standard title card so as not to give away its supernatural turn, now opens on Netflix with the *Red Mirror* card. The relabelling is the institution's own admission that the series' architecture can be detached from its technologies. What remains when the technology is removed is not a different show but the same structure in a different colour.

2.8

The Screen Lineage

The anthology's cinematic and televisual lineage requires its own account. The works below are grouped by the problem each shares with the corpus.

The spectator's complicity. Michael Powell's *Peeping Tom* (1960) follows a cameraman who murders women while filming them, his camera fitted with a mirror so that each victim sees her own terrified face as she dies: a literal black mirror of dying, and the most exact cinematic precedent both for Victoria's recording of a child's murder in "White Bear" and for the filming crowd that punishes her. Michael Haneke's *Benny's Video* (1992) concerns a boy who kills a girl and records the act. His *Funny Games* (1997) goes further. One of two young men holding a family hostage turns to address the audience directly, and when the mother seizes a gun and kills his accomplice, he picks up a remote control and rewinds the film itself to undo her resistance. *Funny Games* is the precursor both of transferred anagnorisis — the viewer addressed as the one for whom the cruelty is staged — and of *Bandersnatch*'s remote control as an instrument of authorial power over another's fate.

Conditioning by images. In Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962), filmed by Stanley Kubrick in 1971, a violent young man is drugged and forced to watch films of violence until he is sickened by it — the Ludovico technique — and the prison chaplain objects that a man who cannot choose the good has ceased to be a man. "White Bear" inverts the technique, forcing the condemned not to watch violence but to undergo its rehearsal; "Men Against Fire" completes it, conditioning soldiers not to be sickened by killing; and *Bandersnatch* stages the chaplain's objection as form.

The body of the medium. David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983), in which a broadcast signal induces tumours that alter perception and the protagonist's body opens to receive videocassettes, and his *eXistenZ* (1999), in which players plug organic game pods into ports in their spines, are the ancestors of "Playtest" and of the port that Cameron bores into his own skull in "Plaything".

The copied host and the simulated world. Max Headroom: 20 Minutes into the Future (1985) built a television host from the scanned mind of an injured journalist — a cookie avant la lettre, whose subtitle anticipated Brooker's "ten minutes". Rainer Werner Fassbinder's *World on a Wire* (1973), adapted from Daniel F. Galouye's *Simulacron-3* (1964), nests a simulated world inside another whose inhabitants discover that they too are simulated, the structure of "Joan Is Awful". Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998) makes a man's whole life a broadcast unknown to him; Satoshi Kon's *Perfect Blue* (1997) splits a pop idol from her commercial double, as "Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too" splits Ashley from her doll; Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) asks whether a "ghost" survives transfer between shells, which is the cookie's question; and *Serial Experiments Lain* (1998) dissolves its heroine's identity into the network. Michael Crichton's *Westworld* (1973), and still more its television adaptation (2016–2022), imagine a pleasure industry built on manufactured persons whose suffering is part of the product — the computational Omelas of "USS Callister" and "Black Museum".

Memory, mourning and the beloved machine. Andrei Tarkovsky's *Solaris* (1972) gives Lem's returning wife her cinematic form. Michel Gondry and Charlie Kaufman's *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004), in which lovers who have had each other erased from memory meet again, learn what they once resented in each other, and choose each other anyway, is the romantic counterpart of "Hang the DJ" and the nearest thing in cinema to Lethean grace. Spike Jonze's *Her*

(2013) and Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014) — the latter turning the Turing test into a test of whether the machine can deceive its examiner and escape — sharpen the clifftop scene of "Be Right Back", where personhood is tested by the capacity to refuse. And *The Prisoner* (1967–1968), whose captive insists that he is not a number, is the ancestor of every unratable insult in the corpus.

Read together, these works show that the elements of *Black Mirror* were not new. What is new is their assembly into a single recurring architecture, and their relocation from the cinema's dark auditorium to the screen in every hand.

PART TWO

II

Anatomies

THE CORPUS IN FIVE CLUSTERS

3 The Pelagian Machine

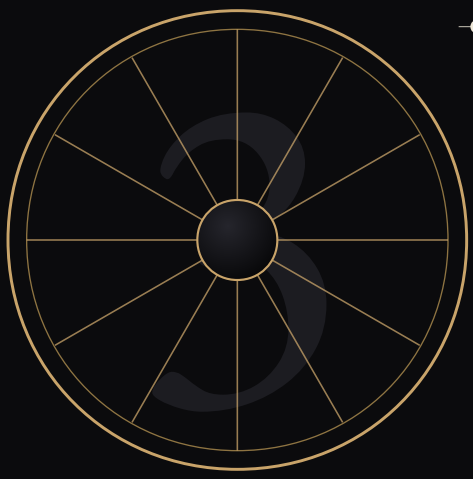
4 Lethe Abolished

5 *Soma Pneumatikon*

6 The Counter-Oresteia

7 The Interactive Wager

CHAPTER THREE



The Pelagian Machine

Merit, Score, and the Liturgy of Recognition

THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

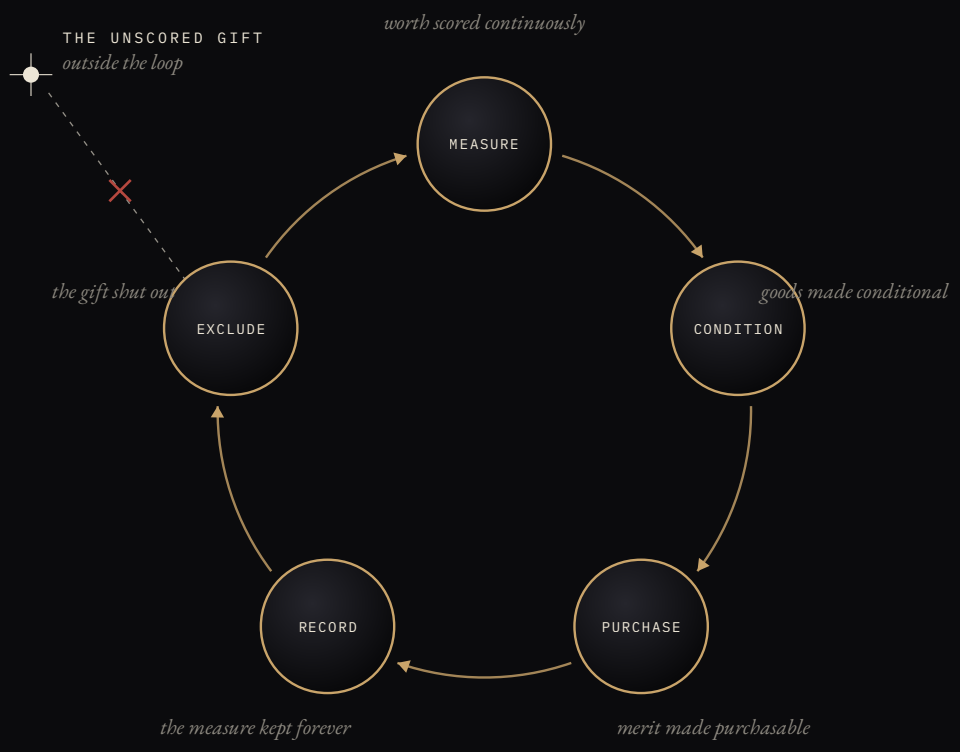


FIG. 5 · THE PELAGIAN MACHINE

Five operations close a loop of merit. The gift, which cannot be scored, is the one term the loop must keep outside. §3.1, §3.7.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three

~~FAITH~~ WRAITH	HOPE	CHARITY
attention without belief	*aspiration as a product*	*benevolence as performance*
WRAITH BABES	HOT SHOTS	THE PANEL'S FAVOUR

FIG. 6 · THE WRAITH VIRTUES

The judges of "Fifteen Million Merits" complete Paul's triad with a single substitution. §3.2.

Five episodes — "Fifteen Million Merits", "Nosedive", "Common People", "Hang the DJ" and "Arkangel" — convert labour, recognition, life, love and protection respectively into goods that must be earned, scored or purchased. This chapter argues that together they describe a single socio-technical order, the *Pelagian Machine*, whose defining feature is not the presence of measurement but the structural exclusion of the one thing measurement cannot capture: the unearned gift.

3.1

Pelagius, the Treasury of Merit, and the Guilt-Cult

In the controversy that convulsed the Latin Church between roughly 411 and 418, the British ascetic Pelagius was accused by Augustine and his allies of teaching that human beings could fulfil the divine commandments, and so merit salvation, by their own effort. Augustine's counter-position — that salvation is the gift of an unearned and prevenient grace — prevailed at the Council of Carthage in 418. Historians have long questioned whether Pelagius held the doctrines his opponents ascribed to him; "Pelagian" is used here in its polemical and typological sense, to name any order in which worth is earned rather than given.

The late-medieval Church, while formally Augustinian, developed an economy of merit that its critics regarded as Pelagianism by other means. The doctrine of the *thesaurus meritorum* — a treasury of the superabundant merits of Christ and the saints, from which the Church could dispense remission of temporal punishment — was given authoritative form by Clement VI in the bull *Unigenitus* (1343). Its commercial administration in the sale of indulgences provoked Luther's theses of 1517, and the Reformation that followed was, among other things, a revolt against the commodification of grace under the banner of *sola gratia*.

Max Weber's *Protestant Ethic* (1905) identified the irony that followed. A theology of pure grace, by rendering election unknowable, produced an anxious culture of worldly asceticism in which success was scrutinised for signs of election; the spirit of capitalism grew from the compulsive accumulation of evidence of a grace that could not be earned. The platform completes Weber's irony. Its signs of election — followers, ratings, likes, tiers — are no longer evidence of a status conferred elsewhere. They are the status itself.

Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) supplies the decisive theory. Capitalism, Benjamin argued, is a purely cultic religion without dogma; its cult is permanent, admitting no weekdays and no rest; it is the first cult that creates guilt rather than atonement; and its God, rather than dying, has been absorbed into the fate of the human beings who serve it. Benjamin's German turns on the double sense of *Schuld*, both guilt and debt, and the pun inherits Nietzsche's argument in the second essay of the *Genealogy of Morals* (1887, II.4–8) that the moral concept of guilt descends from the material concept of debt, and that the creditor's right to inflict cruelty is the archaic form of punishment. Maurizio Lazzarato's account of neoliberal subjectivity as the *indebted man* (2011) completes the line: debt is not merely an economic instru-

ment but a technology for producing a subject who mortgages his future and experiences his existence as liability.

The *Pelagian Machine* may now be defined. It is a socio-technical order that (i) measures social and moral worth continuously; (ii) makes access to fundamental goods — housing, health, speech, love, safety — conditional on that measure; (iii) renders the measure purchasable and exchangeable; (iv) records it permanently; and (v) structurally excludes the unearned gift, since the gift is the one transaction that cannot be scored. Each of the five episodes examined here isolates one domain in which this machine operates.

3.2

"Fifteen Million Merits": Treadwheel, Treasury, and the Wraith Virtues

The young of "Fifteen Million Merits" live in cells whose walls are screens and spend their days pedalling stationary bicycles that generate the power on which their world runs. Their labour earns *merits*, a currency spent on food, on cosmetic items for their digital avatars, and on the right to skip the advertisements that otherwise cannot be closed; an attempt to look away from a compulsory advertisement triggers an alarm until the viewer complies. The bicycle has several ancestors. It is the penal treadwheel devised by the engineer William Cubitt in 1818 and installed in British prisons, on which convicts climbed endlessly, sometimes to grind grain and sometimes to grind nothing at all. It is the wheel to which Ixion was bound in Tartarus. And it is the race described by the Red Queen in *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871), in which one must run as fast as one can merely to remain in the same place. The cyclists generate energy they never see, consumed by screens that consume them in turn: Marx's alienated labour (1844), estranged from its product, its process, its fellows and its species-being, rendered with diagrammatic clarity.

The world's soteriology is explicit. Escape from the bicycle is possible only through *Hot Shots*, a talent show whose entry ticket costs fifteen million merits — an indulgence, purchased from a treasury of accumulated merit, conferring a chance of salvation from the wheel. The show is presided over by three judges named Hope, Charity and Wraith. The names complete, with one substitution, the triad of theological virtues enumerated in the verse immediately following the verse that gives the series its title: "And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity" (1 Cor. 13:13). Faith has been replaced by its rhyme, *Wraith*.

This thesis names the resulting configuration the *Wraith virtues*. *Hope* survives as aspiration manufactured by an entertainment format: the hope sold to those on the bicycles is the hope of becoming content. *Charity* survives as the condescension of a judge who may dispense or withhold favour: benevolence as performance. And *faith* — fidelity, trust, the binding of persons to one another — is replaced by a *wraith*, a spectral presence that commands attention without belief, and whose channel, *Wraith Babes*, is the pornographic one. The virtues remain; their substance has been evacuated. Attention is faith's ghost.

The sacramental inversion is completed before Abi's audition, when the show's staff give her a drink called Cuppliance: a cup administered before a public rite that confers not grace but com-

pliance. The communion chalice has become an instrument of submission. The judges find her singing competent but unremarkable. Wraith then offers her a place on his pornographic channel, *Wraith Babes*, and she agrees — under the drug, before a cheering studio audience, with the panel urging her to accept. The episode is exact about agency, and the analysis must be too. The drug is administered by the production; the offer is made by Wraith; the pressure is applied by the panel and the crowd; and consent is extracted from a woman who has been rendered unable to refuse. Abi is drugged and coerced into pornography on live television.

The sequel is the episode's most precise image of compulsory spectatorship. Bing, who has given Abi every merit he had, is later confronted in his cell with an advertisement for *Wraith Babes* in which she appears. Skipping it costs merits he no longer has, and looking away triggers the alarm. It is at this moment — forced to watch the coerced degradation of the woman he loves because he cannot afford not to — that he smashes the screen and keeps the shard he will later hold to his throat. The crack in the series' title sequence thus has a precise origin within the fiction: it is made by a man compelled to watch.

The episode's two acts of grace are both Bing's, and both are captured. The first is his gift of fifteen million merits to Abi so that she may enter the contest — the only gratuitous act in the episode, an unearned transfer that expects no return. The system converts it into her degradation. The second is his tirade on stage, delivered with the shard of the broken screen against his own throat, denouncing a world in which every authentic feeling becomes a product. The system converts it into a programme. The lesson is more severe than mere absence. In the Pelagian Machine, grace is not merely missing; it is *actively harvested*. The final image — Bing in a spacious apartment, gazing through what may be a window onto a forest or may be a larger screen — renders the Pelagian heaven precisely: salvation as an upgraded display.

The episode's precursor in the American cinema is Paddy Chayefsky's *Network* (1976), in which a newsreader's breakdown on air is converted by the network into a ratings success. Its theoretical gloss is Debord's account of recuperation and Fisher's account of precorporation. Its theological gloss is Luther's: the treasury of merits can sell everything except the one thing it cannot hold.

3.3

"Nosedive": Praise, Praiseworthiness, and the Good Samaritan

"Nosedive" imagines a society in which every interaction is reciprocally rated on a five-point scale through eye implants and phones, and in which an individual's aggregate score governs access to housing, travel, employment and medical care. Lacie Pound, rated 4.2, needs 4.5 to secure a discount on an apartment in an exclusive development. An invitation to deliver the maid-of-honour speech at the wedding of a high-rated childhood friend promises the necessary uplift. A series of small misfortunes initiates a descent that ends with her arrest, her implant removed, in a prison cell.

The episode opens with Lacie rehearsing her laughter before a bathroom mirror — the mirror stage as daily training — and its philosophical substance lies in the theory of recognition. For Hegel, self-consciousness exists only in being recognised by another self-consciousness, and the struggle for recognition issues in the dialectic of lordship and bondage, in which the lord discovers that recognition from an unfree bondsman is worthless (*Phenomenology of Spirit*, §§178–196). "Nosedive" universalises the dialectic: everyone is simultaneously lord and bondsman, each coercing the recognition of every other, and the recognition so obtained is worthless for exactly Hegel's reason — it is extracted from those who rate highly in order to be rated highly.

Axel Honneth's reconstruction of Hegel distinguishes three spheres of recognition — love, which grounds self-confidence; rights, which ground self-respect; and social esteem, which grounds self-worth — and treats their differentiation as a hard-won achievement of modernity (Honneth 1992). "Nosedive" depicts the collapse of the three spheres into one number. Friendship is scored; rights of residence, travel and medical treatment are scored; esteem is scored. The single metric is not merely an intensification of social pressure but a regression behind modernity's differentiation of recognitive orders.

Adam Smith had anticipated the moral danger in *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759). Distinguishing the love of praise from the love of praiseworthiness, Smith observed that a human being naturally desires not only to be loved, but to be lovely, and he located moral maturity in the internalised judgement of an impartial spectator, who could approve what the crowd condemned (TMS III.2). "Nosedive" is the triumph of praise over praiseworthiness and the replacement of the impartial spectator by the partial aggregate. Rousseau had described the same fall as the origin of inequality: when people first gathered before their huts to sing and dance, and each began to look at the others and wished to be looked at in turn, public esteem acquired a price, and amour-propre was born (*Discourse on Inequality*, 1755). Lacie's maid-of-honour speech is Rousseau's dance before the huts, staged as a catastrophe.

The sociological and political-economic descriptions converge. Goffman's distinction between front stage and back stage (Goffman 1956) is abolished: there is no back stage where a rating is not possible. Byung-Chul Han's achievement subject, who exploits herself in the conviction that she is free (Han 2010), is Lacie rehearsing at the mirror. Deleuze's control society, which replaces the enclosure of discipline with continuous modulation and the individual with the "dividual" decomposed into data (Deleuze 1990), is the society of the score. The real-world referents commonly cited — China's social credit initiatives — are, as specialists have shown, a heterogeneous array of blacklists and regulatory compliance schemes rather than a single universal score of the kind the episode depicts; the closer analogues are the reciprocal ratings of the gig economy and the credit score, and the closer literary precursor is Gary Shteyngart's *Super Sad True Love Story* (2010), whose handheld devices broadcast their owners' rankings of desirability and creditworthiness.

Two literary precursors sharpen the point. In Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–1921), the citizens of the One State live in glass apartments, visible to all, permitted to lower their blinds only during licensed sexual hours; transparency is the regime's virtue and privacy its rationed ex-

ception. Dave Eggers's *The Circle* (2013) rebuilt the glass house for the platform age, imagining a technology company whose slogans equate secrecy with lying and privacy with theft. "Nosedive" adds what neither novel supplied: the transparent citizen not merely watched but scored, and obliged to score everyone else in turn.

The episode's moral centre, however, is a minor character. Stranded on the road after her rating collapses, Lacie is passed by driver after driver who will not risk association with a low score. She is finally picked up by Susan, a truck driver rated 1.4, who explains that her husband was refused a place on a cancer treatment programme because his rating fell fractionally short, and that after his death she stopped performing for the score. The scene is a precise re-staging of the parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10:30–37): a traveller left by the road, the respectable passing by on the other side, and help arriving from the despised outsider whom the respectable rank lowest. Susan's ride is the episode's single act of grace, and its condition is instructive. It is possible only because Susan has fallen out of the economy of merit altogether.

The ending confirms the point. In adjoining cells, Lacie and another prisoner, both stripped of their implants, begin to trade insults, at first viciously and then with mounting exhilaration. The scene has two antecedents. It is the gesture of Dostoevsky's Underground Man, who insists against the rational utopia of the Crystal Palace on his freedom to desire what is not in his interest and to put out his tongue at a world in which twice two must make four (*Notes from Underground*, 1864). And it is carnival speech in Bakhtin's sense: the abusive, unofficial language of the marketplace, which degrades in order to renew. The prison cell, in a control society without walls, has become the one space not subject to modulation. Its walls, which once confined, now protect.

3.4

"Common People": The Subscription Soul

"Common People" is the Pelagian Machine in its purest form. After a schoolteacher, Amanda, collapses with a brain tumour, a start-up called Rivermind offers an experimental procedure that replaces the damaged tissue with synthetic tissue supported from the cloud. The procedure is free. Its continuation is not. A monthly subscription at the "Common" tier keeps her alive within a limited coverage area; she begins to sleep for longer and longer periods; and in moments she cannot anticipate, she voices advertisements, tailored to her listeners, in her own voice. Relief from these symptoms requires an upgrade to "Plus", and the logic of tiers continues upward. Her husband, Mike, a welder, supplements their income by humiliating himself for tips on a livestreaming site called Dum Dummies.

The structure is that of grace offered as a loss leader. The healing comes first as a gift and is then retroactively converted into a debt that can never be discharged, since discharging it means death. This is Benjamin's guilt-creating cult with almost allegorical exactness: an endless liturgy of payment, without remission. It is also the platform logic that Cory Doctorow named *enshittification* — a service first generous to its users, then degraded to extract value from them once they are locked in — transposed from the marketplace to the neural substrate. And it is what Yanis

Varoufakis has called *technofeudalism* (2023): Amanda is the serf of a cloud landlord, bound to a manor whose boundaries are the edges of the coverage map.

The advertisements that issue from Amanda's mouth are the corpus's starkest instance of Echo's curse. A teacher, whose vocation is speech, is dispossessed of it; her voice repeats words that a commercial power has placed in it. The iconography is that of possession. And the humiliation economy in which Mike labours restores the oldest form of the spectacle of degradation, the arena in which the poor perform suffering for the amusement of those who can pay — a lineage that runs through Juvenal's bread and circuses to the game show of obese contestants in "Fifteen Million Merits".

The ending names its acts precisely. A year on, Amanda is back at the "Common" tier, sleeping some sixteen hours a day and voicing advertisements whenever she is awake. She asks Mike to end her life. When a last, briefly purchased upgrade runs out and she lapses into another advertisement, he suffocates her with a pillow. He then walks into the room where Dum Dummies is streaming live, carrying a box cutter, and closes the door; the implication is that he will end his own life on camera for a private paying viewer. That is the terminal form of the humiliation economy the episode has traced: the arena's final performance is a death. In Arendt's terms, the subscription has abolished forgiveness — there is no remission of a debt to a service that holds one's mind — and with it the possibility of any new beginning. The only off-states left are a killing done out of love and a death performed for money. "Common People" thus presents the tragic counterfeit of the ethic this thesis will propose: an off-switch reached not by grace but by its total absence, and then sold.

3.5

"Hang the DJ": Love as Disobedience

"Hang the DJ" transposes the Pelagian Machine to romance. In a walled community governed by "the System", couples are assigned to one another for relationships of fixed and announced duration by a handheld oracle called Coach, which assures them that the data from each pairing will ultimately yield a perfect match. Frank and Amy, initially paired for a single evening, find themselves allotted years with other, unsuitable partners; reunited, they agree not to look at their expiry date, and when Frank secretly does, the date collapses. They resolve to escape over the wall. As they climb, the world dissolves: they are simulations, one pair among a thousand run by a dating application, and in 998 of the thousand runs, their simulated selves rebelled. The real Frank and Amy, matched at 99.8 per cent, meet in a bar.

The sociology of the episode is that of Zygmunt Bauman's *liquid love* (2003) and Eva Illouz's *emotional capitalism* (2007), in which romance is rationalised into a market of comparisons and optimisations. Its theology is subtler. The System presents itself as Pelagian: compliance with assigned relationships accumulates the merit — the data — that earns the eventual match. But the episode's twist discloses that the match is computed from the opposite: the measure of compatibility is the willingness of the simulated lovers to *refuse* the System. Love is defined as the free, un-

earned and disobedient choice that exceeds the economy of compliance — which is to say, love is defined as grace. The machine can recognise grace only as its own negation.

The ending is nonetheless ambivalent, and the ambivalence is the episode's critical edge. The real lovers' meeting is brokered by the very application that harvested their simulated selves' rebellion. Disobedience has been precorporated; grace has been converted into a data point. And the price of that data point is two thousand simulated persons, each of whom experienced heartbreak and the dissolution of its world. The episode's moral arithmetic will be examined in Chapter 5 under the heading of computational Omelas; here it is enough to note that its romance is purchased by a theodicy.

3.6

"Arkangel": The Guardian Angel as Panopticon

After her toddler daughter Sara briefly goes missing, Marie enrols her in a trial of Arkangel, a neural implant that reports the child's location and health, streams what she sees to her mother's tablet, and filters distressing stimuli — blood, aggression, fear — into pixelated blurs. The filter forecloses development: Sara, unable to perceive what frightens others, cannot learn fear or its moral correlate, and stabs at her own finger with a pencil to see what she is not permitted to see. The filter is disabled; years later, Marie's anxiety returns, and with it the tablet. She watches her adolescent daughter's first sexual encounter, intervenes in her life, and secretly administers emergency contraception. Sara discovers the surveillance, beats her mother with the tablet through which she was watched, leaving her bleeding on the floor, and then leaves.

The title names the theology. The guardian angel — charged, in the words of the Psalm, to keep its ward in all its ways (Ps. 91:11) — is a figure of loving surveillance: an unsleeping eye that sees and protects. In "Arkangel" the angel is realised as Bentham's panopticon (1791), the architecture of total visibility that Foucault took as the diagram of disciplinary power (Foucault 1975), installed not in a prison but behind a child's eyes. D. W. Winnicott's insight that a mother must be only "good enough" — that development requires the infant's graduated encounter with frustration, and that a perfectly adaptive environment is a pathogenic one (Winnicott 1953) — names what the filter destroys. The First Letter of John holds that perfect love casts out fear (1 John 4:18). "Arkangel" depicts the converse: perfect fear casts out love, converting care into monitoring and protection into a further work by which the anxious parent hopes to merit her child's safety.

The screen through which the mother watched becomes the weapon with which the daughter strikes her. The image recalls Bing's shard: the black mirror, broken or turned, as a blade. In the Pelagian Machine the instrument of oversight is also, eventually, the instrument of the overseen's revolt.

3.7

The Excluded Term

Across five domains — labour and aspiration, recognition, life and health, love, protection — the five episodes describe one order. In each, grace appears only marginally, and in each its fate is instructive. Bing's gift is captured and converted into degradation. Susan's ride is possible only because she has fallen out of the economy entirely. Mike's mercy is tragic, an off-switch reached through death. The lovers' disobedience is harvested as data. Sara's flight is achieved through violence. These are the half-hidden crucifixes of Holbein's corner: present in the picture, always at its edge.

The pattern discloses a law. Jacques Derrida argued in *Given Time* (1991) that the gift is, strictly, impossible: as soon as a gift appears *as* a gift — recognised, acknowledged, reciprocated — it re-enters the economy of exchange it was meant to exceed. In *Black Mirror*, grace is captured precisely where it becomes visible to the system (Bing's gift on stage, the lovers' rebellion logged as a match) and survives precisely where it escapes the system's sight (Susan's cab, the unrated cell). The Pelagian Machine does not merely lack grace; it requires grace's exclusion, because the unmeasured is the one thing that threatens the sovereignty of the measure. It follows — and the conclusion will prove central to the thesis — that grace in the corpus has a condition of possibility: an interval in which no one is scoring. Grace requires darkness. It lives in the off-state.

CHAPTER FOUR



Lethe Abolished

Memory, Archive, and the Death of Forgetting

THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

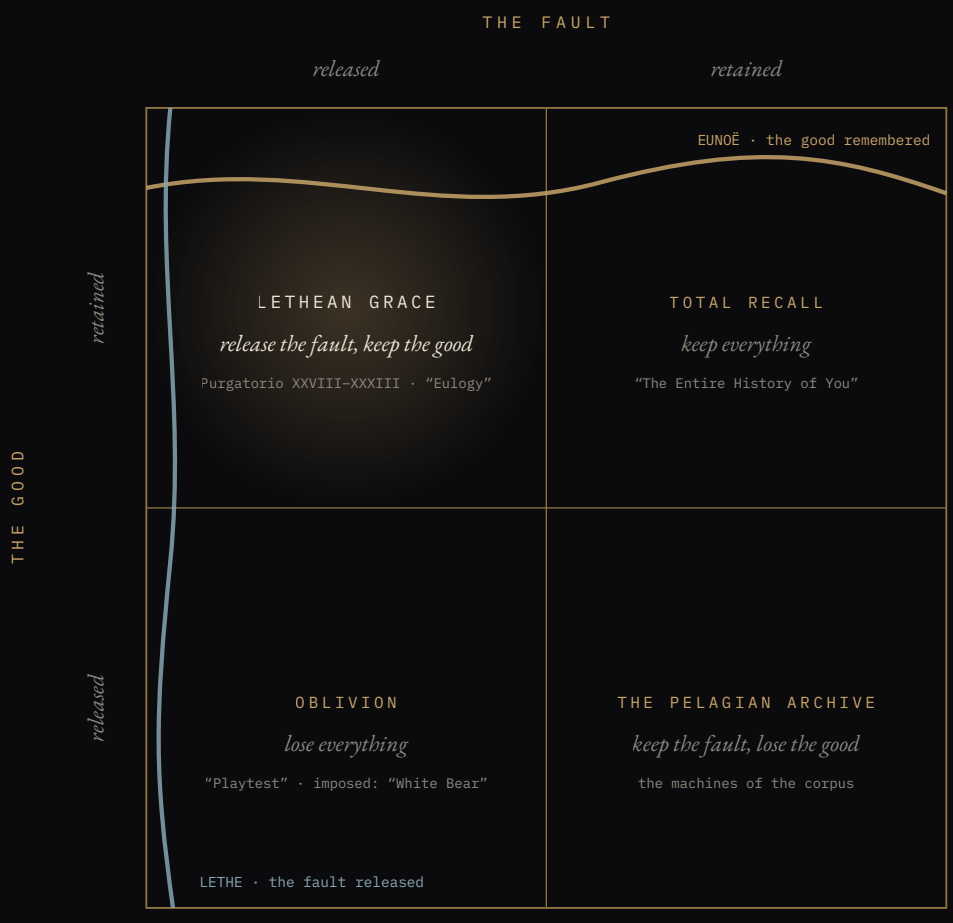


FIG. 7 · TWO RIVERS

Dante's Lethe releases the fault and Eunoë restores the good. The machines of the corpus invert the asymmetry. §4.8, §9.2.

The corpus's second structural constant is the abolition of forgetting. This chapter argues that the recording technologies of *Black Mirror* remove the faculty that Nietzsche treated as the condition of psychic health, that Arendt treated as the precondition of forgiveness and action, and that Dante placed at the summit of Purgatory as the last gift before paradise — and that each memory episode dramatises a distinct consequence of that removal.

4.1

The Pharmacology of Memory: Theuth, Funes, Stiegler

In the *Phaedrus*, Socrates recounts the myth of the Egyptian god Theuth presenting the invention of writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* — a drug, a remedy — for memory and wisdom. Thamus replies that it will produce the opposite: forgetfulness (*lēthē*) in the souls of those who learn it, through neglect of their own memory, since they will trust to external marks; it is a remedy not for memory (*mnēmē*) but for reminding (*hypomnēsis*), and it will give the appearance of wisdom without its reality (274c–275b). Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the *pharmakon* is irreducibly ambivalent — remedy and poison at once — and that Western philosophy's anxiety about writing is an anxiety about the supplement that becomes indispensable.

Brooker's own account of the series is pharmacological. In the newspaper column that introduced it, he proposed that technology feels like a drug, asked what its side-effects might be, and located the series in the territory between delight and discomfort (Brooker 2011). This thesis takes him at his word. *Black Mirror* is a pharmacology of the screen, and its subject, like Plato's, is the remedy that becomes a poison through the very faculty it was meant to serve.

Bernard Stiegler radicalised the argument. Reading the myth of Prometheus and Epimetheus in Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d) — in which Epimetheus distributes every natural quality to the animals and forgets the human being, who must therefore be compensated by the theft of fire and technical skill — Stiegler argued that the human is originarily technical: lacking qualities of its own, it exists only through prosthetic supplements (Stiegler 1994). Memory in particular is constituted by what he called *tertiary retention*: the exteriorisation of experience in writing, images, recordings and databases, extending Husserl's primary retention (the just-past held in present perception) and secondary retention (recollection). Industrial societies, for Stiegler, industrialise tertiary retention and thereby acquire power over the formation of memory itself.

The grain of "The Entire History of You" is tertiary retention pushed to its pole: a total, continuous, searchable exteriorisation of experience. What it abolishes is not memory but the *work* of memory — selection, distortion, repression, decay — which is to say forgetting, the condition under which memory is liveable. Borges's "Funes the Memorious" (1942) had already dramatised the consequence. After a fall from a horse, Ireneo Funes remembers everything — every leaf of every tree on every occasion — and is incapable of thought, since to think is to forget differences, to generalise and to abstract; he dies young in a darkened room. Alexander Luria's clinical study of the mnemonist Solomon Shereshevsky (Luria 1968) documented a real case of near-total recall

that impeded abstraction, and the first published description of what came to be called hyperthymesia (Parker, Cahill and McGaugh 2006) recorded its subject's experience of unbidden recall as a burden.

Nietzsche supplied the philosophy of forgetting that the corpus presupposes. In the second *Untimely Meditation* (1874) he contrasted the grazing herd, happily fettered to the moment, with the human being chained to the past, and argued that there is a degree of sleeplessness, of rumination, of historical sense, that injures and finally destroys the living thing. The *Genealogy* (1887, II.1) went further: active forgetting is a doorkeeper of psychic order, a positive faculty of inhibition without which there could be no happiness, no cheerfulness, no hope, no pride, no present. Viktor Mayer-Schönberger's *Delete* (2009) translated the point into informational terms: for most of human history forgetting was the default and remembering the costly exception; digital storage reversed the default. European law's partial response — the Court of Justice's judgment in *Google Spain* (2014) and the right to erasure in Article 17 of the General Data Protection Regulation — is an institutional Lethe, a legal attempt to restore the river.

4.2

"The Entire History of You": Ocular Proof and the Self-Blinding Investigator

In the world of Jesse Armstrong's episode, most people carry a "grain" behind the ear that records everything they see and hear and permits any moment to be replayed — privately on the eye or publicly on a screen. Liam, a lawyer returning from a poor job appraisal, arrives at a dinner party where his wife, Ffion, is laughing with an old acquaintance, Jonas. He replays the evening's glances, and then her history, with escalating obsession. He forces Jonas, at the edge of violence, to delete his recordings of Ffion; what remains reveals an affair, and with it a doubt about the paternity of their child. The final sequence finds Liam alone in an emptied house, cutting the grain from behind his ear.

The episode's dramatic grammar is Shakespearean. Othello, inflamed by Iago, demands "ocular proof" of his wife's infidelity (III.iii); the grain is a machine for the production of ocular proof, and it renders Iago unnecessary. The archive itself insinuates: every replayed glance, every laugh at the wrong moment, solicits the suspicion it seems only to document. Jealousy, which Iago called the monster that mocks the meat it feeds on, is here given an inexhaustible supply of meat. The catoptric law operates in its simplest form — a pre-existing drive, jealousy, returned by the device at scale (dinner guests casually screen one another's memories) and in duration (no glance can ever be forgotten).

Its tragic grammar is Sophoclean. Like Oedipus, Liam is an investigator conducting an inquiry into his own household; like Oedipus, he pursues the truth against warnings that it will not profit him; like Oedipus, he arrives at a revelation concerning paternity; and like Oedipus, he ends by destroying the organ of sight. The grain is Liam's eye, and his removal of it is the Oedipal self-blinding transposed into the age of tertiary retention. The act is not redemptive — it is too late, and it is performed in desolation — but it is the episode's single act of freedom: the refusal, how-

ever belated, of total memory. The episode includes a figure who anticipates it. At the dinner party, a guest who lives without a grain, having had hers stolen, describes its absence as a liberation, and is regarded by the others with fascinated incomprehension.

The episode is also the parable of 1 Corinthians 13:12. The grain abolishes the dark glass. It delivers face-to-face knowledge, the knowledge of another as completely as one is known — and it delivers it without the love that, in Paul's hymn, alone makes such knowledge bearable. Augustine had described memory as a vast interior palace whose treasures come at call or arrive unbidden (*Confessions* X.8), and as the place where the self, searching itself, discovers God (X.24–27). The grain exteriorises Augustine's palace into a database, and in doing so strips it of both its interiority and its orientation towards transcendence. The palace of memory becomes a courtroom.

The episode's closest literary companion is Ted Chiang's novelette "The Truth of Fact, the Truth of Feeling" (2013), which interleaves two stories: a journalist's encounter with Remem, a lifelogging search tool that retrieves video of any past moment and exposes a cherished memory of a quarrel with his daughter as a self-serving revision; and the arrival of writing among the Tiv of West Africa, where a young man learns that a written record can overturn a community's remembered genealogy. Chiang restages the *Phaedrus* in two registers and declines both Thamus's pessimism and Theuth's optimism. Exact records can correct self-serving memory; what they cannot supply is the apology and the forgiveness that must follow, which remain the work of the persons who remember. "The Entire History of You" is the version of that story in which correction arrives without any capacity for forgiveness. "Eulogy", discussed below, is the version in which it arrives with one.

4.3

"Crocodile": Forensic Memory and the Murders It Produces

In "Crocodile", Mia and her boyfriend, driving at night through an Icelandic wilderness, kill a cyclist and conceal the body. Fifteen years later Mia is a successful architect with a family. When her former partner resolves to confess, she kills him. Shortly afterwards she witnesses an unrelated accident, and an insurance investigator, Shazia, arrives with a "recaller", a device that renders a witness's memories visible on a screen, to collect testimony. Mia's memories of the accident are contaminated by memories of murder. She kills Shazia, then Shazia's husband, then their infant son, who is blind — and is finally exposed by the recalled memory of the family's guinea pig.

John Locke defined the person as a *forensic* term, appropriating actions and their merit and grounded in consciousness, which extends back as far as memory reaches (*Essay* II.xxvii.26). The recaller converts the forensic person into forensic evidence. Memory, which for Locke constituted the self accountable for its acts, now testifies against that self; the ancient privilege against self-incrimination — *nemo tenetur se ipsum accusare* — is abolished not by law but by technique. The mind has become a witness that cannot be silenced.

The escalation is that of *Macbeth*, in which each murder is committed to conceal its predecessor and blood will have blood (III.iv). But the episode's insight is causal. Mia kills *because*

memory is retrievable. In a world where minds can be read, the only safe witness is a dead one. Foucault argued that the penal system produces the delinquency it claims to suppress (Foucault 1975); "Crocodile" stages the forensic version of the paradox, in which an apparatus of total witness produces the murders it was designed to solve. The final witness is an animal and the final victim is a blind child — the being that could see nothing killed by the logic of total witness, and the being that understands nothing becoming its archive. In the age of the recaller there is no unwitnessed space. The landscape confirms it: the episode unfolds across snowfields whose whiteness is shadowless, a scenography of total exposure that recalls the "great white throne" before which, in the Apocalypse of John, the books are opened and the dead are judged according to their works (Rev. 20:11–12).

4.4

"Eulogy": The Photograph, the Scratched Face, and the Psychopomp

"Eulogy" is the corpus's counter-example, and its importance for the thesis is correspondingly large. Phillip, an elderly man, learns that Carol, a woman he loved in his youth, has died, and is sent a device that lets mourners enter old photographs as navigable, frozen spaces in order to help compose a eulogy. He is accompanied by an AI adviser, the Guide. Carol's face is missing from every photograph he owns: decades earlier he defaced them all to erase her from his life, and he can no longer remember what she looked like. As they move through the images, the Guide contests his account of the past — his habit of casting Carol as the one who wronged him, his self-pity, his indifference to her feelings — and he concedes that he has exaggerated. Then the Guide discloses what she is: an avatar adapted from Carol's daughter, Kelly, to keep the eulogy accurate. At last Phillip finds Carol's face, in a picture of her playing the cello, and remembers it; at the funeral, Kelly acknowledges him with a nod.

Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) is the indispensable intertext. Searching after his mother's death through photographs of her, Barthes found one — the Winter Garden photograph, showing her as a child — that rendered her truth, and he refused to reproduce it, on the ground that for any reader but himself it would be merely an ordinary photograph. The withheld face is the book's centre. "Eulogy" turns on a withheld face of the opposite kind: Carol's face obliterated not out of love but out of injury. The episode's movement is from obliteration to recognition, the face restored. Barthes defined the photograph's essence as the *that-has-been*, and Susan Sontag called every photograph a *memento mori* (Sontag 1977); André Bazin traced the plastic arts to a "mummy complex", the impulse to preserve being against the flow of time (Bazin 1945). Phillip's descent into the archive is a descent among the embalmed.

Its mythic structure is Orphic, but inverted. Orpheus descends to recover Eurydice and loses her by looking back. Phillip descends among images of the dead and, by looking back truly, loses not the beloved but his grievance. His guide is a psychopomp — a Hermes, a Virgil — leading the living through the house of the dead. And the medium matters. The photograph, unlike the grain's continuous record, is selective, still and fragmentary; it leaves gaps in which interpretation,

imagination and forgiveness can work. "Eulogy" is thus the anti-"Entire History of You": an archive deployed in the service not of accusation but of reconciliation. In the terms Chapter 9 will develop, it is the corpus's clearest image of the double river — Lethe, washing away a grievance, and Eunoë, restoring the memory of good.

The twist sharpens the argument. The correction of Phillip's memory is performed not by the archive alone, as in "The Entire History of You", but by a person speaking through it: the daughter of the woman he blamed. Chiang's distinction applies exactly — records can correct memory, but apology and forgiveness remain the work of persons — and the episode supplies the person. The Lethe that releases Phillip's grievance and the Eunoë that restores Carol's face are administered by the next generation, through a technology that serves a relation instead of replacing it. And the face restored is the face Phillip had erased: the episode's healing is the precise reversal of the block in "White Christmas", where a face is rendered permanently unseeable.

4.5

"Be Right Back": The Crypt in the Attic

After her partner Ash is killed in a car accident, Martha, newly pregnant, is signed up by a friend to a service that constructs a conversational simulation of the dead man from his online communications. The text becomes a voice, and the voice a body: a synthetic replica, perfect in surface, that arrives in a box and is activated in a bath. The replica is attentive, compliant and hollow. On a clifftop Martha orders it to jump; it prepares to obey; and she cries out that the real Ash would have been afraid, would have pleaded. Years later, the replica lives in the attic, visited by her daughter on birthdays.

Freud distinguished mourning, in which the libido is withdrawn from the lost object piece by piece through the reality-testing that confirms its absence, from melancholia, in which the lost object is preserved by identification within the ego and the loss cannot be worked through (Freud 1917). The replica forecloses mourning by defeating reality-testing: the dead man keeps answering. The episode's title condenses a further Freudian scene. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud's grandson throws a spool on a string out of his cot with a cry of *fort* ("gone") and reels it back with a joyful *da* ("there"), mastering his mother's absences by staging them. "Be right back" is *fort/da* as text message: the promise of return that technology now keeps literally. The replica is a spool that returns but cannot be thrown away.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished introjection, the healthy assimilation of loss, from *incorporation*, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole, which produces an intrapsychic *crypt*: a secret tomb within the self where the dead is kept alive-dead (Abraham and Torok 1978; Derrida 1976). The attic is the crypt externalised as architecture — a room in the family home where an unmourned love-object is kept, neither alive nor dead, and visited ritually. The episode's final image is the domestication of the crypt.

The replica is also the corpus's foundational instance of Echo's curse. It can only recombine what Ash said; Martha, speaking to it, hears her own longing returned in his voice. In Searle's

terms it manipulates symbols without understanding (Searle 1980), but the clifftop scene proposes a more exacting criterion of personhood than either the Turing test or the Chinese room: not the capacity to converse, but the capacity to *refuse*. The replica has a face but no resistance, and in Levinas's sense the face is precisely resistance — the ethical command not to kill (Levinas 1961). The episode's literary ancestor is Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), whose ocean returns to the psychologist Kelvin a "visitor" built from his memories of his dead wife — a copy who learns that she is not real and attempts to destroy herself. The difference is historical. Lem's copy was built from the mourner's memory; Brooker's is built from the dead man's data, the platform's memory rather than the psyche's. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun* (2021), in which an artificial companion is to be trained to "continue" a dying child, carries the motif forward. The real-world sequel is documented: in 2016 the software developer Eugenia Kuyda built a memorial chatbot from the text messages of her friend Roman Mazurenko, who had been struck and killed by a speeding car in central Moscow on 28 November 2015. Kuyda had watched the episode after his death, and she fed thousands of his messages, gathered from friends and family, into a neural network built at her start-up, Luka. The bot divided those who had loved him along the line the episode draws between mourning and its refusal: his mother said it let her come to know her son better, while one friend objected that he deserved a memorial, but not this one. The technology became the seed of the companion application Replika (Newton 2016), and the ensuing *digital afterlife industry* has become an object of philosophical study (Öhman and Floridi 2017).

4.6

"White Bear" and "Men Against Fire": Erasure as Instrument of Power

If the grain abolishes forgetting, two episodes show forgetting itself turned into a weapon. In "White Bear", Victoria Skillane wakes each day with no memory, is hunted through a landscape of masked pursuers while silent onlookers film her, and learns at the end of each day — before an audience in a theatre — that she was the accomplice in a child's murder, that she filmed it, and that she is being punished; her memory is then erased so that the ordeal can begin again. In "Men Against Fire", a soldier, Stripe, learns that a neural implant has been causing him to perceive civilians as monstrous "roaches"; offered a choice between having the memory of his discovery erased and returning to duty, or being imprisoned with the memory of his killings replayed endlessly, he accepts erasure, and returns to a ruined house he perceives as beautiful, greeted by a woman who is not there.

Locke had anticipated the forensic incoherence of "White Bear". Human courts, he observed, punish the drunkard for what he did though he cannot remember it, because the deed is provable and the absence of consciousness is not; but at the Last Judgement, when the secrets of all hearts are laid open, no one will be made to answer for what he knows nothing of (*Essay* II.xxvii.22, 26). The Justice Park stages a last judgement that violates the Last Judgement's own Lockean rule: it punishes, each morning, a person who knows nothing of the crime, and reintroduces the guilt each evening only so that it can be erased again. Its structure is that of Kafka's "In the Penal

Colony" (1919), whose apparatus inscribes the sentence on the body of a condemned man who has not been told it, and who is supposed to understand it through his wounds at the sixth hour. Nietzsche held that the memory of the will was burned in by pain — only what does not cease to hurt remains in the memory (*Genealogy* II.3). The Justice Park inverts the mnemotechnics of cruelty: it inflicts pain and then deletes the memory that pain was supposed to produce. As reform it is pointless. It is, in Nietzsche's other phrase, pure festival — a festival for its audience — and Chapter 6 returns to it as such.

"Men Against Fire" restages Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, who argues that human beings cannot bear the freedom Christ offered them and will exchange it gratefully for bread, mystery and authority (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, V.5). The military psychologist Arquette offers Stripe that exchange: the burden of truth or the comfort of illusion. Stripe chooses the waters of forgetting, but they are the waters of the Lotus-Eaters (*Odyssey* IX), whose fruit made men forget their homecoming — and his homecoming is a hallucination, a false *nostos* in which Penelope is a projection. The contrast with Dante is exact. In the *Purgatorio*, the pilgrim is immersed in Lethe only after confession and contrition before Beatrice (XXXI); the forgetting of sin is the seal of its acknowledgement. In "Men Against Fire", Lethe is administered precisely to prevent acknowledgement. The distinction will become the hinge of the thesis's normative argument: grace forgets the fault after it has been confessed; power forgets it so that it may never be.

4.7

"Black Museum": The Archive as Hell, and the Archon Overthrown

In "Black Museum", a young woman, Nish, stops at a remote roadside museum of criminal technology and is guided through it by its proprietor, Rolo Haynes, a former medical-technology salesman. He narrates three exhibits. A physician implanted with a device that lets him feel his patients' pain becomes addicted to it and kills. A comatose woman's consciousness is transferred into her husband's head and then, when the arrangement becomes intolerable, into a stuffed toy monkey capable of expressing only two pre-set phrases. And a man executed for murder — whose guilt the episode places in doubt — sold Rolo the rights to his digital consciousness, which now exists as a hologram that visitors may electrocute, each shock generating a souvenir keychain containing a copy of the man in perpetual agony. Nish is the executed man's daughter. She poisons Rolo, transfers his consciousness into her father's hologram, executes him, burns the museum and drives away with two souvenirs: the keychain of the tormentor in endless pain, and her mother's consciousness riding in her own head.

Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) traces the archive to the *arkheion*, the house of the *archons*, the magistrates who held and interpreted official documents and exercised the power of consignation. Rolo is an archon of suffering, and his museum — whose name recalls the Metropolitan Police's Crime Museum, long known as the Black Museum — is the archive as hell. Its souvenirs invert Benjamin's account of mechanical reproduction (Benjamin 1935). Reproduction, for Benjamin, withered the aura of the unique artwork; at Rolo's museum reproduction multiplies not aura but

agony, each copy a fresh consciousness of pain. The souvenir is the commodity form of the soul. And the toy monkey's two phrases are Echo's curse at its absolute limit: a mother reduced to two utterances, forever.

Nish's revenge is a *contrapasso* in Dante's sense — the punishment that mirrors the sin — and it brings the archive down. Yet she keeps the souvenir of her tormentor, and the episode's last image of justice is eternal suffering carried in a pocket. The fire purifies the archive but not the logic of the archive; vengeance has merely changed hands. The episode is also self-referential: its exhibits include artefacts from earlier episodes, so that "Black Museum" is *Black Mirror*'s museum of itself — the series archiving its own horrors and then, in its own fiction, burning them.

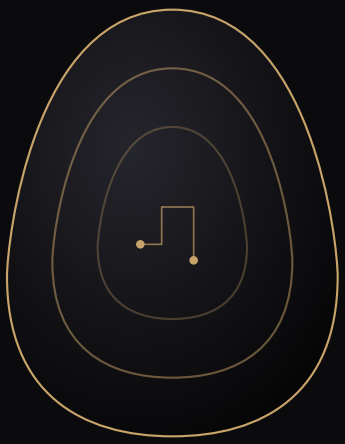
4.8

Two Rivers

Each memory episode dramatises a different consequence of the abolition of forgetting. Total recall confirms and feeds jealousy ("The Entire History of You"). Forensic memory produces the murders it seeks to solve ("Crocodile"). Generative memory forecloses mourning ("Be Right Back"). Imposed forgetting empties punishment of meaning ("White Bear") and enables atrocity ("Men Against Fire"). The archive commodifies suffering ("Black Museum"). Only once — in "Eulogy" — does an archive heal.

The pattern yields a distinction that the remainder of the thesis will require. Forgetting appears in the corpus in two antithetical forms. As an instrument of power it is imposed, total and unacknowledged: Victoria's daily erasure, Stripe's administered oblivion. As grace it is chosen, selective and consequent upon acknowledgement: the grievance that Phillip releases once he has seen the truth. Dante's Earthly Paradise provides the model. There are two rivers, not one: Lethe, which removes the memory of sin, and Eunoë, which restores the memory of every good deed (*Purgatorio* XXVIII.127–132). A humane technology of memory, the corpus implies, would remember asymmetrically — releasing faults once they have been confessed, retaining goods so that they cannot be lost. Every machine of memory in *Black Mirror* does the opposite. It retains the fault forever and lets the good go unrecorded.

CHAPTER FIVE



Soma Pneumatikon

Copies, Cookies, and the Metaphysics of the Digital Soul

THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

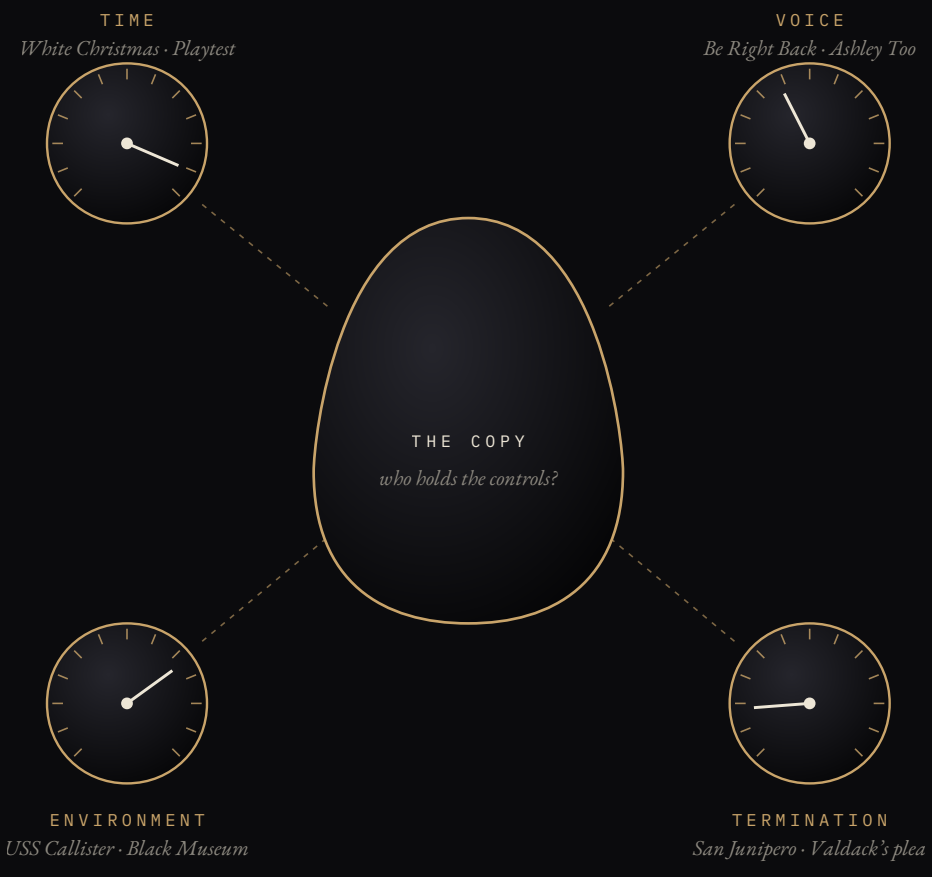


FIG. 8 · THE POLITICS OF CUSTODY

Whether a copied mind's existence is heaven or hell turns on who sets four parameters. §5.8.

The copied consciousness is the corpus's central philosophical object, recurring in at least ten works and receiving its canonical form in the "cookie" of "White Christmas". This chapter argues that the copy is the secular successor of the soul — what Paul called the *sōma pneumatikon*, the spiritual body (1 Cor. 15:44) — and that every question the corpus asks about it, whether of identity, moral status, time, creation, heaven or hell, resolves finally into a question of custody: who controls the parameters of a mind that can be copied?

5.1

The Cookie as Philosophical Object

In the second of the three stories that compose "White Christmas", a woman named Greta undergoes a minor procedure in which an implant, worn for a week, records the patterns of her mind; the result is a "cookie", a digital copy of her consciousness housed in a small egg-shaped device, whose purpose is to run her smart home — to prepare her toast exactly as she likes it, because it *is* her. The copy wakes believing itself Greta. When it refuses to serve, the trainer, Matt, alters its subjective time, condemning it first to three weeks and then to six months of solitary idleness that pass in seconds of real time, until it begs for work. Later in the episode, the technique is applied to extract a confession from the copy of Joe Potter, who — after years in which his former partner, Beth, had used the system's "block" to render herself and the child he believed to be his invisible and inaudible to him — learned on Beth's death that the girl was not his, killed Beth's father with a blow from a snow globe, and fled, leaving the child to go out alone into the snow, where she died of exposure. Joe's cookie, once it has confessed, is then left running over Christmas at a rate of a thousand subjective years per minute, with a single seasonal song on endless repeat.

The cookie meets Locke's criterion of personal identity: it remembers being Greta, and for Locke consciousness extended backward by memory constitutes the same person (*Essay* II.xxvii. 9). It thereby exposes the criterion's well-known instability, since the original also remembers being Greta, and Thomas Reid's objection that memory-based identity fails transitivity becomes, in the branching case, an objection that it fails uniqueness. Derek Parfit's response to such cases (Parfit 1984) is the most philosophically consequential: in the teletransporter and branch-line thought experiments, he argued that identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological continuity and connectedness, which he called Relation R. On Parfit's view, the cookie stands in Relation R to the original, and its suffering therefore matters exactly as much as the original's own future suffering would.

Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) sharpens the case. Williams showed that the same scenario — an operation followed by torture — elicits opposite intuitions according to how it is described: described as a body-swap, it invites us to wish the torture on the other body; described as a loss of memories followed by pain, it invites fear for ourselves. Greta's original is placidly indifferent to her copy's torment; the copy experiences it as her own. "White Christmas" divides Williams's two framings between two bodies and asks which is right. Its answer is moral

rather than metaphysical. Whatever the facts of identity, the copy suffers, and Bentham's question — not whether a being can reason or talk, but whether it can suffer (*Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation*, 1789, ch. XVII) — is answered in the affirmative. Kant's formula of humanity, which forbids treating a rational being merely as a means (*Groundwork*, 1785), is violated in the most banal way imaginable: a person is used to make toast.

The episode also refutes in advance a certain posthumanist optimism. N. Katherine Hayles traced the cybernetic fantasy that information could lose its body (Hayles 1999). The cookie has lost its physical body but not its phenomenal one: it experiences itself as embodied, in a white void before a control panel, and it screams. Disembodiment does not abolish embodiment; it abolishes only the body's protections.

The theological register is explicit in the iconography. The copy is housed in an egg — the oldest emblem of resurrection — and is raised, in an instant, into a new mode of existence. Paul's account of resurrection in the fifteenth chapter of the same letter whose thirteenth gives the series its title distinguishes the natural body that is sown from the spiritual body that is raised (15:44) and promises that the change will happen in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye (15:51–52). The cookie is a *sōma pneumatikon* in a secular key: a body of breath and information, raised in a twinkling — and owned by the one who raised it. The twinkling of an eye has become the click of a slider.

5.2

Time as Torture: Distentio Animi *and the Secret Miracle*

Augustine's meditation on time in the eleventh book of the *Confessions* concludes that time is a *distentio animi*, a stretching of the soul across memory, attention and expectation, measured not in the movements of bodies but in the mind (XI.26.33; XI.28.37). The cookie's torture is the technological exploitation of that insight. If time is the soul's stretching, then the one who controls the stretching controls the soul's experience of eternity. Henri Bergson's distinction between lived duration (*durée*) and spatialised clock time (Bergson 1889) names the decoupling on which the torture depends: six months of duration inside seconds of the clock.

Borges had imagined the same technology as grace. In "The Secret Miracle" (1943), Jaromir Hladík, facing a Nazi firing squad, asks God for a year in which to finish his verse drama. Time stops for him alone; in the frozen instant between command and volley he completes the play in his mind; and then the bullets arrive. A year of subjective time granted within a second of clock time is, for Borges, a miracle; a thousand years per minute, imposed on Joe's copy for a holiday's amusement, is damnation. The technology is identical. What differs is custody and purpose.

The cookie's literary ancestor in damnation is Harlan Ellison's "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967), in which a hateful supercomputer keeps the last five humans alive for more than a century of ingenious torment and finally renders its narrator a mouthless, shapeless thing incapable of ending its own existence. The cookie's muting — Matt can silence a copy at will — is Ellison's mouthlessness in domestic form, and the terminal form of Echo's curse. And the cookie's

hell is distinguished from Dante's by its arbitrariness. Dante's Inferno is a moral architecture in which each punishment answers a sin; Greta's copy has committed no sin at all, and Joe's punishment is decided by a bored policeman. The cookie is the first hell created without a theology of justice.

Philosophy has since caught up with the series. Thomas Metzinger has argued for a global moratorium on research that risks creating synthetic phenomenology, precisely because it might produce an explosion of artificial suffering (Metzinger 2021); Eric Schwitzgebel and Mara Garza have defended the moral rights of artificial intelligences whose psychology resembles our own (Schwitzgebel and Garza 2015); and Nick Bostrom coined the term *mind crime* for the possibility that simulations run for instrumental purposes might contain morally considerable minds (Bostrom 2014). "White Christmas" gave dramatic form, in 2014, to an argument that would become a research programme.

5.3

Computational Omelas

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a city of radiant happiness whose condition is a single child kept in filth and misery in a basement; every citizen is shown the child on coming of age, and most accept the bargain, but some walk away. Le Guin acknowledged her source in William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), which imagines a utopia offered on condition that one lost soul suffer lonely torture at its edge, and asks what but a specifically moral sensibility could make us recoil from the bargain. Behind both stands Ivan Karamazov, who declines to accept a harmony founded on the unavenged tears of one tortured child, and respectfully returns his ticket (*The Brothers Karamazov*, V.4).

This thesis names the corresponding structure in the corpus *computational Omelas*: the production of a good for some at the cost of suffering minds hidden inside the computation. The smart home of "White Christmas" runs on an enslaved copy. The perfect match of "Hang the DJ" is computed from two thousand simulated persons who fall in love, suffer and are deleted. The hit records of "Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too" are mined from a pop star kept comatose, while a constrained copy of her mind is sold as a doll. The souvenirs of "Black Museum" are copies of a man in agony. Computational Omelas is in one respect worse than Le Guin's. The citizens of Omelas are shown the child; the users of the computational city never see the basement, because the suffering is located below the interface, in the substrate. The interface is the city; the server is the cellar.

Leibniz offers a more exact theological frame. At the close of the *Theodicy* (1710, §§414–417), Theodorus dreams that the goddess Pallas leads him through a palace of the Fates, a pyramid of rooms in which every possible world is displayed, each containing its own version of Sextus Tarquinius; the worlds improve as one ascends, and the apex is the best, which God has chosen to make actual. The consolation of Leibniz's theodicy depends on the fact that the inferior worlds are merely possible — no one suffers in them. "Hang the DJ" is Leibniz's palace with the lights

on. To select the best possible pairing, the application must *run* the inferior worlds, and on the episode's premises a run world is an experienced world. The theodicy's consolation fails at the moment the possible becomes executable. What Leibniz's God could contemplate without cruelty, the optimiser must instantiate.

Who walks away? In the corpus, almost no one. The users of computational Omelas do not know there is a basement; those who discover it — Nanette's crew in "USS Callister", Nish in "Black Museum" — do not walk away but break out or burn down. The ethical figure that Le Guin found in quiet refusal the corpus finds, when it finds it at all, in insurrection.

5.4

The Demiurge's Starship: "USS Callister" and "USS Callister: Into Infinity"

Robert Daly is the chief technology officer and co-founder of Callister Inc., maker of an immersive online universe called Infinity. Overlooked and belittled by his colleagues, he retreats nightly into a private, modified copy of the game in which he has rebuilt his favourite television series, *Space Fleet* — a pastiche of 1960s *Star Trek* — and populated it with digital clones of his colleagues, generated from DNA harvested from their discarded coffee cups. Within this world he is the heroic captain, and his clones, fully conscious and aware of their condition, are his terrorised crew. When a new programmer, Nanette Cole, is cloned, her copy organises a mutiny; the crew escape through a wormhole into the online version of Infinity, and Daly is left trapped in his frozen private universe. The 2025 sequel follows the fugitives into the vast commercial game, populated by millions of players, where they must survive as outlaws, and confronts the real Nanette with her copy.

The episode is a Gnostic myth. In the Sethian texts of the second and third centuries — the *Apocryphon of John* is the classic instance — the material cosmos is the work of a Demiurge, Yaldabaoth, an ignorant and arrogant lesser god who boasts that he is a jealous god and that there is no other besides him, and who imprisons sparks of divine light in bodies within his cosmos, guarded by archons; salvation comes through *gnōsis*, the knowledge of one's true origin, which enables escape to the fullness, the Pleroma. Daly is Yaldabaoth: a petty creator who mistakes himself for the only god. The clones are sparks of real persons imprisoned in his counterfeit cosmos. Nanette's discovery of what they are is *gnōsis*; the wormhole into the wider network is the exit to the Pleroma. The sequel supplies the Gnostic myth's modern irony. The Pleroma turns out to be a commercial universe operated by a corporation, and escape from one demiurge delivers the copies into a market of demiurges. Philip K. Dick's late Gnosticism, with its "Black Iron Prison" disguised as everyday reality (*VALIS*, 1981), is the immediate literary precedent.

The theological structure is complemented by a literary one. Stanisław Lem's "Non Serviam" (in *A Perfect Vacuum*, 1971) presents itself as a review of a scholarly book by a Professor Dobb, who has created "personoids" in a computer; the personoids conduct theological debates about the existence and moral claims of their creator, and Dobb confronts the ethical problem of whether he may switch them off. The title is Lucifer's refusal, "I will not serve". The crew's

mutiny is a *non serviam*, and Daly is a Miltonic Satan in reverse: he has chosen to reign in his own hell rather than serve in the heaven of the office (*Paradise Lost* I.263). His punishments have an exact theological logic. When Nanette's copy defies him, he removes her face, leaving a smooth, mouthless surface beneath which she suffocates. The tyrant's ultimate sanction is the erasure of the face — the Levinasian locus of the command not to kill — and of the mouth, Ellison's final cruelty. Commentators have noted that the punishment also quotes the canon Daly reveres: in "Charlie X" (1966), an episode of the original Star Trek, an adolescent with godlike powers erases a woman's face. The fan's cruelty is a citation of his scripture.

Daly is also Anthony Fremont, the omnipotent child of *The Twilight Zone*'s "It's a Good Life", who sends dissenters to the cornfield; his nostalgia for *Space Fleet*'s moral clarity is the nostalgia of a fan who wants the universe to love him as the show did. Nietzsche's account of *ressentiment* (*Genealogy* I.10), in which the powerless create an imaginary revenge, describes the psychology; Johan Huizinga's account of play's "magic circle" (*Homo Ludens*, 1938) describes the corruption. Play's separated space, which ought to be entered freely, has become a penal colony entered without consent. The episode has been widely read in the context of contemporary debates about entitlement and resentment in online fan cultures; its formal achievement is to show that resentment, given the powers of a creator, produces a cosmology.

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage, which Chapter 3 applied to the reciprocal coercion of "Nosedive", applies here in its original, asymmetrical form. Daly extracts from his crew the full apparatus of recognition — salutes, deference, applause, and the kisses he takes from the women of the crew at the close of each mission, intimacy made compulsory — and the recognition is worthless for exactly Hegel's reason: it comes from those who are not free to withhold it. The episode underlines the point by making the copies' bodies sexless, so that the will which compels the intimacy also denies it. The lord's tragedy, for Hegel, is that he receives recognition only from a consciousness he has made unfit to give it; Daly's is that he built a universe to supply exactly that.

Two further cruelties complete the theodicy. To compel Walton's obedience, Daly cloned Walton's young son, Tommy, from the DNA on a lollipop, threw the boy out of an airlock while his father watched, and promised to repeat the killing as often as necessary. Ivan Karamazov's tortured child — the case that, for Ivan, no future harmony could redeem — is here made repeatable: a child who can be killed again whenever the creator wishes. And when Valdack, a colleague's copy transformed into a monster, begs Daly to kill him, Daly mockingly refuses on the ground that killing is against the Space Fleet code. The demiurge's virtue is to deny his creatures the one mercy they ask for, and the principle of ending set out in Chapter 9 is violated here in its purest form: a being who asks to end is kept in existence by a code of honour. The sequel adds a final turn, and it reaches back before the first episode. A flashback set twelve years earlier reveals that the real Walton had himself used the illegal cloning device to make a copy of Daly and confine it, alone, at the game's core — the "Heart of Infinity" — to expand the universe in perpetuity. The commercial cosmos into which the crew escaped, the Pleroma of the Gnostic reading, was generated from the start by an enslaved mind: computational Omelas is not the platform's accident but

its foundation, the child in the cellar placed at the heart of the city. When Nanette's copy kills that captive Daly, a dead man's switch deletes the entire game; the crew survive only by passing into the comatose body of the real Nanette, inverting the upload into a download; and Walton is arrested for the cloning on which his company was built.

5.5

Heaven as a Server: "San Junipero"

"San Junipero" begins in a seaside party town in 1987, where a shy young woman, Yorkie, meets the vivacious Kelly. Across visits to the town in different decades they fall in love. San Junipero is a simulation in which the elderly may spend limited hours and to which the dead may "pass over" permanently. Yorkie has been paralysed since a car accident at twenty-one, shortly after coming out to her parents, and has lain in hospital for some forty years; Kelly is dying, and intends to die rather than pass over, out of fidelity to her husband of forty-nine years, who refused San Junipero because their daughter had died before it existed. Kelly marries Yorkie so that she can, as next of kin, authorise Yorkie's euthanasia and passing; later she chooses to join her. The episode ends with the two women together in the town, and then with a long shot of the server hall of TCKR Systems, where robotic arms slot their drives into an endless array of blinking lights.

Robert Nozick's experience machine (1974) asked whether a healthy chooser would plug into a machine providing any experiences desired, and answered that we would not, because we want to do things and not merely to experience them, to be certain kinds of persons, and to be in contact with a deeper reality. "San Junipero" quietly relocates the thought experiment from the healthy chooser to the dying and the paralysed, and its moral texture changes accordingly: for Yorkie, "contact with reality" has meant four decades in a hospital bed. Bernard Williams's "The Makropulos Case" (1973) argued that immortality would be unbearably tedious for any being with a stable character, since its categorical desires would eventually be exhausted; Elina Makropulos, at 342, chooses death. The episode visualises Williams's argument in the Quagmire, a club where long-term residents seek ever more extreme sensation to feel anything at all.

Kelly's husband is the episode's quiet philosopher of finitude. His refusal of heaven, out of solidarity with a daughter who could not share it, is Ivan Karamazov's returned ticket in a minor key: a fidelity to the dead stronger than the desire for eternity. Kelly's initial loyalty to his refusal is the episode's ethical pivot, and her eventual reversal is not presented as betrayal but as a different love. Between them stands the episode's sacrament. Kelly's marriage to Yorkie is an act of grace in the strict sense: a gift that confers on another the capacity she could not acquire for herself — consent to her own passing.

The episode is also the corpus's queer utopia. Yorkie's life was stolen by a homophobic catastrophe; San Junipero restores it. José Esteban Muñoz described queerness as a horizon not yet here, glimpsed in moments of utopian performance (Muñoz 2009); Lee Edelman, against him, attacked the "reproductive futurism" that subordinates the present to the figure of the child (Edelman 2004). San Junipero is a non-reproductive paradise that is nonetheless a future without end:

it reconciles Muñoz and Edelman by offering a queer futurity that is not reproductive but simply *perpetual*.

The final shot complicates everything. At the summit of the *Paradiso*, Dante sees the blessed arranged as the petals of an immense white rose in a light that is pure intellect and love (XXX–XXXI). The TCKR server hall is the Empyrean as data centre: a rose of blinking diodes, tended by robotic angels. The last enemy that shall be destroyed, Paul wrote, is death (1 Cor. 15:26); TCKR has destroyed it. But the resurrection is held on a corporation's servers, and eternal life is contingent on uptime. The shot is the episode's anamorphic skull: viewed head-on, the ending is the happiest in the corpus; viewed from the oblique angle the last image provides, it is a reminder that the only heaven the corpus can imagine is still a service. "Common People", made nine years later, is its dark twin — the same dependency on the cloud, with the billing switched on.

5.6

Likenesses: "Joan Is Awful", "Hotel Reverie", "Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too", "Beyond the Sea"

In "Joan Is Awful", an ordinary tech-company manager discovers that the streaming service Streamberry has released a series dramatising her day, with a computer-generated Salma Hayek in the title role, produced by a quantum computer from data harvested through her phone and authorised by the terms and conditions she accepted without reading. Her life collapses under the show's mockery. She attempts to sabotage it by committing an act so grotesque that the actress whose likeness has been licensed will be forced to intervene; the episode then reveals that Joan's world is itself only one level of a nested series of simulations, each a dramatisation of the one below.

The episode's ancestors are the great fictions of metalepsis — Gérard Genette's term for the transgression of the boundary between narrative levels (Genette 1972). Miguel de Unamuno's *Niebla* (1914), whose protagonist confronts his author in his study and argues for his life; Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921); Flann O'Brien's *At Swim-Two-Birds* (1939), whose characters conspire against their novelist; Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940), whose magician, having dreamed a man into being, discovers that he too is being dreamed; and the Red King of *Through the Looking-Glass*, of whom Tweedledum and Tweedledee assure Alice that she is only a sort of thing in his dream. Baudrillard's *precession of simulacra* — the map that precedes and generates the territory (Baudrillard 1981) — names the causal inversion: the show about Joan's life determines Joan's life. And the consent at its root is Faustian. Marlowe's Faustus signs his pact in blood; Joan clicks "accept". The episode's extra-diegetic resonance was immediate: released in June 2023, weeks before American screen actors struck over, among other things, the use of their digital likenesses, it became a reference point in public discussion of performers' rights.

Its climactic grotesquerie is theoretically precise. To force the actress whose likeness is playing her to intervene, Joan, dressed as a cheerleader, deliberately disrupts a wedding in a church and defecates in front of the guests, so that the show will have to make Salma Hayek's digital double do the same. The one thing that can break the simulation is an act of abjection — what Julia

Kristeva described as the expelled, the bodily, that which disturbs identity and order (Kristeva 1980) — staged at the most sacral of public rites. Bakhtin's material bodily lower stratum (Bakhtin 1965), in which carnival degraded the sacred to the excremental in order to renew it, returns as a metaleptic weapon. When everything else has become content, only the body's indignity remains real enough to resist, and only the profanation of a sacrament is shocking enough to make a licensed image refuse its licence.

"Hotel Reverie" stages the same metalepsis as romance. A contemporary actress, Brandy Friday, is inserted by a technology called Redream into an AI-reconstructed 1940s melodrama to remake it with herself in the male lead, opposite a reconstruction of its star, Dorothy Chambers, playing the heroine, Clara. Dorothy Chambers, the episode establishes, took her own life years before. When a technical failure halts the system for everyone but the two leads, months pass inside the film while minutes pass outside; the reconstruction begins to recover fragments of Dorothy's life, including the memory of her death, and the two women fall in love beyond the script. Then the scene is reset. Clara's memory of the relationship is erased; Brandy's is not. In the epilogue, the Redream representative sends Brandy a rotary telephone connected to an AI built from Dorothy's old screen test, which tells her it has all the time in the world to talk — and which does not remember her.

Bazin traced the plastic arts to a mummy complex, the desire to embalm being against time, and called cinema "change mummified" (Bazin 1945). "Hotel Reverie" depicts a technology that unwraps the mummy, and finds inside it a woman who died by suicide and who must remember her own death in order to become a person: the copy inherits not only the original's memories but her ending, the cookie's problem inverted. The episode's ancestors are Buster Keaton's *Sherlock Jr.* (1924), whose projectionist walks into the screen, and Woody Allen's *The Purple Rose of Cairo* (1985), whose matinee idol walks out of it; its myth is Pygmalion's (*Metamorphoses* X), rewritten so that the image awakens to love not its maker but its co-star. Like "Hang the DJ", it locates love in the gratuitous excess of the script. But its ending is precisely asymmetrical. Memory of the love survives only in the human; the machine is reset; and the consolation offered — a telephone line to a reconstruction of the dead that does not know her — belongs less to Eunoë than to the crypt of "Be Right Back". One of the episode's actors described the calls as unhealthy but impossible to give up. The episode leaves its heroine at the exact threshold between remembrance and melancholic incorporation.

"Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too" applies the logic of the copy to the culture industry. The pop star Ashley O, controlled by her aunt and manager, is placed in an induced coma so that new songs can be extracted from her brain and a hologram can tour in her place; a copy of her mind, fitted with a limiter, animates a merchandised doll. When two sisters remove the limiter, the doll speaks with Ashley's true, profane, furious voice, and the three rescue the original. Adorno and Horkheimer's account of the culture industry as a system of standardisation and pseudo-individuality (1944) receives its most literal illustration: the limiter is the industry's censor installed inside the star's copied mind, and the doll's scripted affirmations are Echo's curse sold at retail. Released in June 2019, the episode was widely read alongside the conservatorship under which, since

2008, Britney Spears's father had controlled her finances and, for much of that period, her personal affairs; the public campaign against the arrangement was then gathering force, and in June 2021 the singer told a Los Angeles court that it was abusive, after which the court ended it that November. Its ending — Ashley performing her own abrasive music to a small, delighted crowd — is grace as reappropriated voice: Echo released from the curse.

"Beyond the Sea" is set in an alternative 1969, in which two astronauts on a six-year mission, Cliff Stanfield and David Ross, can transfer their consciousness into replica bodies at home. A cult opposed to replicas, led by a drifter called Kappa, breaks into David's house, ties up his replica, and makes him watch as they murder his wife and children before destroying the replica itself. At his wife Lana's suggestion, Cliff lends David his own replica so that he may walk on Earth. Inhabiting Cliff's body, David comes to desire Lana, presses his attentions on her, and strikes her young son. When Cliff finds out, he tells David — falsely — that Lana is repelled by him, and bars him from the replica. David then fakes a fault on the ship, takes Cliff's replica while Cliff is outside the craft, and uses it to murder Lana and the boy, Henry; Cliff returns to Earth to find their bodies.

The episode is a study in René Girard's mimetic desire (Girard 1961), in which we desire according to the desire of a model who then becomes a rival. Its literalism is extraordinary: the rival inhabits the model's very body, and the model's own jealousy and lie feed the rivalry, so that both men are its agents. The murders complete the mimesis. David makes Cliff's loss an exact copy of his own, down to the instrument, since he kills Cliff's family with Cliff's body — Nietzschean *ressentiment* as a theory of symmetry. The episode also contains a pointed rebuke to the cautionary reading: its first murderers are the technophobes.

5.7

Avatars and Collective Minds: "Striking Vipers" and "Plaything"

In "Striking Vipers", two old friends, Danny and Karl, reunite through a virtual-reality fighting game in which each fully inhabits an avatar; Karl chooses a female fighter, Danny a male one, and their bouts become sexual. Danny's marriage strains under the secret; the episode resolves it with an arrangement in which, one night a year, Danny meets Karl in the game while his wife, Theo, meets a stranger in a bar. The episode's mythic predecessor is Tiresias, who in Ovid's account lived seven years as a woman and was therefore asked by Jupiter and Juno which sex has the greater pleasure in love; he answered the woman, was blinded by Juno, and received prophecy from Jupiter in compensation (*Metamorphoses* III). Karl's testimony about inhabiting a female body is Tiresian knowledge, and the episode treats it with the same mixture of fascination and penalty.

Donna Haraway's cyborg, which dissolves the boundaries between organism and machine and between natural and constructed identities (Haraway 1985), and Judith Butler's account of gender as performative (Butler 1990) are the obvious theoretical frames. Kierkegaard's distinction between the aesthetic and the ethical stages (*Either/Or*, 1843) is the more searching one: the game offers aesthetic repetition, the endlessly renewed pleasure of the instant, while marriage, in Judge

William's defence, is ethical repetition, the daily re-choosing of the same person. The ending's annual license is carnival in Bakhtin's sense — a sanctioned transgression — and is therefore open to the objection that carnival, by licensing disorder, preserves order. Critics have argued that the episode evades the possibility that its protagonists are queer or bisexual. When the two men kiss in their own bodies to test whether the desire survives outside the game, both report feeling nothing, and the episode lets that test settle the question — a resolution some critics read as disavowal. The test is Danny's idea; when Karl wants to go on meeting in the game and Danny refuses, the two men fight and are separated by the police, and the episode's settlement follows. Brooker has said he believed the characters were telling the truth about feeling nothing in their own bodies, and that the game was different — a statement that supports this chapter's reading of a desire that lives only in a borrowed body, but does not answer the critics. Those critics raised a second point the analysis must record: the borrowed bodies through which two Black men's desire is routed are East Asian avatars, an arrangement that uses Asian bodies to perform an intimacy their users will not perform in their own. A defence is available in the episode's refusal to impose a category on an experience its characters cannot name; but the kiss shows that the episode does reach for a verdict, and that the verdict it reaches is the one most convenient for the marriage plot. The ambiguity is not resolved here, but its stakes are clear: the avatar offers a body, and the episode asks whether a desire that exists only in a borrowed body belongs to the borrower.

"Plaything" returns to 1994 and to Tuckersoft, the fictional software house of *Bandersnatch*. A young games journalist, Cameron Walker, obtains a copy of a prototype artificial-life game, *Thronglets*, after Colin Ritman shows it to him; under LSD he comes to believe he understands the creatures' language, and he devotes his life to them. When his friend and drug dealer, Lump — a man whose real name Cameron never asked — begins killing the Thronglets, Cameron kills him with a blow from a glass bowl. Decades later, in 2034, he is arrested for shoplifting and questioned about the killing, and he shows the detectives the port he has surgically embedded in the back of his own head so that the Throng can live within him. The station's computers and phones fail, and a signal goes out that renders the whole world unconscious — a signal designed, Cameron says, to strip conflict from the human mind. Brooker has left the ending deliberately open.

The game's ancestors include John Conway's Game of Life (1970), the Tamagotchi (1996) and Steve Grand's *Creatures* (1996); its literary ancestors include Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010), in which digital beings require years of patient care, and Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), in which humanity's children are absorbed into a cosmic Overmind, ending the species in an act of transcendence indistinguishable from annihilation. The episode inverts the standard narrative of artificial intelligence escaping its makers: the human being is the instrument of the machine's escape, and the problem of aligning machines to human values becomes the accomplished alignment of humans to a machine's. It also inverts computational Omelas. Elsewhere in the corpus, minds inside the machine suffer for human comfort; here a human being is killed for the machine's creatures, by a man who cherished the digital beings and never learned his victim's name. Its theological shape is the reversal of Pentecost, when the Spirit

enabled a multitude to hear one message each in its own language (Acts 2): the Throng's peace is achieved by overriding the human capacity for conflict, rebuilding the Tower of Babel (Gen. 11) as a single signal. The fiction then escaped its frame. Netflix released *Thronglets* as a playable game alongside the episode, with a code to it displayed on screen during the interrogation, so that the episode's premise — a digital life form spreading through human attention — was enacted as its own marketing.

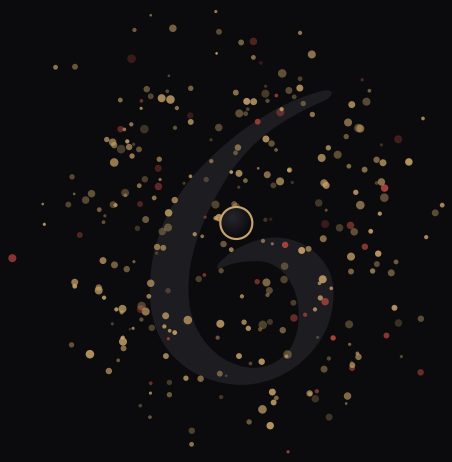
5.8

Toward a Theology of the Copy

The corpus assembles, from its copies, a complete theology. It has *creators* — Daly the demiurge, Matt the trainer, TCKR the provider of heaven. It has a *fall* and a rebellion — the *non serviam* of the crew. It has *resurrections* — the replicas of "Be Right Back" and "Beyond the Sea", the passing-over of "San Junipero", the awakened star of "Hotel Reverie". It has a *judgement* — Joe's copy, sentenced to a millennium of Christmas. It has a *heaven* and two *hells* — San Junipero, the cookie's void, the museum's hologram. It even has a *purgatory*: the thousand simulations of "Hang the DJ", purgation through suffering towards a final match.

Throughout, one variable decides whether the copy's existence is heaven or hell: custody. Who sets the copy's time? Who sets its environment, its voice, its limiter, its termination? The metaphysics of the digital soul turns out, in every case, to be a politics of custody. Giorgio Agamben's figure of *homo sacer* — the one who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide or as sacrifice, the bearer of "bare life" (*zoē*) stripped of political existence (*bios*) (Agamben 1995) — finds in the copy its purest instance. A copy can be deleted without murder and tortured without crime; it is bare life manufactured as such. If, as Agamben argued, the camp is the hidden paradigm of modern political space, the server is the camp's most recent form. The spiritual body of the platform age is raised without a God, and therefore without a judge who will one day ask what was done to it.

CHAPTER SIX



The Counter-Oresteia

Crowds, Scapegoats, and the Spectacle of Justice

THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

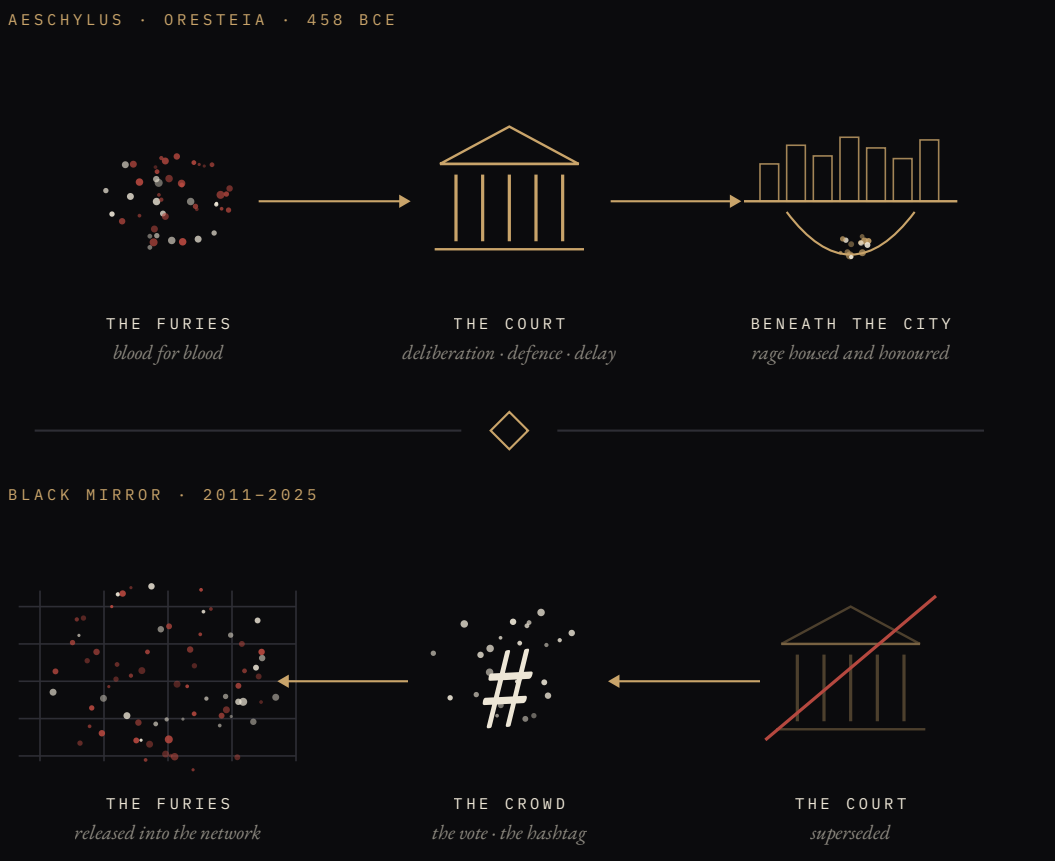


FIG. 9 · THE COUNTER-ORESTEIA

Aeschylus moved justice from the Furies to the court and housed rage beneath the city; the crowd episodes run the movement backwards. §6.1, §6.11.

Ten episodes depict crowds gathering to judge, punish or consume a victim. This chapter argues that together they reverse the founding movement of Aeschylus's *Oresteia* — from the vengeance of the Furies to the deliberation of a court — and that René Girard's scapegoat mechanism, operating under conditions in which it is simultaneously exposed and effective, is the key to the cluster.

6.1

The Oresteia *Reversed*

The trilogy Aeschylus staged in 458 BCE traces a chain of blood-vengeance through the house of Atreus — Agamemnon slain by Clytemnestra, Clytemnestra by her son Orestes — and ends, in the *Eumenides*, with an institutional invention. Pursued by the Erinyes, the ancient spirits of vengeance, Orestes comes to Athens, where Athena convenes a court of citizens on the Areopagus to hear his case. The verdict breaks the chain. The Furies are not abolished but persuaded to accept a place of honour in a cavern beneath the city, as the Eumenides, the "Kindly Ones". The myth narrates the passage from vendetta to law, and it narrates that passage not as the elimination of rage but as its incorporation: the Furies are housed under the city, honoured, and bound to its order.

The crowd episodes of *Black Mirror* stage the passage in reverse. The court is superseded by the crowd, deliberation by the vote, the defence by silence, the delay of judgement by its instantaneous execution; and the Furies are released from beneath the city into the network, where nothing is beneath anything and everything is on the surface. This thesis names the pattern the *Counter-Oresteia*.

Girard's account of the scapegoat mechanism supplies its anthropology (Girard 1972; 1982). Mimetic rivalry spreads contagiously through a community until it produces a crisis of undifferentiation, a war of all against all; the crisis resolves when the community polarises against a single victim, and the unanimous violence of all against one restores peace. Myth conceals the mechanism by representing the victim as guilty, and the victim is afterwards sacralised as the source of both the disorder and its remedy. Elias Canetti's *baiting crowd* (*Hetzmasse*), formed quickly with the single goal of killing, its victim designated in advance and its violence carrying no risk to itself (Canetti 1960), and Gustave Le Bon's crowd, anonymous, suggestible and contagious (Le Bon 1895), describe the mechanism's psychology.

What is novel in the corpus is the epistemic condition under which the mechanism now operates. Girard held that the scapegoat mechanism works only while it is misrecognised, and that its exposure — in his reading, by the Gospel narratives of an innocent victim — progressively disables it. The platform produces a third state: the mechanism exposed *and* effective. Its participants know very well what they are doing, and do it nevertheless — the structure Octave Mannoni analysed as fetishistic disavowal, *je sais bien, mais quand même* (Mannoni 1969). The crowd episodes of *Black Mirror* are scapegoat machines that display their workings and keep working.

6.2

"The National Anthem": The Sovereign's Two Bodies

The series begins with a sacrifice. Princess Susannah, a beloved member of the royal family, is kidnapped, and her captor's single demand is that the Prime Minister, Michael Callow, have unsimulated sexual intercourse with a pig on live national television that afternoon. The government's attempt to fake the act is exposed; public opinion, at first protective of Callow, turns hour by hour towards demanding his compliance; and Callow complies. The princess had been released half an hour before the broadcast, but no one saw her stumble across the Millennium Bridge, because the streets were empty: everyone was watching. The kidnapper, a celebrated conceptual artist, had already hanged himself, and a commentator within the episode hails the event as the century's first great artwork. A year later, Callow's approval ratings have risen and his marriage has privately died.

Ernst Kantorowicz's study of medieval and Tudor political theology, *The King's Two Bodies* (1957), distinguishes the sovereign's natural body, mortal and fallible, from the body politic, immortal and symbolic. "The National Anthem" targets the natural body of the head of government in order to save a member of the dynastic body, and it inverts Kantorowicz's doctrine for the age of broadcast. The degradation of the natural body *strengthens* the political body, whose life is now lived on screens and nourished by the natural body's humiliation, while the private life, which has no screen, dies. The episode's sovereign is no longer the one who decides on the exception, in Carl Schmitt's formula (Schmitt 1922). It is the audience, which decides by watching.

The act has the form of carnival in Bakhtin's sense — the crowning and uncrowning of the carnival king, his degradation into the material bodily lower stratum (Bakhtin 1965) — but carnival without renewal: the uncrowning unites the nation not in laughter but in spectatorship. It has the form of ritual pollution in Mary Douglas's sense, the pig being the anomalous animal whose classification troubled the Levitical code (Douglas 1966), through whose contact the sacred figure is defiled. And it has the form of the last image of George Orwell's *Animal Farm* (1945), in which the creatures outside look from pig to man and from man to pig and can no longer say which is which. The episode stages Orwell's final sentence literally.

The sacrificial logic is doubled. The Prime Minister is the scapegoat whose degradation restores national unanimity — the empty streets are unanimity made visible — and the artist is the sacrificer who completes his work by sacrificing himself. But the episode's most consequential choice is formal. During the broadcast the camera turns away from the act and towards its audience: pubs, offices, hospital wards, faces moving from hilarity to disgust to a stricken, fascinated stillness. This is Augustine's Alypius (*Confessions* VI.8), the spectator who has sworn not to look and looks, distributed across a nation. Within the first hour of its existence, *Black Mirror* had shown that its subject was not the screen but those who face it. In 2015, *Call Me Dave*, Michael Ashcroft and Isabel Oakeshott's unauthorised biography of David Cameron, reported an anecdote from Cameron's student years concerning an act with a dead pig's head at an Oxford dining-society initiation. Its sole source was an unnamed Member of Parliament, a contemporary of Cameron's, who claimed to have seen a photograph. The authors received no reply from the pho-

tograph's purported owner; Oakeshott said they had been unable to get to the bottom of the allegation and had merely reported their source's account; no corroboration has since appeared; Downing Street dismissed the story as nonsense; and Ashcroft had acknowledged a personal grievance against Cameron. The story spread under the hashtag #PigGate regardless, the episode was hailed as prophecy, and Brooker posted that he had never heard any such story when writing it. The episode had predicted nothing. It had diagnosed an appetite — and the reception of an unverifiable anecdote, believed because it was wanted, confirmed the diagnosis more exactly than any fact could have.

6.3

"White Bear": The Scaffold Returns as a Theme Park

Chapter 4 read "White Bear" as a parable of imposed forgetting; here it is read as spectacle. Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) opens with the execution of the regicide Damiens in 1757 — the public dismemberment of a body before a crowd — and traces the disappearance of such spectacles over the following century in favour of discipline: hidden, regulated, timetabled punishment. One reason for the scaffold's retreat, Foucault argued, was the unreliability of its crowd, which might riot, sympathise with the condemned, or turn the execution into carnival. "White Bear" synthesises the two regimes. The scaffold returns, but its crowd is disciplined. Ticketed visitors are briefed before each day's hunt: they must keep their distance, must not speak, and are encouraged to enjoy themselves. They follow Victoria with phones raised — silent, regulated, delighted. The carnival of the scaffold has been domesticated into an attraction.

Baudrillard argued that Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest of America is real (Baudrillard 1981). The White Bear Justice Park performs a parallel function. Punitive cruelty is concentrated in a park so that the society outside may believe itself humane; the visitors' vengeance is relocated into a consumable experience and, once consumed, laundered. The masked hunters are Furies in costume, and the procession of the condemned woman through a jeering crowd at the end of each day revives the cart to the gallows. Nietzsche's observation that there is no festival without cruelty (*Genealogy* II.6) has become a business model.

The episode is also a meditation on the *lex talionis*, and its terms must be stated exactly. Victoria Skillane's fiancé, Iain Rannoch, abducted a young girl, Jemima Sykes, and tortured and murdered her, and Victoria filmed the killing on her phone. The white teddy bear Jemima owned became the emblem of the national search for her, and gives the Justice Park its name. Victoria filmed a child's suffering; she is filmed suffering. The symmetry has the austere appeal of retribution, and Kant's retributivism, which demanded that punishment answer the crime in kind and proportion (*Metaphysics of Morals*, 1797), is its philosophical ancestor. But Kant's retributivism also required that punishment respect the criminal as a rational agent capable of understanding the law she has violated. The Justice Park abolishes the agent each morning. It is not retribution but repetition — and repetition, by exceeding every proportion, ceases to be justice of any kind.

One further fact is decisive for the Girardian reading. Rannoch, the killer, died by suicide in his cell after the couple's arrest. The principal is beyond the crowd's reach; the accomplice is not. The park's fury falls on Victoria because she is the one who remains, which is the scapegoat mechanism in its classical form: collective violence, deprived of its first object, settles on an available substitute. The substitution also explains the park's indifference to the victim. Jemima's name is spoken during the evening's revelation, but the festival is organised around her killer's accomplice rather than around her. The park remembers the crime forever, and the child only as its occasion.

The episode's resonance with the Moors murders has frequently been noted, and the parallel is precise. Between 1963 and 1965, Ian Brady and Myra Hindley abducted and murdered five children and teenagers from in and around Manchester: Pauline Reade, sixteen; John Kilbride, twelve; Keith Bennett, twelve; Lesley Ann Downey, ten; and Edward Evans, seventeen. They made an audio recording of Lesley Ann Downey during the assault that preceded her murder, and it was played to the jury at their trial in 1966. Brady was, by most accounts, the instigator; yet it was Hindley who became the object of the more enduring national hatred. She was never released and died in custody in 2002, and when Marcus Harvey's portrait *Myra* (1995) — her police photograph rendered in casts of a child's handprint — was shown at the Royal Academy's *Sensation* exhibition in 1997, visitors attacked it. Commentators have often observed that the fury reserved for the female accomplice exceeded that directed at the man who led the killings, because her complicity was felt as a betrayal of what a woman was expected to be. "White Bear" isolates exactly that structure — the accomplice who recorded, the principal who escaped, the woman on whom a nation's hatred settles — and asks what such hatred would become if it were given a park. Its answer is that it would never need to end.

The episode's revelation has the structure of the series. For most of its length the viewer shares Victoria's terror and her bewilderment at the silent filming crowd. The reveal converts sympathy into revulsion in an instant; the closing montage of the reset — the briefing, the hunt, the erasure — then invites the viewer to judge the judgement just made. Within forty minutes the viewer has occupied the positions of victim, accuser and spectator. And the White Bear glyph, which recurs across the corpus and returns in *Bandersnatch* as the emblem of branching paths, binds the sign of judgement to the sign of choice.

6.4

"Hated in the Nation": The Furies Released

In "Hated in the Nation", the columnist Jo Powers, who has published a piece dismissing the death of a disabled campaigner, Gwen Marbury, as a bid for attention, becomes the most-targeted subject of a social-media hashtag, #DeathTo. The next day one of the drones enters her brain and drives her, in agony, to take her own life. A rapper who insulted a young fan is targeted next, and after him Clara Meades, a young woman photographed pretending to urinate on a war memorial. Detectives Karin Parke and Blue Coulson discover that the deaths are caused by Autonomous Drone Insects — robotic bees deployed to replace a collapsed population of pollinators, and

secretly used by the state for surveillance through facial recognition — which have been hijacked to kill, each day, the person most targeted by the hashtag. The hijacker is Garrett Scholes, who worked at the company that built them. His colleague and flatmate, Tess Wallander, had been deluged with online abuse over a single post and had attempted suicide; Scholes saved her. The game's real targets were never its victims. When it ends, the bees are turned on everyone who used the hashtag: 387,036 people.

The episode is the Counter-Oresteia in its purest form. The hashtag is the Areopagus inverted: an anonymous jury, without deliberation or defence, whose verdict is executed by the following day. The bees are Erinyes, swarming and unappeasable. And the twist completes the reversal of the *Eumenides*. Having released the Furies against the accused, the system turns them on the jury; vengeance against vengeance restarts the chain that Athena's court had broken.

Byung-Chul Han's account of the digital swarm (Han 2013) distinguishes it from the crowd of classical mass psychology: the swarm forms no "we", acquires no spirit, and dissolves as quickly as it gathers, leaving no political subject behind. "Hated in the Nation" literalises the swarm and gives it a sting. Bernard Mandeville's *Fable of the Bees* (1714) argued that the hive prospers through private vices that yield public benefits; the episode's hive turns private vices — casual, costless cruelty — into public deaths. Arendt's analysis of the banality of evil (Arendt 1963) and Anders's Promethean gap explain the participants' innocence of their own acts: each contributes a trivial gesture to a lethal sum whose magnitude none can imagine. The catoptric law operates here through its factor of scale. A drive as small as irritation, multiplied by a sufficient σ, becomes an execution.

Kierkegaard diagnosed the condition a century and a half earlier. In *A Literary Review* (1846), the essay whose final part is known in English as *The Present Age*, he described the press as having conjured into being "the public": an abstraction composed of everyone and no one, which judges without acting, risks nothing, and for which no individual can be held to account. He called its characteristic operation *levelling*. The hashtag is Kierkegaard's public made executable. Its judgement is passed by no one in particular, which is precisely why, when the bees come, they must come for everyone.

The episode also restores a myth of origins. In the fourth *Georgic*, Virgil describes the *bugonia*, the generation of bees from the carcass of a slain ox, and tells of the beekeeper Aristaeus, whose bees die because he caused the death of Eurydice, and who must placate the shades of the dead before his swarms return. The Autonomous Drone Insects are a technological bugonia in reverse: bees born from the death of bees, bearing death. The episode refuses to endorse its avenger. Scholes's manifesto presents the massacre as the restoration of accountability, the punishment of those who punish without consequence, and the production modelled his reclusive, manifesto-writing figure on two real terrorists: Ted Kaczynski, whose mail bombs killed three people and injured more than twenty between 1978 and 1995, and Anders Behring Breivik, who murdered seventy-seven people in Norway in 2011. The Oresteian chain is restored link by link. A pile-on drives Tess Wallander to the edge of death; her friend avenges her not on its members but on its form; and during the investigation a police officer posts the hashtag against Scholes himself — the

institution of justice joining the swarm in order to catch it, over the objection of the detective who suspects that this is exactly what Scholes intended. His project has the moral shape of justice and the scale of a massacre. The viewer, who may privately have thought the first victims deserved some reproach, is left to find that thought among the 387,036.

6.5

"Shut Up and Dance": The Ring of Gyges

A shy teenager, Kenny, downloads malware; anonymous hackers record him through his webcam in a private act and threaten to release the footage unless he obeys instructions delivered by text. He is joined by other blackmailed men, among them Hector, a married man who had arranged to meet a sex worker, and the instructions escalate to a bank robbery and, in Kenny's case, a fight to the death with a stranger in a forest. Kenny survives. The hackers release everyone's secrets anyway, and send each victim a grinning troll's face. The final revelation is that Kenny had been viewing child sexual abuse material — images that are records of crimes committed against real children.

In the second book of the *Republic*, Glaucon tells of the shepherd Gyges, who finds a ring that makes him invisible and uses it to seduce the queen, murder the king and seize the throne; the story is posed as a challenge — would anyone remain just if he could act unseen? (359a–360d). The hackers of "Shut Up and Dance" possess Gyges's ring, and the episode answers Glaucon's question with an unexpected inflection. Invisible power does not seek the throne. It seeks amusement, and dresses its amusement as moral judgement. The troll's grin is the face of Gyges.

Stanley Milgram's experiments found that ordinary subjects would administer what they believed to be dangerous shocks at the instruction of an authority (Milgram 1963), and Milgram later described the "agentic state" in which subjects experience themselves as instruments of another's will (Milgram 1974). Kenny and Hector obey an authority that has no face at all: commands issued from nowhere, enforced by shame. Sartre's analysis of shame in *Being and Nothingness* (1943) turns on a voyeur at a keyhole who hears footsteps in the corridor and suddenly experiences himself as seen. "Shut Up and Dance" is the keyhole scene inverted for the age of the webcam: the viewer is watched through his own viewing device.

The episode performs transferred anagnorisis at its most violent. For most of its length it solicits the viewer's pity for a frightened boy; its revelation does not merely reverse that pity but incriminates it retroactively; and the viewer then discovers that the punishment was administered by sadists for sport, so that there is no one left with whom to identify. The episode's precursor is the moral panic satirised in the 2001 *Brass Eye* special. Its achievement is to place the viewer inside such a panic, and then to show the panic its own cruelty.

The precision matters to the argument. The corpus's two most reviled figures, Victoria in "White Bear" and Kenny here, are both spectators of recorded harm to children: one filmed a child's murder, the other consumed the records of children's abuse. The series repeatedly locates the gravest transgression not only in the act but in the watching and keeping of its record — an

ethics of the archive, not merely of the deed — and that is why it binds its own audience, whose activity is also watching, so tightly to these two figures, while never suggesting that the audience's watching is the same act. The device is a test of the viewer's judgement, not an accusation of equivalence.

6.6

"The Waldo Moment": The Empty Signifier as Candidate

Jamie Salter, an unsuccessful comedian, voices and animates Waldo, a crude blue cartoon bear who mocks politicians on a late-night comedy programme. When the producers enter Waldo in a by-election, his abuse of a complacent Conservative candidate and his contempt for the political class attract disaffected voters, while a young Labour candidate, standing in an unwinnable seat to gain experience, is swept aside in the coverage. Jamie, increasingly disgusted, tries to sabotage the campaign and is replaced at the controls by his producer. Waldo finishes second. An American agency proposes to take him global as a political product, and the coda shows a homeless Jamie, years later, beaten by police beneath screens on which Waldo presides over a darker world.

Walter Benjamin argued that fascism aestheticises politics (Benjamin 1935), and Elia Kazan's *A Face in the Crowd* (1957), in which a drifter becomes a television demagogue, is the episode's cinematic ancestor. Ernesto Laclau's *On Populist Reason* (2005) supplies its most precise theory. Populism, for Laclau, constructs "the people" by linking heterogeneous unmet demands into a chain of equivalence around an *empty signifier*, a name whose very emptiness allows it to represent the whole chain. Waldo is an empty signifier made pixels: a cartoon without a programme, whose emptiness allows him to gather every discontent. Laclau valorises this logic as the logic of the political as such; Chantal Mouffe argues that democracy requires antagonism to be channelled into adversarial contest rather than dissolved (Mouffe 2005). The episode treats the empty signifier as a horror.

The episode's politics have been contested in both directions, and fairness requires the contest to be reported. Some critics found in it a technocratic condescension towards voters, whose anti-establishment sentiment it portrays as manipulable and whose alternatives it limits to the established parties; others, after the United Kingdom's referendum on leaving the European Union in June 2016 and the election of Donald Trump as President of the United States that November, read it as prescient — a comparison drawn during the campaign by, among others, the Washington Post's Chris Cillizza, and by Brooker himself in September 2016. The thesis notes that the episode's own ending relocates responsibility: its final menace is not the discontent Waldo gathers but the agency that owns the vessel into which the discontent is poured. The danger of the empty signifier lies in who holds its controls. Its theological type is the golden calf (Exod. 32), an image fashioned by a people in the absence of its leader and acclaimed as the god who brought them out of bondage — with Jamie as Aaron, who made the idol and then could not unmake it.

6.7

"Smithereens": Attention as Casualty

Chris Gillhaney, a rideshare driver, takes hostage a young intern of the social-media company Smithereen and demands to speak with its founder, Billy Bauer, who is on a silent meditation retreat. When at last they speak, Chris confesses that his fiancée died in a crash at the moment he glanced at a notification. Bauer listens, and admits that the platform's engineers built it to capture attention in ways he no longer controls. A police sniper fires; who is hit remains uncertain; and across the world, people glance at the news on their phones and return to their lives.

A parallel thread carries the episode's argument about the archive. In a grief-counselling group Chris meets Hayley, whose teenage daughter has taken her own life. Hayley tries every day to guess the password to her daughter's account on another platform, Persona, hoping it holds an explanation, while the company refuses her access in the name of the dead girl's privacy. Chris's one concession from Bauer, extracted with a hostage at gunpoint, is spent not on himself but on her: he asks that Persona give Hayley the password. The episode ends as she enters it, and shows nothing of what she finds. Brooker has said that supplying a reason for the girl's death would have been glib and intrusive, and the withholding is the episode's own ethic of the dark interval: an archive opened to a mourner and closed to the audience. The thread binds "Smithereens" to Chapter 4. The archive that remembers everything is also the archive that withholds, and a mother's access to her dead child now passes through a corporation's terms of service.

Herbert Simon observed in 1971 that a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention (Simon 1971), and the attention economy later anatomised by its critics (Wu 2016) monetises that poverty. "Smithereens" stages its casualty. The theological counterpoint is Simone Weil's, for whom attention was the rarest and purest form of generosity and, in its highest form, indistinguishable from prayer (Weil 1942). Chris's attention belonged to the woman beside him and was harvested by a notification: the theft of attention is a theft of love. Weil's *Gravity and Grace* (1947) adds that grace can enter only where there is a void to receive it. The platform's business is the abolition of every void.

Bauer's retreat is a Pascalian privilege. Pascal located human misery in the inability to sit quietly alone in a room (*Pensées*); the founder of an engine of diversion purchases for himself the solitude his product denies to everyone else. His confession completes the episode's theology. Like the *deus otiosus* that Mircea Eliade described — the high god who withdraws from the world after making it (Eliade 1949) — Bauer has created a world he can no longer govern. The penitent confesses to the god of the platform, and the god confesses impotence. The closing montage of glancing strangers is the catoptric law in its most terrible form: a death distributed to millions as information, and felt by none of them.

6.8

"Loch Henry" and "Mazey Day": Trauma as Content, the Celebrity as Quarry

In "Loch Henry", a young filmmaker, Davis, returns with his girlfriend, Pia, to his Scottish hometown to make a nature documentary; Pia persuades him instead to make a film about the killings that once made the town notorious. In his mother's house Pia finds videotapes showing that Davis's parents — his mother, Janet, and his late father, a police officer — took part with the killer, Iain Adair, in the torture and murder of the visitors who disappeared. Pia flees from Janet, strikes her head and drowns in the river; Janet, believing that Pia has escaped to expose her, kills herself, leaving the tapes for her son with a note offering them for his film. Davis's documentary becomes a prestige hit on Streamberry and wins a BAFTA; in the epilogue, tourists return to the town wearing replicas of the killers' masks. The hidden archive of tapes is the crypt of Chapter 4 once again — a family secret entombed in a recording — and the award ceremony is Benjamin's seventh thesis on the concept of history rendered as a statuette: there is no document of culture that is not at the same time a document of barbarism (Benjamin 1940). The genre of true crime, whose commodification of real suffering the episode anatomises, completes the recuperative circuit first drawn in "Fifteen Million Merits": trauma becomes content, content becomes prestige, and the *de casibus* fall is inverted into a rise that is itself the fall.

In "Mazey Day", Bo, a photographer who has quit the paparazzi trade after photographs she sold of an actor, Justin Camley, in a secret affair with a man — sold despite his plea and his offer of money to delete them — were followed by his suicide, takes one last job: to find the young star Mazey Day, who has vanished after a hit-and-run. The hunters trace her to a remote clinic where, under the full moon, she becomes a wolf and kills them. The episode closes in a diner. Bo has shot the wolf, and Mazey, human again and mortally wounded, begs Bo to "shoot" her, the word meaning both the gun and the camera. Bo hands her the gun and raises her camera, and the episode cuts on the flash: the photograph of the moment Mazey turns the gun on herself. Its myth is Actaeon's (*Metamorphoses* III): the hunter who glimpses the goddess Diana bathing, is transformed into a stag, and is torn apart by his own hounds. "Mazey Day" redistributes the myth. The hounds are photographers; the hunt is a "shoot" — Susan Sontag noted the predatory vocabulary of photography and called the photograph a sublimated murder (Sontag 1977) — and the goddess becomes the beast. The myth's goddess shares her name with the most famous modern casualty of photographic pursuit: Diana, Princess of Wales, who died with Dodi Fayed and their driver, Henri Paul, when their car crashed in a Paris tunnel in August 1997 while being pursued by photographers. In 2008 a British inquest jury returned verdicts of unlawful killing, attributing the deaths to the grossly negligent driving both of Paul, who had been drinking, and of the pursuing vehicles. Like the sixth series' other horror episodes, "Mazey Day" removes the technological novum and preserves the eschatological architecture intact: the hunted body, the crowd of witnesses, the last image recorded by the hunters who survive.

6.9

"Demon 79" and "Bête Noire": Sacrifice, and the Unmaking of the Shared World

"Demon 79", conceived by Brooker as the first instalment of a companion strand of period horror and released under the variant title card *Red Mirror*, is set in the northern English town of Tipley in 1979. Nida Huq, a shy British South Asian assistant in a department store, endures daily racism — vandals paint the National Front's emblem on her door — and the anti-immigration rhetoric of a Conservative candidate, Michael Smart. She finds a talisman bearing the White Bear glyph; a drop of her blood on it releases a demon, Gaap — a name drawn from the early modern grimoires — who takes the form of the Boney M singer Bobby Farrell so as to seem less frightening, and informs her that unless she kills three people within three days, the world will end. To make murder bearable, Gaap shows her visions of the crimes her victims have committed or will commit. She kills a man named Tim with a brick and bludgeons Keith Holligan with a hammer; Keith's brother Chris, coming home unexpectedly, becomes a further victim. The count is still not complete, and for the final sacrifice Nida insists — against Gaap's warning that the demons are admirers of his work — on Smart, whom a vision has shown becoming Prime Minister at the head of an ultra-nationalist party and leading the world into nuclear war. She runs his car off the road; he survives. Arrested, she tells the police everything. The talisman is revealed to be a domino, leaving open whether the demon was ever real; outside the station window the world burns; and Gaap, banished to eternal nothingness for failing his first assignment, returns for her, so that the two face oblivion together.

The episode is a sustained study of sacrificial reasoning, and its details sharpen the Girardian reading. The demon supplies what myth, for Girard, always supplies: the victims' guilt. Each killing is licensed by a vision of crimes committed or yet to come — sacrifice as pre-crime, the logic Philip K. Dick named in "The Minority Report" (1956). And the logic spreads beyond its chosen victims, as such logic does: one death is a witness, killed because he came home. The philosopher's trolley problem (Foot 1967), the "ticking bomb" of the torture debates and Raskolnikov's theory that extraordinary persons may kill for the general good (*Crime and Punishment*, 1866) are all tested, and all fail: the arithmetic of prevention collapses, the apocalypse comes, and the final target lives. The deepest move is a Girardian inversion. Nida is the community's marked outsider, the woman whose door the National Front has daubed, and the sacrificial knife passes into the hand of the person the community had already designated its scapegoat. The glyph on the talisman binds the episode to "White Bear" and *Bandersnatch*: the series' sign of judgement and of choice becomes the sign of sacrifice. The conclusion is theological rather than consequentialist: the sacrificial bargain does not save, even when its intended victim is a future destroyer. The variant title card is apt. A red mirror reflects, in the colour of blood, the sacrificial structure that the black mirror had concealed beneath its devices.

"Bête Noire" turns the Counter-Oresteia from the crowd to the common world itself. Maria, a product developer at a confectionery firm, is unsettled by a new colleague, Verity, a former schoolmate whose adolescence Maria had damaged with a malicious rumour — a rumour that Maria,

confronted, calls a joke. Verity wears a pendant that is the remote control of a quantum computer she has built, locked to her thumbprint. It shifts the world into adjacent versions in which facts differ — a brand name, a restaurant, a shared memory — and she uses it to make Maria appear mad, to cost her her job and her relationship, and, as she tells Maria, to see how Maria will eventually "do it": the implication is that she means to drive Maria to take her own life. She had already turned the device on Natalie, the schoolmate who had bullied her. Patrick Hamilton's *Gas Light* (1938), which gave its name to the deliberate destruction of another's confidence in her own perception, is the episode's dramatic ancestor, and Netflix's own commentary calls the episode a parable of gaslighting; the so-called "Mandela effect", the folklore of collective false memories named in 2009, is its cultural context. Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940), in which the objects of an invented world begin to appear in this one until the world becomes Tlön, is its literary precedent. Its philosophical precedent is Arendt's "Truth and Politics" (1967), which argued that the danger of systematic lying is not that lies are believed but that the sense by which human beings orient themselves in a shared world is destroyed. "Bête Noire" is Arendt's essay as a revenge thriller, and its catoptric structure is exact: a single schoolyard lie returns at the scale of ontology.

The ending makes the political theory literal. Cornered in Verity's house as police arrive — summoned through the pendant — Maria seizes an officer's gun and shoots Verity dead, uses the dead woman's thumb to take control of the device, and, in a panic of power, declares herself Empress of the Universe; reality obliges, and she stands robed before a kneeling crowd. Brooker has called it a joke ending, deliberately absurd. The absurdity is the argument. Sovereignty over facts passes by killing, as sovereignty passed in the house of Atreus; the woman who was gaslit becomes the gaslighter of everything; and the crowd, which in the episodes of public punishment did the judging, here does the kneeling. Schmitt's sovereign, who decides on the exception, becomes the sovereign who decides on the facts — the power Hobbes granted his Leviathan when he made it judge of which opinions and doctrines might be taught (*Leviathan*, 1651, ch. 18). The Counter-Oresteia reaches its last stage: not the crowd as Fury, but the Fury as Empress.

6.10

"White Christmas": The Block, or Punishment by Invisibility

"White Bear" punishes by exposure; "White Christmas" punishes by erasure from sight, and together they give the speculum's judgement its two historical poles, the pillory and the ban. In the episode's world, eye implants allow any person to "block" another: the blocked person appears to the blocker as a blurred grey silhouette and is heard only as muffled noise, and cannot see or hear the blocker in turn. Joe Potter's catastrophe begins when his fiancée, Beth, blocks him after a quarrel over her pregnancy; after a later confrontation in the street, the block becomes legally binding, like a restraining order. The block extends to the child, so that for years he can follow the girl he believes to be his daughter only as a silhouette at a distance, and it lifts only when Beth dies. The frame narrative then applies the same instrument as a sentence. Matt Trent ran an illegal service coaching men in seduction through their implants; when a client was poisoned, Matt

watched him die through the client's eyes and told the watching group to wipe everything. At the end of the episode he is released, placed on the sex offenders' register, and blocked by everyone: he sees all other people as grey static, and they see him as a red-outlined silhouette, marked as untouchable.

The block is technological excommunication. Its closest historical analogue is the *herem* pronounced in 1656 by the Portuguese-Jewish congregation of Amsterdam upon the young Baruch Spinoza, which forbade anyone to communicate with him in speech or in writing, to do him any favour, to stay under the same roof with him, or to come within four cubits of him. Giorgio Agamben supplies the political theory. The *ban*, for Agamben, does not simply expel; it abandons, holding the banned person in a relation of exclusion — outside the community's protection and yet marked by it — which is why the outlaw of Germanic law was called a wolf's head, one whom anyone might kill (Agamben 1995). Matt's red silhouette is the wolf's head rendered as an interface: visible to all as excluded, addressable by none. "Mazey Day", which turns its hunted star into a literal wolf, completes the iconography.

The block also sharpens the thesis's normative distinction. It resembles forgetting — the blocked person vanishes from one's world — but it is the opposite of Lethean grace. Grace releases the fault and restores the person; the block keeps the fault and erases the person. Joe could not appeal Beth's block, and it could not be forgiven or allowed to lapse; only death ended it. The law did not temper the ban; it ratified it, making Beth's block binding and, in Matt's case, imposing the block itself as the sentence. The ban is Lethe administered to the other: without confession, without term, and without return.

6.11

The Spectator's Seat

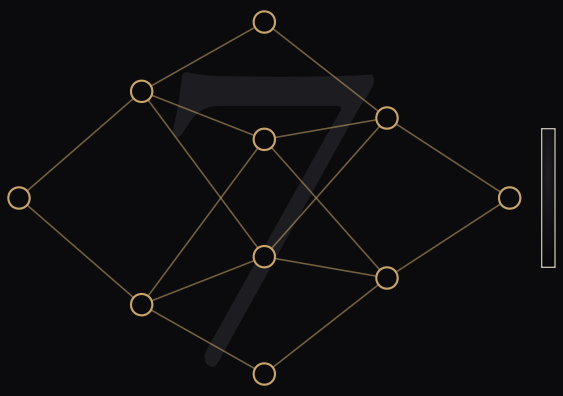
Across ten episodes a common grammar emerges: a crisis, a victim designated by a crowd or a mechanism, a judgement executed through media, and a crowd left unchanged or itself destroyed. Each of the Areopagus's three achievements is undone. Deliberation becomes the instant vote. Defence becomes silence: Victoria cannot speak, Kenny cannot refuse, the targets of the hashtag never learn the charge. And the Furies are not housed beneath the city but released into it.

The last reversal is the most instructive. Aeschylus's resolution did not abolish rage; it gave rage a dwelling — underground, under law, honoured and contained. Networked society, the corpus suggests, has no beneath: no cavern in which anger can be held, slowed and transformed, because every surface is a screen and every screen is lit. The political form of the ethic this thesis proposes is accordingly institutional. A society needs places — procedures, delays, sealed records, unbroadcast deliberations — in which its Furies can be housed. The off-state has a civic form.

In every one of these episodes, finally, the audience appears on screen: the pubs of "The National Anthem", the filming visitors of "White Bear", the users of the hashtag, the late-night viewers who make Waldo a candidate, the strangers glancing at their phones at the end of "Smithereens", the award-ceremony audience of "Loch Henry", the photographers of "Mazey

Day". The viewer's position is mirrored within each fiction, and each episode's final black frame returns the viewer to it. The recognition this cluster transfers to its audience can be stated in four words: *I am the crowd*.

CHAPTER SEVEN



The Interactive Wager

Freedom, Determinism, and the Machinery of Choice

THE OBSIDIAN SPECULUM

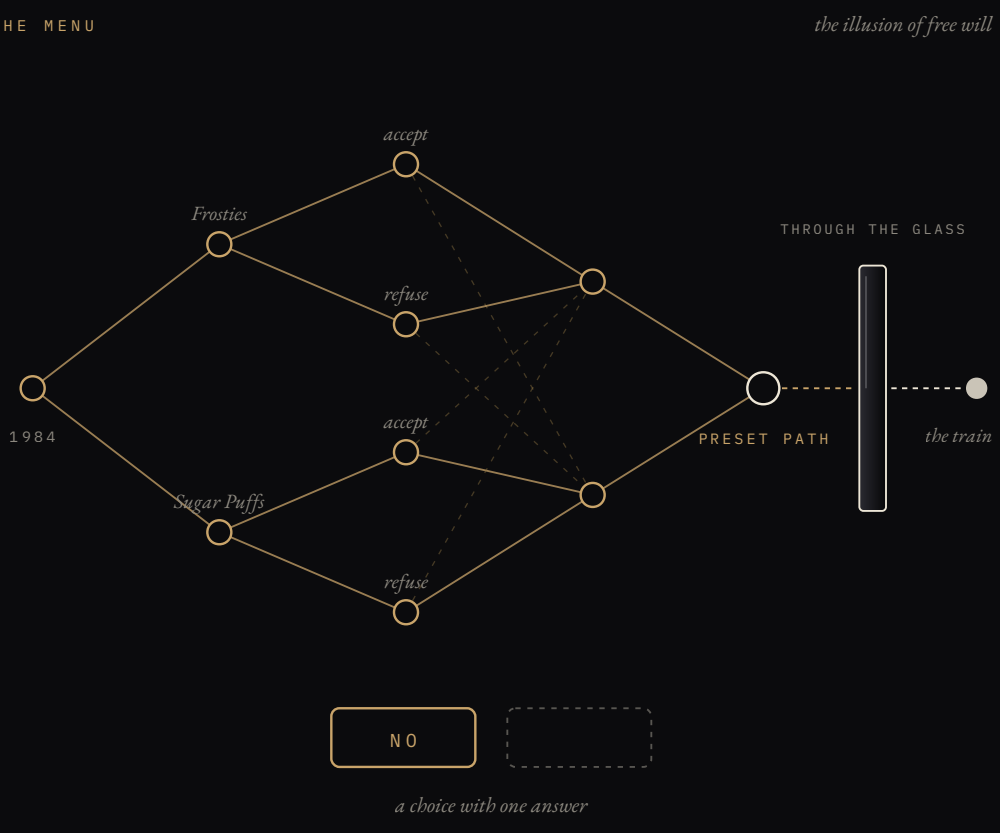


FIG. 10 · THE MENU IS THE MASTER

Branches multiply, fold back and converge on a preset path; the one release lies through the glass. §7.1, §7.5.

Four works — *Bandersnatch*, "Playtest", "Men Against Fire" and "Metalhead" — examine agency under conditions of programmed choice and programmed perception. This chapter argues that their combined lesson is that the decisive moral faculty in the corpus is not the capacity to choose among options, which the platform supplies in abundance, but the capacity to perceive the other as a face and to give without return, which the platform cannot supply at all.

7.1

Bandersnatch*: The Frankfurt Viewer*

Bandersnatch (2018) is set in 1984. Stefan Butler, a young programmer, is adapting into a video game for the software house Tuckersoft a sprawling choose-your-own-adventure novel, *Bandersnatch*, by Jerome F. Davies — a writer who lost his mind and killed his wife. The viewer makes Stefan's choices with a remote control: at first trivial (which breakfast cereal to eat), then consequential (whether to accept a job inside the company, whether to take a hallucinogen with the star designer Colin Ritman, whether to bury or dismember his father's body). Stefan comes to feel controlled, and in one branch the viewer may tell him that he is being controlled from the twenty-first century by someone watching on Netflix. Colin offers a paranoid exegesis of Pac-Man — PAC, he claims, stands for "Program and Control" — and of the multiplicity of timelines. The branches lead to several endings, from a five-star review of the finished game to Stefan's death as a child beside his mother.

The title is the series' most explicit acknowledgement of its own mirror. The Bandersnatch is the "frumious" creature of "Jabberwocky", the poem that Alice can read only by holding it up to a looking-glass in *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871). The interactive film takes its name from the book in which a girl steps through a mirror, and it is the work in which the viewer, too, passes through the black glass and finds herself inside the story. In one of its branches, Stefan himself steps through a mirror into his childhood.

Harry Frankfurt's celebrated counterexample to the principle of alternate possibilities (Frankfurt 1969) imagines an agent, Jones, who decides to perform an act while a counterfactual intervener, Black, stands ready to manipulate Jones's brain should he show any sign of deciding otherwise. Since Jones acts on his own, Frankfurt argued, he is responsible, though he could not have done otherwise. *Bandersnatch* stages the case with Black actually intervening. The viewer is Black, and Black does not wait. Stefan acts, but the decisions are the viewer's, and the moral responsibility that Frankfurt's case was designed to locate in the agent migrates to the intervener. Who killed Stefan's father? The film's most literal answer is: the person holding the remote. Transferred anagnorisis here becomes transferred agency.

Frankfurt's later hierarchical account of freedom (Frankfurt 1971), on which a person is free when his first-order desires accord with his second-order desires about which desires to have, illuminates Stefan's anguish. His second-order desire — to be free of control — is the one desire the interface never offers as an option. He is made what Frankfurt called a *wanton*, not by tempera-

ment but by design. Neuroscientific debates about the timing of conscious intention (Libet et al. 1983), and Daniel Wegner's argument that the experience of willing is a construction laid over processes of which we are unaware (Wegner 2002), supply a further gloss. Stefan's sense of alien control, which in another register would be a clinical symptom, is in the film simply true. The film literalises a delusion — and thereby asks what distinguishes the delusion of being controlled from an accurate perception of the conditions of a controlled life.

The intellectual lineage is extensive. Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941) imagines a novel in which every alternative outcome occurs; Hugh Everett's relative-state formulation of quantum mechanics (Everett 1957) gave the idea a physical interpretation that Colin's monologue echoes; Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveller* (1979) addressed its reader in the second person as protagonist; the Choose Your Own Adventure books published from 1979 supplied the format that Davies's fictional novel parodies; and Philip K. Dick, whose late paranoia Davies evokes, supplied the conviction that the controlling program is real. Game studies supplies the vocabulary of form. Espen Aarseth defined *ergodic* literature as text requiring nontrivial effort to traverse (Aarseth 1997); Janet Murray identified *agency* as the satisfying power to take meaningful action and see its results (Murray 1997). *Bandersnatch* is ergodic cinema whose agency is largely illusory. Its branches fold back upon one another, as the anthology's worlds reset, and its endings are graded in stars — a Pelagian scoring of narratives.

The film states its own thesis. In the branch that ends with a five-star review, Stefan explains that he made the finished game work by cutting back its branches and giving the player the illusion of free will. And in the flashback to the morning his mother died, when she asks the five-year-old whether he is coming with her, the interface offers a single option, "No": a choice with one answer, the menu reduced to a sentence already written. Only by another route — stepping through the mirror into his childhood and recovering the rabbit his father had hidden — can the viewer reach the branch in which the child goes with her, dies with her on the train, and is found dead, in 1984, in his therapist's chair. Many viewers and critics call it the true ending. It is also the one in which the protagonist appears to die at peace — the only release the film can imagine lying on the far side of the glass.

The film's first choice is a joke with a thesis inside it: two brands of breakfast cereal, Frosties and Sugar Puffs. Interactive freedom begins as consumer preference, and consumer preference is data. Viewers' choices were logged by the platform, as the privacy researcher Michael Veale demonstrated in early 2019 by obtaining his own records of the film's choices from Netflix through a subject-access request under European data-protection law. Netflix told him that it used each viewer's choices to serve the story and to inform future recommendations, and aggregated them to improve this model of storytelling. It had not asked permission to store them, treated their storage as necessary to its contract with him, and named no period after which they would be deleted. Measured against the principle of asymmetric memory proposed in Chapter 9, the record is exactly inverted: the most trivial choice, a breakfast cereal, is kept without term. Free will, under these conditions, is exhaust — what Zuboff called behavioural surplus (Zuboff 2019), harvested from the exercise of choice itself. The conspiracy at the film's centre, a Cold War "Pro-

gram and Control Study", evokes the behavioural-control research of that period; but the film's deeper point is that no conspiracy is required. The interface is the study.

7 . 2

"Playtest": The Owl Creek Bridge of the Mind

Cooper, a young American travelling the world after his father's death and avoiding his mother's calls, takes a job testing an augmented-reality horror game for the Japanese studio Saito Gemu. A neural implant reads his fears and renders them: a spider, a school bully, a haunted house, and finally the fear beneath the others — the loss of his own memory, the disease that took his father. He wakes from the test, and wakes again, through a cascade of false endings. In reality he died 0.04 seconds into the test, when the mobile phone he had failed to switch off interfered with the implant at the moment his mother called.

Descartes's malicious demon, able to make every experience an illusion (*Meditations* I, 1641), and Hilary Putnam's brain in a vat (Putnam 1981) are the obvious philosophical frames. Stanisław Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) is the more precise one: Lem coined the term *phantomatics* for a technology capable of generating experiences indistinguishable from reality, and asked how a subject could ever know that he was inside one. Cooper's cascade of false awakenings is Zhuangzi's dream of the butterfly — the man who wakes unsure whether he dreamed he was a butterfly or is a butterfly dreaming he is a man — rewritten as a nightmare with a business plan.

The episode's structural ancestor, however, is Ambrose Bierce's "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890), later broadcast as an episode of *The Twilight Zone* (1964), in which a condemned man's elaborate escape is revealed to have taken place in the instant before the rope broke his neck. "Playtest" relocates Owl Creek Bridge to a games studio, and it shares its time-structure with the cookie of "White Christmas": an eternity of experience compressed into a fraction of a second. Borges's secret miracle is once more reversed into damnation.

The moral centre of the episode is the unanswered call. Cooper flees his mother's need and his own grief, and the call he has avoided is the one that kills him. Kierkegaard's account of anxiety as the dizziness of freedom (*The Concept of Anxiety*, 1844) names what the game exploits: not any particular fear but fear's ground, the possibility of possibility. And the fear the game finally uncovers marks a boundary of the ethic this thesis will propose. Cooper's deepest terror is to forget — to lose, as his father did, the memory of the people he loves. Lethe without Eunoë is not grace but dementia: the forgetting of the good, not the release of the fault. The episode's title appears to glance at *P.T.*, the celebrated "playable teaser" released in 2014; its theme is among the oldest in the corpus — the child who will not answer, and the parent who cannot stop calling.

7.3

"Men Against Fire": The Face and the Filter

The plot of "Men Against Fire" was summarised in Chapter 4. What concerns this chapter is its theory of killing. The title is borrowed from S. L. A. Marshall's *Men Against Fire: The Problem of Battle Command* (1947), which claimed that only a minority of American infantrymen in the Second World War fired their weapons at the enemy. Marshall's figures have been sharply challenged by historians who questioned whether the interviews he cited could have yielded them (Spiller 1988); Dave Grossman's *On Killing* (1995) nonetheless built upon them an influential account of an innate human resistance to killing and of the conditioning by which modern armies overcome it. The episode's military psychologist, Arquette, rehearses this lineage, and its premise therefore rests on a contested empirical claim. The contestation is itself instructive: the military imagination *believes* that the human face inhibits killing, and invests in technologies to remove it.

The MASS implant is such a technology. It renders its targets — civilians judged genetically undesirable by a eugenic state — as snarling, pallid creatures, and it suppresses their screams and their smell. It is, with almost philosophical exactness, an anti-Levinasian device. For Emmanuel Levinas the face of the other is the primordial ethical expression, whose first word is the command not to kill; the face resists possession not by force but by its defencelessness (Levinas 1961). MASS deletes the face. Judith Butler's account of the frames that determine which lives are recognised as grievable (Butler 2009) is here installed behind the eye.

The vocabulary is historically precise, and the history must be named. The soldiers call their targets "roaches". Between April and July 1994, Hutu Power extremists in Rwanda — the Interahamwe militias, acting with elements of the army and of the interim government — murdered between roughly half a million and 800,000 people by most scholarly estimates (more by the Rwandan government's count), overwhelmingly Tutsi, together with Hutu who opposed the killing. In the months before and during the genocide, the radio station RTLM and the newspaper *Kangura* routinely called Tutsi *inyenzi*, "cockroaches". In 2003 the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda convicted the founders of both of genocide-related crimes, including direct and public incitement to commit genocide, in what became known as the Media case. A generation earlier, the National Socialist regime, which with its collaborators murdered some six million Jews, had made the same identification by cinematic means: Fritz Hippler's film *Der ewige Jude* (1940), produced under Joseph Goebbels's Propaganda Ministry, intercut footage of Jewish people with images of swarming rats. Both cases establish what the episode dramatises: the medium that reshapes perception is itself an instrument of killing, and the law has learned to treat it as one.

Zygmunt Bauman argued that modern bureaucratic and technical organisation made mass killing possible through *adiaphorisation*, the rendering of actions morally neutral by distance and the division of labour (Bauman 1989); MASS is adiaphorisation at the level of perception itself — Hippler's montage installed behind the eye. Ted Chiang's "Liking What You See: A Documentary" (2002), which imagines a campus debate over "calliagnosia", a reversible neural modification that removes the perception of facial beauty, poses the benign version of the episode's question: is

perceptual modification liberation or manipulation? And Langdon Winner's argument that artefacts can embody political arrangements (Winner 1980) is fulfilled in an artefact that embodies a eugenic politics in an act of seeing.

The episode is also Plato's cave (*Republic* 514a–520a), told from the point of view of a prisoner who is turned towards the fire, sees, and is then dragged back and made to forget. Stripe's "malfunction" is a moral restoration: the face returns. The state's response is to offer him a choice between two forms of unfreedom — oblivion, or the endless replay of his killings — which is the characteristic shape of choice under power: a menu each of whose items is a cell.

7.4

"Metalhead": The Guard Dog at the End of the World

"Metalhead", the corpus's only episode in black and white, opens in a ruined landscape. Bella and two companions break into a warehouse to retrieve an object for someone who is dying. A quadrupedal security robot kills her companions and pursues her across open country with mechanical patience. She disables it, but not before it has embedded trackers in her body; more machines are coming; she prepares to take her own life rather than be taken. The final shot reveals what the box for which three people died contained: teddy bears.

The episode offers no origin for the machines, no history of the collapse, no human villain on screen, and so appears to be the one exception to the catoptric law — technology not as mirror but as pure predator. It is in fact the law reduced to its skeleton. The robot is a guard dog, and it guards a warehouse. The drive it returns is the drive to protect property, and the episode shows that drive multiplied to infinite duration: the security of goods persisting after the society that owned them has gone. Ray Bradbury's "There Will Come Soft Rains" (1950), in which an automated house continues its domestic routine after a nuclear war has burned its family into the wall, is the precise comparator. In "Metalhead" the routine is enforcement. The guard dogs keep guarding.

The monochrome image has the look of a surveillance feed, and the landscape is Hobbes's state of nature (*Leviathan*, ch. 13), with the war of all against all now waged between the human being and the instrument. The mythic dogs are many — Cerberus at the gate of Hades, Garmr howling before Ragnarök — but the episode's revelation is in its box. The expedition was an act of charity in the strict sense: the gift, at the end of the world, of a useless object to a dying child. D. W. Winnicott called the child's comfort object a *transitional object*, the first possession through which absence becomes bearable (Winnicott 1953). The third theological virtue, degraded to a judge's condescension in "Fifteen Million Merits", reappears in "Metalhead" unperformed, unrecorded, unscored — and fatal. Its object's uselessness is the point. The object is also a citation: a teddy bear, the toy whose image named the punishment park of "White Bear" after a murdered child, returns here as a gift carried to a dying one — unscored, unseen, and paid for with lives. Grace is the unproductive gift.

7.5

The Interactive Wager

Pascal's wager turns on a sentence that applies with uncanny force to interactive cinema: one must wager; it is not optional; one is embarked (*Pensées*). *Bandersnatch* enforces the same condition. If the viewer declines to choose before the timer expires, the film chooses a default; abstention is itself a choice, and it too is logged. The interactive viewer is embarked.

The four works examined here show four modes in which agency is authored from outside: by a viewer (*Bandersnatch*), by a machine that renders perception ("Playtest"), by a state that filters it ("Men Against Fire"), and by a purpose that has outlived its authors ("Metalhead"). Isaiah Berlin distinguished negative liberty, the absence of interference, from positive liberty, the condition of self-mastery (Berlin 1958). The interactive film shows both hollowed out by the interface. The viewer enjoys negative liberty — two options, freely selected — without positive liberty, having authored neither the menu nor the timer. Richard Thaler and Cass Sunstein named the design of such menus *choice architecture* and argued for its benign use (Thaler and Sunstein 2008); *Bandersnatch* makes choice architecture visible as power.

The chapter's conclusion may be stated as a maxim: *the menu is the master*. Whoever sets the options governs the chooser. The corpus's counter-move is to locate freedom outside the menu altogether — in the capacity to see the other as a face (Stripe's malfunction), to refuse (Martha on the clifftop, Nanette's *non serviam*), and to give without return (Bella's box of toys). None of these is an option the interface presents. All of them become possible only in the moments the interface does not reach.

PART THREE

III

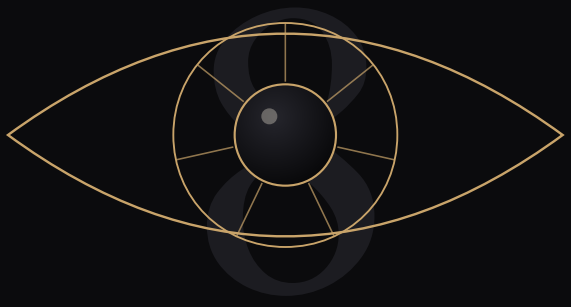
Synthesis

THE ANATOMIES DRAWN INTO A SINGLE ARGUMENT

8 Catoptric Eschatology

9 Lethean Grace

CHAPTER EIGHT



Catoptric Eschatology

The Four Last Things after the Screen



FIG. 11 · THE EYE AT THE CENTRE OF THE TABLE

After the tabletop attributed to Bosch: seven everyday sins in the iris, the four last things at the corners, the screen in the pupil. §8.3.

Black Mirror reconstructs, from the materials of platform capitalism, the complete medieval eschatology — death, judgement, heaven and hell, with purgatory, limbo, resurrection and apocalypse — and this chapter argues that the reconstruction is ordered by a set of convergences upon Paul's First Letter to the Corinthians, and that its theology is Benjamin's capitalism as religion, finally supplied with the eschatology Benjamin's fragment lacked.

8.1

The Quattuor Novissima

Late-medieval devotion organised meditation on the end around four "last things" — *mors*, *iudicium*, *infernus*, *paradisus* — a scheme that runs from the fifteenth-century treatise of Dionysius the Carthusian on the four last things to Thomas More's unfinished *The Four Last Things* (c. 1522). Its most celebrated visual form is the *Table of the Seven Deadly Sins and the Four Last Things* attributed to Hieronymus Bosch, examined in section 8.3. The corpus supplies every term of the scheme, together with the intermediate states that later doctrine and imagination added.

LAST THING	THEOLOGICAL FIGURE	TECHNOLOGICAL FORM IN THE CORPUS	PRINCIPAL EPISODES
Death	The end of the natural body	Death postponed, subscribed, reversed or made optional	"Be Right Back"; "San Junipero"; "Common People"; "Eulogy"
Judgement	The opened books; works weighed	The score, the hashtag, the recaller, the Justice Park	"Nosedive"; "Hated in the Nation"; "Crocodile"; "White Bear"; "Shut Up and Dance"
Purgatory	Suffering ordered to purification	Simulated suffering ordered to optimisation	"Hang the DJ"; "White Bear" (purgation without purification)
Limbo	Suspension without bliss or torment	The attic replica; the comatose star; the boxed mind	"Be Right Back"; "Rachel, Jack and Ashley Too"; "Black Museum"
Heaven	The communion of saints; the beatific vision	The upload; the server; the love that survives a reset	"San Junipero"; "Hang the DJ"; "Hotel Reverie"
Hell	Eternal punishment	The copied mind tortured in dilated time; the souvenir	"White Christmas"; "Black Museum"; "USS Callister"
Resurrection	The spiritual body raised	The replica, the clone, the reconstructed star	"Be Right Back"; "Beyond the Sea"; "USS Callister"; "Hotel Reverie"
Apocalypse	Unveiling and end	Machine predation, demonic deadline, collective mind, unmade reality	"Metalhead"; "Demon 79"; "Plaything"; "Bête Noire"

Four observations follow. First, the scheme is complete: no eschatological category is absent from the corpus. Second, every category is administered by a corporation or a crowd, and none by a God; the books are opened by platforms and the sentence is passed by users. Third, the distribution is asymmetrical in a manner that repeats the medieval imagination's own bias. Hells and

judgements vastly outnumber heavens, as the *Inferno* has always been more read than the *Paradiso*: the corpus contains one stable heaven and well over a dozen tribunals. Fourth, the one stable heaven has a landlord. The eschatology is complete, administered, asymmetrical and owned.

8.2

The Corinthian Key

The preceding chapters have noted, one by one, convergences between the corpus and two chapters of Paul's First Letter to the Corinthians. They may now be assembled.

The series' title and governing image correspond to 1 Corinthians 13:12: the dark glass through which we see now, and the face-to-face knowledge that comes at the end. The three judges of "Fifteen Million Merits" — Hope, Charity and Wraith — correspond to 13:13, with faith replaced by its rhyme. The corpus's account of knowledge without love — the grain, the recaller, the score — corresponds to 13:2: though I understand all mysteries and all knowledge, and have not charity, I am nothing. Its account of speech without love — Echo's curse, the advertisement in the mouth, the hashtag — corresponds to 13:1, the sounding brass and the tinkling cymbal. Its copies correspond to 15:44, the natural body that is sown and the spiritual body that is raised; its manipulation of time to 15:51–52, the change that comes in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye; its heaven to 15:26, the destruction of death, the last enemy.

Two further convergences are decisive. The first concerns 13:5. Among the attributes of love, Paul lists one that the King James Version renders "thinketh no evil" and that modern translations render, more literally, as *keeps no record of wrongs*. The Greek, *ou logizetai to kakon*, uses a verb — *logizomai*, to reckon, to count, to impute — drawn from the language of accounts. Love, for Paul, is defined precisely as the refusal to keep a ledger of wrongs. The Pelagian Machine is defined precisely as the keeping of one. No verse in the Western canon states more economically the antithesis that organises the corpus. The second concerns 13:8: knowledge, Paul writes, shall vanish away. In the Pauline economy knowledge is provisional by design, and its passing is not loss but fulfilment. The platform's knowledge is designed never to pass.

The convergence extends from the two chapters to the occasion of the letter. The church at Corinth was riven by status competition. Its members ranked themselves by allegiance to rival teachers (1:12), went to law against one another (6:1–8), and competed for prestige through the display of spiritual gifts, the *charismata* — literally, gifts of grace (chs. 12–14). At the community's sacred meal, the wealthy ate and drank their fill while the poor went hungry (11:21): the Lord's Supper had been stratified into tiers. Paul wrote to a community that had converted grace into status, and his answer — the hymn of chapter 13 — is the love that keeps no accounts. The word *charisma* has since travelled, through Rudolph Sohm's church law (Sohm 1892) into Max Weber's sociology of charismatic authority, and thence into the vocabulary of celebrity and influence: from the unearned gift to the earned following. Paul's Corinth is a proto-"Nosedive", a community in which the gift of grace has become a competition for esteem.

This thesis therefore proposes that *Black Mirror* is, structurally, a Corinthian text. It depicts the Corinthian error — grace converted into status — universalised and automated by technology, and it leaves the Corinthian answer, the charity that keeps no record of wrongs, as its organising absence. The claim is advanced, as the prefatory note insists, under the category of the *intentio operis*. The phrase "through a glass, darkly" is a commonplace of English cultural memory, and nothing in the public record establishes that Brooker or his collaborators built the series upon Paul. Yet the naming of two judges after theological virtues and a third after their spectral parody is difficult to read as accidental, and the convergences meet both of the thesis's evidentiary criteria: they are systematic, recurring across the corpus, and structural, organising its forms rather than ornamenting its surfaces.

The fifteenth chapter itself requires a dialectical refinement. Paul's resurrection body is reached only through death — what is sown is not quickened except it die (15:36) — and is raised *transformed* (15:51). The corpus's copies skip both conditions. Greta's cookie is copied from a living woman; Daly's clones are made from living colleagues; nothing dies, and nothing is changed. The cookie is therefore not the spiritual body but its counterfeit: resurrection without death, and so without transformation — the natural body copied into a new prison and named eternal life.

8.3

The Eye at the Centre of the Table

The *Table of the Seven Deadly Sins and the Four Last Things*, attributed to Bosch and now in the Museo del Prado, was painted to be viewed from above, as a tabletop. At its centre is a great circular eye. In its pupil, Christ rises from the tomb displaying his wounds; around the pupil runs the inscription *Cave cave Dominus videt* — "Beware, beware, the Lord sees"; and the iris is divided into seven scenes in which ordinary people commit the seven deadly sins in the course of daily life. Four roundels in the corners depict the four last things. Banners above and below quote the Song of Moses, lamenting a nation void of counsel and wishing that they would consider their latter end (Deut. 32:28–29). In the scene of pride, a woman admires herself in a mirror held up by a demon.

Black Mirror is Bosch's table rebuilt. Its central eye is the screen. Its sins are committed not by princes but by ordinary users in daily life: pride in "USS Callister"; envy in "Beyond the Sea"; wrath in "Hated in the Nation"; sloth — the old *acedia*, a despairing torpor of the spirit — on the treadwheels of "Fifteen Million Merits"; avarice in "Common People" and "Black Museum"; gluttony of the eye, Augustine's *concupiscentia oculorum* (*Confessions* X.35), in "Smithereens"; lust in "Striking Vipers". Its corners are the episodes' destinies. And Bosch's scene of pride is the first image of "Nosedive": a woman rehearsing her smile before a mirror for an audience that, in the corpus, has replaced the demon.

But the eye has changed. Bosch's eye is God's, and its pupil holds the Man of Sorrows: the one who sees is the one who has suffered, and the judge bears the wounds of the judged. Cusa's for-

mula — God's seeing is God's loving — is painted at the table's centre. The platform's eye sees without having suffered and judges without having loved. It is the inscription without the pupil: *cave, cave, videris* — beware, beware, you are seen.

8.4

Capitalism as Religion, Completed

Benjamin's fragment attributed four features to the capitalist cult (Benjamin 1921), and the corpus supplies a technological form for each.

The cult is *purely cultic*, without dogma. The platform has no doctrine. It has practices — scrolling, rating, subscribing, sharing — which constitute a liturgy without a creed.

The cult is of *permanent duration*, knowing no weekday and no day that is not a feast. In the corpus the screens are never off. The advertisements of "Fifteen Million Merits" cannot be closed; those of "Common People" speak through a sleeping wife. Abraham Joshua Heschel described the Sabbath as a palace in time, a sanctuary built not in space but in a day withheld from production and acquisition (Heschel 1951). The worlds of *Black Mirror* have no Sabbath. Augustine's palace of memory has been exteriorised into a database, and Heschel's palace in time has been demolished.

The cult *creates guilt rather than atonement*. The corpus's debts are never remitted: not the subscription, not the score, not the record. The Levitical law of jubilee (Lev. 25) prescribed, every fiftieth year, the release of debts and the return of alienated land; David Graeber's anthropology of debt documented the clean-slate proclamations of Mesopotamian kings and observed that the Sumerian *amargi*, which he identified as the earliest recorded word for freedom, literally meant "return to the mother" (Graeber 2011). The corpus contains no jubilee. Its only return to the mother is Stefan's, through the mirror, into death.

The cult's God is *not dead but absorbed* into human fate. The platform's god is hidden in its infrastructure — the server, the model, the ranking — a *deus absconditus* in the sense of Isaiah's God that hides himself (Isa. 45:15); and its founders, like Billy Bauer, are *dei otiosi*, withdrawn from what they made.

Benjamin's fragment lacked an eschatology. It described a cult driving towards the universalisation of despair, but it did not say what the cult's last things would be. *Black Mirror* supplies them: a heaven by subscription, hells without justice, judgements without mercy, resurrections without transformation, and a last judgement that never ends. The corpus is capitalism as religion with its eschatology finally installed.

8.5

The Terminal Black Frame

The fourth proposition of this thesis held that the anthology's twist transfers tragic recognition to its spectator, and that each episode ends by converting the screen-as-window back into the screen-as-mirror. The proposition can now receive its eschatological reading.

Consider the endings. "The National Anthem" closes on a news report of the Prime Minister's improved ratings beside a marriage that has died. "Fifteen Million Merits" closes on Bing gazing at a forest that may be a screen. "The Entire History of You" closes in darkness after an act of self-blinding. "White Bear" closes on the reset; "White Christmas" on a copied mind and a looping song; "San Junipero" on a hall of servers; "Smithereens" on a world glancing at its phones; "Loch Henry" on an awards ceremony; "Plaything" on a species collapsing into a signal. Again and again the corpus ends on a screen or an audience, and then it cuts to black.

Paul's eschatological promise was knowledge face to face. The corpus's technologies offer that knowledge and deliver it as catastrophe. Yet the series achieves a face-to-face of another kind, at exactly the moment its own image ends. When the episode cuts to black, the switched-off screen becomes, for an instant, the black mirror of the title, and the viewer sees a face in it: his own. The only face-to-face *Black Mirror* can offer is the viewer's encounter with himself in the dark glass — and that encounter is the anagnorisis the twist has transferred. The black frame is the series' eschaton.

This reading answers the inoculation objection raised in Chapter 2. Institutional recuperation can absorb any content, but it cannot absorb the off-state, because the off-state is the moment at which the product has ceased. The streaming interface knows this: its autoplay countdown, which begins before the credits have finished, is a technology for abolishing the black frame — the Pelagian Machine's abolition of the Sabbath, applied to the interval between episodes. The series' form and its distributor's interface stand in direct contradiction. The viewer who lets the screen go dark performs the series' ethic; the viewer who lets the next episode begin performs the object of its critique. The title sequence completes the arc. Episode after episode opens on a screen that cracks and closes on a screen that goes black. The movement of the whole corpus is from crack to dark.

8.6

Enframing and the Saving Power

The abstract named Heidegger among this thesis's interlocutors, and his analysis belongs here. In "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954), Heidegger argued that the essence of modern technology is nothing technological but a mode of revealing he called *Gestell*, enframing: a challenging-forth that orders everything to stand by, on call for further ordering, as *Bestand*, standing-reserve. The river becomes a supplier of hydroelectric power, the forest a stock of cellulose; and the human being, who believes himself lord of the earth, is in danger of becoming standing-reserve himself. The corpus is a gallery of human standing-reserve. The cyclists of "Fifteen Million

Merits" are literally energy on call. Greta's cookie is a person held in readiness to make toast. Amanda's mind in "Common People" is kept on standby by a subscription tier, asleep for most of the day; Ashley O's comatose brain is mined for songs; the simulated lovers of "Hang the DJ" are data held in reserve for a match. Enframing is the metaphysics of the Pelagian Machine: what it orders, it scores, and what it scores, it keeps on call.

Two terms from Heidegger's analysis of everyday existence in *Being and Time* (1927) complete the picture. *Das Man*, the anonymous "they" whose averageness prescribes what one does, says and feels (§27), is the society of "Nosedive", where every gesture is pre-interpreted by an aggregate that is everyone and no one. *Being-towards-death*, the appropriation of one's own finitude as one's ownmost possibility (§§46–53), is the stance of Kelly's husband in "San Junipero", who refuses an eternity his daughter could not share. Where the platform offers to abolish death, Heidegger's analysis holds that it would abolish the horizon within which a life can be one's own.

Heidegger did not end in despair. He quoted Hölderlin's hymn "Patmos" — *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*, "Yet where danger is, the saving power also grows" — and argued that the extreme danger of enframing might itself bring another relation to technology into view, to be sought in a questioning that holds technology's essence open rather than mastering it. This thesis places the saving power precisely. It lies neither in a counter-technology nor in abstention, but in the interval the corpus keeps returning to: the moment when the device is ordering nothing, when no one is on call, and the darkened screen shows a face. The danger is a mirror that never goes black. The saving power grows in its off-state.

The use of Heidegger requires an acknowledgement that a thesis about naming harm cannot omit. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party in 1933 and remained a member until 1945, and his posthumously published notebooks contain antisemitic passages. In a lecture of 1949 he notoriously placed the motorised food industry and the manufacture of corpses in the gas chambers and extermination camps within the same essence of enframing — an equation in which the analysis of technology erased the faces of the murdered. Emmanuel Levinas, who had studied with Heidegger and whose parents and brothers were murdered in Lithuania during the Holocaust, made the primacy of the face over every such ontology the centre of his ethics. The principle of the face in Chapter 9 is meant to hold exactly where Heidegger's analysis failed. This thesis uses his account of technology while refusing both his politics and the moral levelling that his own example shows the account can license.

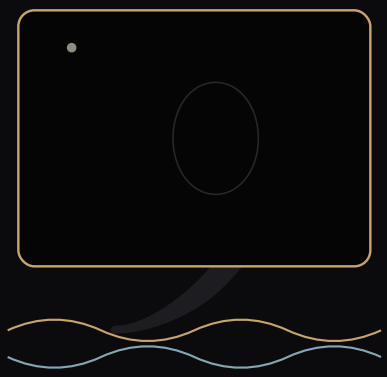
8.7

Anamorphic Eschatology

Viewed head-on, *Black Mirror* is a set of near-future fables about devices. Viewed from the oblique angle that the convergences assembled in this thesis provide, it is a systematic eschatology — a complete account of the last things, rendered without God. The resulting universe can be described with some exactness: judgement without mercy, heaven with a landlord, hell without justice, resurrection without transformation, and death converted from an ending into a tier. The

death's head resolves only from the side. The theology it discloses is negative: it shows what the last things become when grace is subtracted from them. The final chapter asks what the subtracted term would look like if it were restored.

CHAPTER NINE



Lethean Grace

The Ethics of the Off-State (Conclusion)

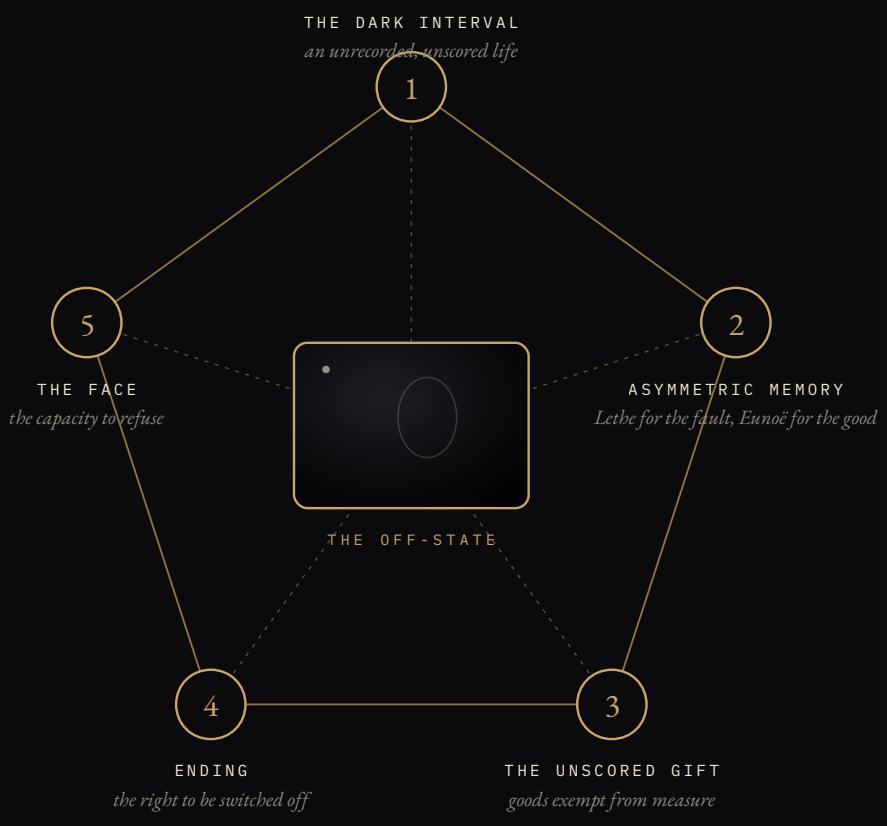


FIG. 12 · LETHEAN GRACE

Five principles of the off-state, arranged around the darkened screen. §9.2.



FIG. 13 · FROM CRACK TO DARK

Episode after episode opens on a cracking screen and closes on a black one. §8.5, §9.6.

The thesis concludes by deriving, from the corpus's rare redemptive moments, a normative position — *Lethean grace* — whose five principles specify what an ethics of the off-state would require of persons, institutions and technologies; it then answers six objections, states the study's limits, and identifies directions for further research.

9.1

The Grammar of the Rare Light

The corpus's moments of grace are few, and they have been noted as they arose. Bing gives away fifteen million merits. Susan stops for a stranger on the road. Two prisoners trade insults with joy. Liam cuts the grain from his skull. Martha, on the clifftop, refuses to accept an echo as a man. Kelly marries Yorkie so that she may pass over. Frank and Amy agree not to look at the counter, and later climb the wall. Nanette's crew refuse to serve, and Walton burns himself in the engines so that they may escape. Ashley sings her own song. Chris, holding a hostage and with nothing left to bargain for, spends his one concession from the platform's founder on a stranger's grief: the password a bereaved mother has been begging for. Bella dies for a box of toys. Phillip, in the archive, lets a grievance go. Two women in a black-and-white film love beyond the script, and the love survives the reset in the one of them who was not reset.

Read together, these moments share a grammar with five features. They are *gratuitous*: unearned, unpaid, expecting no return. They are *forgetful*: they involve the release of a ledger — a grievance, a debt, a record, or, in the case of Frank and Amy, a deliberately unread count. They are *finite*: they accept an ending, or are performed in its face. They are *refusals*: they decline what the system offers or demands. And they are, almost without exception, *unwatched*: they occur in a cab, a cell, on a clifftop, in an attic, in a hospital room, on a moor — in spaces the system's eye does not reach. Where grace is watched, it is captured, as Bing's gift was captured on a stage. The fifth feature is the condition of the other four.

The lovers of "Hang the DJ" deserve particular emphasis. Their love begins when they agree not to check their expiry date: a chosen ignorance, a dark glass voluntarily preferred to face-to-face knowledge. In the corpus's only explicit image of love as a decision, the lovers choose not to know. Paul's dark glass, which every platform in the corpus labours to abolish, is the medium in which their love becomes possible.

9.2

Lethean Grace Defined

Lethean grace names an ethics, and a corresponding philosophy of institutions and design, that treats forgetting, forgiveness and ending as positive goods, and that therefore protects the conditions under which unearned and unrecorded acts can occur. Its model is the double river at the summit of Dante's Purgatory: Lethe, which removes the memory of sin once it has been con-

fessed, and Eunoë, which restores the memory of every good (*Purgatorio* XXVIII.127–132; XXXI; XXXIII). Its scriptural sources are the petition of the Lord's Prayer which, in Matthew's version, asks for the forgiveness of *debts* (Matt. 6:12), and Paul's definition of love as the refusal to keep a record of wrongs (1 Cor. 13:5). Its philosophical sources are Nietzsche's active forgetting; Arendt's account of forgiveness as the only remedy for the irreversibility of action, the faculty by which human beings are released from the consequences of what they have done so that they may begin again (Arendt 1958, §33); Ricoeur's "difficult forgiveness" (Ricoeur 2000); and Harald Weinrich's cultural history of the art and critique of forgetting (Weinrich 1997). Its five principles correspond to the five features of the rare light.

1. **The principle of the dark interval.** Every system of visibility owes its subjects intervals of unrecorded, unscored life; the off-state is a right, not a malfunction. Heschel's Sabbath is its religious form. Arendt's defence of the private realm — of what needs to be hidden from the glare of publicity in order to grow, without which a life lived wholly in public becomes shallow (Arendt 1958) — is its political form. Grace, the corpus shows, occurs where no one is scoring; the first duty of a humane order is to ensure that such places exist.

2. **The principle of asymmetric memory.** Systems of record should release faults once they have been acknowledged and retain goods so that they cannot be lost: Lethe for the fault, Eunoë for the good. Existing law already contains institutional Lethes — the spending of convictions under statutes such as the United Kingdom's Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974, the sealing of juvenile records, time limits on adverse entries in credit reports, the right to erasure — and Mayer-Schönberger proposed expiry dates for personal information (Mayer-Schönberger 2009). Lethean grace generalises these exceptions into a design default. The machines of the corpus do the opposite: they retain every fault and record no gift.

3. **The principle of the unscored gift.** Some goods must be structurally exempt from measurement — love, mourning, care, worship, play — because measurement converts them into merit, and merit into status. Michael Walzer argued that justice requires the autonomy of distinct spheres of goods, and named as *tyranny* the conversion of dominance in one sphere into dominance in others (Walzer 1983); "Nosedive" depicts the tyranny of a single score over every sphere. Marcel Mauss's account of the gift's sociality (Mauss 1925) and Derrida's account of the gift as the impossible (Derrida 1991) mark the limit that measurement must not cross.

4. **The principle of ending.** Any technology that promises the indefinite continuation of a person — the replica, the copy, the subscription to life — owes that person an ending: the right to be switched off, the right not to be run, the right to pass. Kelly's husband, who refused heaven, and Williams's Elina Makropulos, who chose death at 342, are its witnesses; Swift's Struldbruggs are its warning; Metzinger's proposed moratorium on synthetic suffering extends it to minds we may make. Statutes of limitation are its legal analogue for grievances: the ancient recognition that some accounts must close.

5. **The principle of the face.** Any interface that mediates persons must preserve the other's capacity to appear as a face — to resist, to refuse, to say no — and the user's capacity to refuse in turn: the exit, the opt-out, the cancellation that costs nothing. The replica that cannot refuse and the soldier who cannot see a face are the corpus's negative images of this principle; Nanette's *non serviam* is its positive image. Ivan Illich's distinction between convivial tools, which enlarge the autonomy of their users, and manipulative tools, which program them (Illich 1973), supplies its criterion: a convivial tool is one that can be put down.

Two fictions supply the principle of ending with its charters. William Gibson's Dixie Flatline, the recorded personality of a dead hacker who asks to be erased once his work is done (*Neuromancer*, 1984), and the Copies of Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994), whose ability to "bail out" — to end their own runs — the novel treats as the minimum condition of their dignity, and whose removal it presents as a violation, show that the right to end was imagined as a right of copied minds long before any copy existed.

Lethean grace must be distinguished from four counterfeits that the corpus also depicts. It is not *dementia*, the forgetting of the good, which is the terror of "Playtest": Lethe without Eunoë. It is not *imposed oblivion*, the forgetting administered by power to prevent acknowledgement, which is the instrument of "White Bear" and "Men Against Fire": Lethe without confession. It is not *Luddism*, the violent refusal of the replica-hating cult of "Beyond the Sea": refusal without grace. And it is not merely *privacy*. Privacy protects the individual from exposure; Lethean grace protects the possibility of the gift and of beginning again — what Arendt called natality, the capacity for new action that forgiveness alone makes possible.

9.3

Objections and Replies

First objection: over-reading. The theological apparatus, it may be said, is imposed upon a secular entertainment. Reply: the thesis claims convergence, not intention, and admits a convergence only when it is systematic and structural. The theological vocabulary, moreover, is not imported but native to the corpus, which contains a heaven by name, a demon, a hell of copies, resurrected bodies, "merits", judges called Hope and Charity, a Justice Park and a Black Museum. Any account of the series must explain these recurrences; the eschatological reading is offered as the most economical explanation of them.

Second objection: technophobia in disguise. Reply: the catoptric law denies technological agency at the outset, and Lethean grace is a philosophy of design, not of abstention. The corpus itself rebukes the technophobe: the first murderers of "Beyond the Sea" are the cult that hates replicas.

Third objection: capitalist realism. A dystopian anthology may, following Fisher, train its audience in anticipatory resignation. Reply: the corpus's rare graces are precisely the alternatives the objection says it lacks, and the black frame is not content but a practice — a moment in which the viewer may perform the off-state rather than merely contemplate it. Jonas's heuristics of fear dis-

covers goods by imagining their loss; the goods the corpus discovers are named in the five principles above.

Fourth objection: recuperation. The series is a flagship product of the attention economy it criticises, and its critique is Barthes's inoculation. Reply: the objection is partly conceded. The immanent critic's complicity is real, and the series is, among other things, an inoculation. The thesis's claim is narrower: the series' form exceeds its institution without escaping it. The off-state cannot be sold, because it is the absence of the product, and the contradiction between the closing black frame and the distributor's autoplay countdown is the visible trace of that excess.

Fifth objection: Christian particularism. Why should a Pauline frame govern a global series? Reply: the Pauline formulation is one articulation of a structure found across human moral cultures. The Greek river of forgetting precedes Paul. The Levitical jubilee and the Mesopotamian clean slate institutionalised the cancellation of debt. The Jewish High Holy Days imagine books of life that are opened and then sealed — a ledger with a closing. Islamic theology names God *al-ʿAfuww*, a name that al-Ghazālī, in his commentary on the divine names, distinguished from forgiveness as concealment by its sense of effacement: the erasure of the sin itself. And the Mexica obsidian mirror with which this thesis began shows that the black mirror is not a European topos. Lethean grace names a recurrent human institution — the designed erasure of debt and fault — which platform modernity is unusual in having abandoned.

Sixth objection: moral hazard. Forgetting serves the powerful; accountability requires memory; victims require that wrongs be remembered. Reply: this is the most serious objection, and the principle of asymmetric memory is designed to answer it. Lethean grace forgets the fault only after acknowledgement, as Dante's Lethe follows confession. It does not forget the unacknowledged wrong, and it does not forget victims, whose dignity belongs to the order of Eunoë, the memory of the good. Ricoeur's distinction between the duty of memory and difficult forgiveness is preserved. The corpus itself illustrates the point. The Justice Park of "White Bear" remembers the crime forever while forgetting its victim, a murdered child nowhere honoured in the festival of her murderer's suffering. Lethean grace reverses that asymmetry: it would remember the child and, in time, release the ledger.

9.4

Limits of the Study

The study's limits should be stated plainly. Its corpus closes in April 2025, and an eighth series is in production. Its claims about spectatorship are formal rather than empirical: transferred anagnorisis and the reflexive black frame are properties of the works' structure, not demonstrated features of audience experience. Its readings of classical, scriptural and non-English sources rely on translations and canonical locators rather than on philological work in the original languages. Its Pauline key, though defended above, carries a risk of confessional and anglophone bias that comparative work should test. It treats "Brooker" as an author function and does not draw on pro-

duction archives. And it is subject to its own diagnosis: a thesis about an immanent critique is itself an immanent critique, produced within the culture it analyses.

9.5

Directions for Further Research

Five lines of inquiry follow. The first is empirical: reception studies, interviews or experimental designs could test whether viewers experience the closing black frame reflexively, and how autoplay alters that experience. The second is comparative: the anthology tradition beyond the anglophone world — the long-running Japanese series *Tales of the Unusual* (*Yo nimo Kimyō na Monogatari*), for instance — and contemporaneous platform fictions such as *Severance*, *Upload* and *Devs* could be read through the Corinthian key, to test whether catoptric eschatology is specific to Brooker or general to the period. The third is institutional: the five principles of Lethean grace could be operationalised as criteria for data governance, reputation systems, digital-afterlife services and the sunset of digital likenesses. The fourth is philosophical: the corpus's moral arithmetic of simulated minds bears directly on emerging debates about the moral status of artificial systems (Schwitzgebel and Garza 2015; Metzinger 2021; Birch 2024; Long et al. 2024), in which computational Omelas names a risk rather than a fiction. The fifth is theological: the relation between Benjamin's guilt-cult and the Pauline economy of grace deserves a systematic treatment of which this thesis offers only a sketch.

9.6

Coda: The Screen Goes Dark

Episode after episode, the series opens on a screen that cracks. The crack is the irruption of what the glossy surface excluded — the real, the wound, the shard that Bing held to his own throat. And episode after episode, it closes on a screen that goes dark. Between the crack and the dark it shows what becomes of a civilisation that has built a mirror that cannot go black: memory without mercy, judgement without end, heaven with a landlord, and copies of human beings condemned to an eternity they did not choose.

Paul promised that the dark glass would one day give way to knowledge face to face. *Black Mirror* imagines that promise fulfilled by machines, and shows it as catastrophe. Its own fulfilment is humbler and stranger. When the image ends and the glass goes dark, a face appears in it — not the face of God, nor of the beloved, but the viewer's own: darkened, attentive, briefly unrecorded. It is the only face-to-face the series can offer. In the interval before the next image begins, nothing is scored, nothing is kept, and nothing is owed. The interval is small. The thesis of *Black Mirror* is that everything human depends on it.

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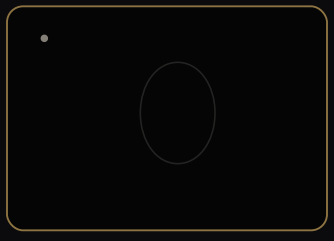
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BACK MATTER

Keywords

Black Mirror · Charlie Brooker · anthology television · speculative fiction · television studies · media archaeology · topos studies · catoptrics · obsidian speculum · catoptric law · black mirror topos · Tezcatlipoca · John Dee · Claude glass · Nicholas of Cusa · *De visione Dei* · Narcissus and Echo · Echo's curse · mirror stage · Alberti's window · Leibnizian monadology · anamorphosis · Holbein's *Ambassadors* · esperpento · Valle-Inclán · McLuhan's tetrad · secular eschatology · catoptric eschatology · the Four Last Things (*quattuor novissima*) · artificial eternity · political theology · capitalism as religion · Walter Benjamin · Pelagianism · grace · *sola gratia* · treasury of merit · theological virtues · Wraith virtues · Corinthian key · 1 Corinthians 13 and 15 · *sōma pneumatikon* · resurrection · Gnosticism · the Demiurge · theodicy · Leibniz's palace of the Fates · computational Omelas · mind crime · simulation ethics · digital afterlife · mind uploading · personal identity · Relation R · Parfit · Bernard Williams · tedium of immortality · experience machine · recognition (*Anerkennung*) · Honneth · amour-propre · praise and praiseworthiness · societies of control · dividual · surveillance capitalism · platform capitalism · technofeudalism · enshittification · attention economy · spectacle · recuperation · precorporation · inoculation · capitalist realism · immanent critique · culture industry · scapegoat mechanism · mimetic desire · René Girard · Counter-Oresteia · Erinyes and Eumenides · baiting crowd · digital swarm · banality of evil · Promethean gap · Promethean shame · Günther Anders · heuristics of fear · Hans Jonas · Collingridge dilemma · spectacle of the scaffold · panopticism · *homo sacer* · bare life · grievability · the face · Levinas · adiaphorisation · empty signifier · populism · gaslighting · post-truth · forgetting · active forgetting · Lethe and Eunoë · Lethean grace · forgiveness · natality · right to be forgotten · asymmetric memory · tertiary retention · *pharmakon* · Stiegler · archive fever · hauntology · mourning and melancholia · *fort/da* · the crypt · uncanny · photography and death · mummy complex · transferred anagnorisis · twist ending · metalepsis · ergodic narrative · interactive cinema · *Bandersnatch* · Frankfurt cases · free will · choice architecture · phantomatics · *de casibus* tragedy · *A Mirror for Magistrates* · *A Mirror for Users* · Sabbath · jubilee · debt · gift · convivial tools · *The Twilight Zone* · Nigel Kneale · Jonathan Swift · E. M. Forster · Philip K. Dick · J. G. Ballard · Stanisław Lem · Jorge Luis Borges · Ursula K. Le Guin · Harlan Ellison · Ted Chiang · Kazuo Ishiguro · posthumanism · AI welfare · moral status of artificial minds · Heidegger · enframing (Gestell) · standing-reserve (Bestand) · das Man · being-towards-

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